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HYDERABAD'S SKYROOT START-UP

Vikram-1 India's first private orbital rocket mission; defining moment, says PM

Tech payloads; India third country, after US & China, to have launch capability in pvt sector



Space startup Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 rocket lifts off from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota, Saturday. PTI

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 18

USHERING IN a new era of India's space programme, Vikram-1, a rocket named after the legendary space leader Vikram Sarabhai, on Saturday became the country's first privately-built launch vehicle to achieve an orbit around the Earth, and successfully deploy a diverse

set of technology demonstration satellites in space.

Built by the Hyderabad-based company Skyroot Aerospace, Vikram-1 marks the beginning of private space flights in India, a development that has been actively enabled and supported by the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and the government. With this

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THE WORLD

PAGE 14



TWO U.S. MILITARY PERSONNEL IN JORDAN KILLED IN IRAN ATTACK

UKRAINE ATTACK KILLS 8 IN RUSSIA

Happening today

● **THE GOVERNMENT WILL** convene an all-party meeting ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament starting Monday.

● **PANAMA'S FOREIGN** Minister will arrive on a five-day visit, during which he will meet Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar.

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● **ARGENTINA AND SPAIN VIE FOR WORLD FOOTBALL CROWN AT METLIFE STADIUM**

Night before final, every line in New York cuts across divides, leads to No. 10 Messi

Sandip G
New York, July 18

IN THE basement of Javits Hall, supporters of Argentina and Spain fidgeted in the sinuous queue to the Fanatics Festival in the heart of New York, two days before the final in MetLife Stadium. The gruff security

guard, stifling his yawn, quizzically verified the loyalties of every new entrant, "Spain in the line over there and Argentina down here. No fights, no punches please. I know you guys are sweet."

Both groups of fans were separated by barricades nearly 50 m ahead but he had read about the skirmishes between England and Argentina fans in Times Square on Thursday.

The two lines, as if in a procession outside a temple, are unified in their singular wish.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

HE IS STABLE... DECLINED MEDICAL INTERVENTION: SAFDARJUNG HOSPITAL

Hunger strike Day 21: Police shift Wangchuk to hospital

Acted on HC order, expert's advice due to his deteriorating health: Delhi Police

Sakshi Chand, Mahender Singh Manral, Pragynesh & Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 18

SOON AFTER dawn on Saturday morning, police swooped on Sonam Wangchuk's protest at Jantar Mantar, breaking up the hunger strike that had entered its 21st day and begun to gain visible political traction this week.

The action came the day after a new Commissioner took charge of the Delhi Police and two days before the Monsoon Session beginning on Monday, when Wangchuk and the activist platform Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) had planned a march to Parliament.

Wangchuk had been on a hunger strike since June 28, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the alleged NEET-UG paper leak.

Dipke later announced that he would begin an indefinite hunger strike. "They thought the *andolan* (movement) would lose steam without Sonam sir. Now, instead of him, I will sit on an indefinite hunger strike," he said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Activist Sonam Wangchuk being removed from the protest site at Jantar Mantar, Saturday. PTI

INSIDE

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DIPKE TAKES CHARGE: 'NOW, I WILL SIT ON INDEFINITE FAST'

WANGCHUK'S WIFE: WANT HIM AT MEDICAL CENTRE OF OUR CHOICE

72nd NATIONAL FILM AWARDS

NATION, PAGE 12

BEST FEATURE FILM
ARTICLE 370



BEST ACTRESS
YAMI GAUTAM, ARTICLE 370



BEST ACTOR



MAMMOOTTY
BRAMAYUGAM

BEST DIRECTOR



RAJKUMAR PERIASAMY
AMARAN

KARTIK AARYAN,
CHANDU CHAMPION

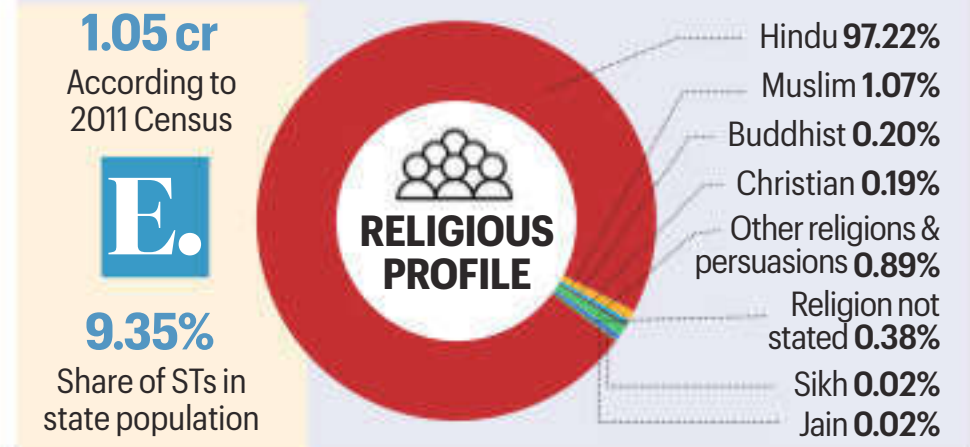
Maharashtra panel to examine if STs who convert can still receive benefits

Zeeshan Shaikh
Mumbai, July 18

THE MAHARASHTRA government has constituted a 27-member committee to examine whether Scheduled Tribe (ST) members who convert to another religion should continue to receive reservation and other government benefits, reopening a politically and constitutionally sensitive issue that

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Maharashtra's ST population



Tennis star Novak Djokovic with Lionel Messi, Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni and goalkeeper Emiliano Martinez in New York, Friday. AP

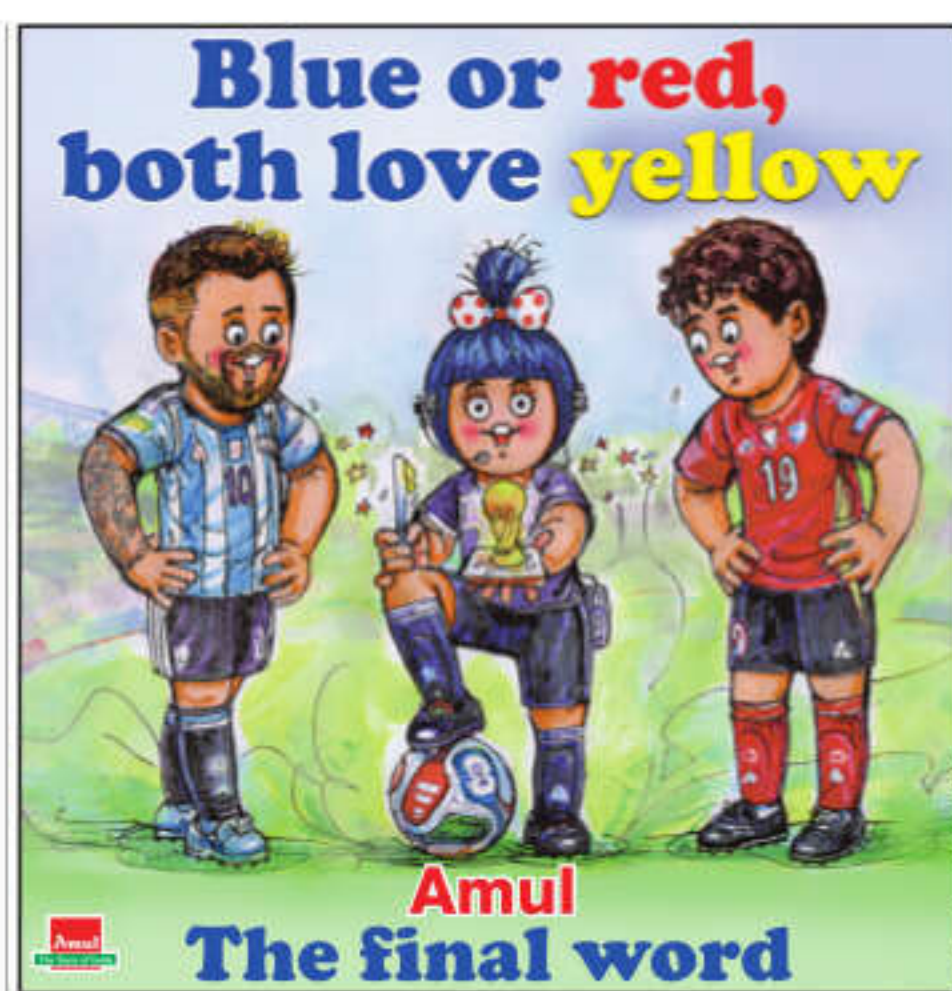
EYE

What the Rain Became

Kerala was raised on the romance of the monsoon. Somewhere along the line, the rains stopped being the backdrop to its life and became a thing to fear

SCREEN

Raghav Juyal on his non-linear journey



MONSOON SESSION BEGINS TOMORROW

Speaker clears merger of 6 Sena UBT MPs with Shinde Sena, separate seating for TMC rebels

Kiren Rijiju invites TMC rebel leader to all-party meet

Liz Mathew, Jatin Anand & Zeeshan Shaikh
New Delhi, Mumbai, July 18

TWO DAYS before the start of Parliament's Monsoon Session, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Saturday approved the merger of six rebel Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs

with the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, raising the latter's strength in the Lower House to 13.

Birla's decision was reflected in a circular issued by the Lok Sabha secretariat on the "revised party position" in the 18th Lok Sabha "consequent upon change in party affiliation of 6 Members of Shiv Sena (UBT)".

The move assumes significance as the BJP has stepped up its efforts to muster a two-thirds majority required to pass the 131st Constitution Amendment

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Sena MPs

Bill to roll out women’s reservation law along with a delimitation legislation.

Birla’s nod makes the Shinde Sena the second-largest constituent of the BJP-led NDA. With 13 Lok Sabha MPs — one more than Nitish Kumar’s Janata Dal (United) and three short of the N Chandrababu Naidu-led TDP’s 16 — Shinde’s party is now the seventh-largest in the Lok Sabha.

The merger of 20 rebel TMC Lok Sabha MPs with a little known outfit Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) has yet to be recognised by the Speaker, with the party position released Saturday stating that the TMC, led by Abhishek Banerjee in the House, has 28 MPs. The Speaker has however allowed the rebel TMC group to have a separate seating from the parent party. Sources said a decision on the TMC rebels is expected on Sunday.

However, on Saturday, Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju invited the TMC’s breakaway faction to the customary meeting of floor leaders of both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha to be held by the government on Sunday.

If Birla allows the merger of 20 rebel TMC MPs with the NCPI, the TMC will lose its position as the fourth largest party in the Lower House and slide to the ninth slot with 8 members, equalling the Sharad Pawar-led NCP (SP).

Rijiju’s invitation to Sudip Bandyopadhyay, the leader of the rebel TMC group, for the Sunday meeting immediately triggered a political row.

“Cheating. Mocking our democracy. Speaker has referred to 20 traitors as still being TMC MPs. Minutes later, Modi-Shah minister invites traitors for all-party meet & refers to them as NCPI,” TMC MP Derek O’Brien said in an X post.

In April, prior to splits and mergers in several parties including the TMC and the Sena (UBT), the BJP had in the Lok Sabha 240 MPs followed by the TDP’s 16, JD(U)’s 12, Shinde Sena’s 7 and the LJP’s 5. Along with smaller allies, the NDA’s tally then stood at 299.

With the rebel TMC MPs

having pledged support to the NDA, the recognition of their merger with the NCPI will increase the NDA’s strength to 319. If the NCP (SP) supports the NDA, its numbers would rise to 327, short of 33 from a two-thirds majority mark of 360, which is required to ensure the passage of a constitutional amendment Bill.

In April, the total strength of the Opposition INDIA bloc and supporting parties was 225 — including the Congress’s 98 MPs, Samajwadi Party 37, TMC 28, DMK 22, Shiv Sena (UBT) 9, NCP (SP) 8, Left 8, RJD 4, three each for IUML, JMM and AAP, and two MPs of the National Conference.

The Opposition alliance is now likely to be down 26, following the splits in the TMC and the Sena (UBT), even as there is uncertainty about the DMK’s position.

In Parliament’s special session in April, the Narendra Modi government’s move to push the Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026, to advance the women quota law along with a Delimitation Bill failed, which saw 528 of 540 Lok Sabha MPs participate, with 298 voting in its favour, 230 against it, and 11 MPs absent. The NDA thus fell short of the two-thirds mark of 352.

Hours after Birla’s move, Ek-nath Shinde, the Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister, said that the MPs of the Uddhav Thackeray-led Sena (UBT) switched to his party to secure development for their constituencies and not for “personal gains”.

Rejecting allegations that the six Sena (UBT) MPs were “lured” with money, Shinde said the Uddhav Sena needed to “introspect” on why its leaders were deserting their party.

“These six MPs have joined us to ensure justice and development for the people who elected them. We will ensure they receive development funds and every possible support,” Shinde said.

“The MPs have not joined us for personal interests but for development. We have already facilitated meetings with Union Home Minister Amit Shah, and our ministers will ensure projects in their constituencies are expedited,” he said.

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Wangchuk

On Wednesday, the Delhi High Court had directed the Centre to ensure that Wangchuk’s health was monitored on a daily basis by government doctors, and to “intervene depending on the medical report”.

Wangchuk was taken to Safdarjung hospital from the protest site and put under medical supervision.

In an official bulletin issued at 9 pm, the hospital said he had declined intravenous fluids, oral rehydration solution and all medications despite repeated counselling.

“Shri Sonam Wangchuk... remains conscious and haemodynamically stable. His pulse, blood pressure and oxygen saturation are currently within normal limits. However, he is exhibiting clinical signs of dehydration, and in view of his prolonged fasting, his condition warrants immediate medical in-

tervention to prevent further deterioration and potentially serious complications.”

It added that the patient’s family has also not yet provided consent for the recommended medical intervention.

According to the statement, “An independent expert from AIIMS, New Delhi, examined the patient and concurred with the treating team’s assessment that immediate oral/intravenous fluid and electrolyte therapy is medically indicated. An AIIMS doctor has also joined the treating team and will remain continuously available for monitoring and clinical management.”

Wangchuk’s wife Gitanjali Angmo said that doctors who had been attending to the activist through the period of his fast had been denied access to him, and demanded that he be allowed to go to a medical facility of his choice.

Soon after Wangchuk was taken to hospital, Delhi Police posted on its official X handle that it had acted “as per orders of

Hon’ble High Court and on expert medical advice due to the deteriorating health condition” of the activist.

Police said protesters had “tried to create obstruction, in which slight commotion ensued”, but police had acted with “maximum restraint”. “We request the protesters at Jantar Mantar to peacefully vacate the place at the earliest,” the statement said.

The operation to take away Wangchuk began around 3 am on Saturday — a little more than 12 hours after Anurag Kumar assumed charge as Delhi Police Commissioner.

Kumar’s predecessor Satish Golchha had been removed by a sudden order issued by the Ministry of Home Affairs earlier in the morning, reportedly for reasons that included his handling of the protest by the CJP.

Sources said on Friday, around 11 pm, a message was sent to all SFOs of the New Delhi district that a security drill before the Monsoon Session would be

held on Saturday morning. They were asked to reach Parliament Street police station by 3 am, with 10 police personnel.

“They were briefed by DCP (New Delhi district) Sachin Sharma. They were informed that they were there to execute a plan to remove Wangchuk from the protest site. They were to wait for Dipke’s movement and remove Wangchuk in 30 seconds... Some of them were asked to wear T-shirts and track pants, posing as medical assistance. They were to park one ambulance near Kerala House in Jantar Mantar,” a source said.

Sources said soon after taking charge, Commissioner Kumar had met with officers of the rank of special commissioner to work out strategy. “The meeting discussed the known daily routine of the protesters, and zeroed in on a window when CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke usually went to a nearby restroom. It was decided to pick up Wangchuk in that window,” a source said.

Opp unites

the examination system and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over repeated examination paper leaks.

This session is crucial. The Opposition has been in disarray, ironically, after they unitedly forced the defeat of the Constitution amendment Bill to increase parliamentary seats in April. Since then, 37 Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs from four anti-BJP parties have defected to the ruling side — making it the largest floor crossing from the Opposition to the Treasury benches in parliament since the enactment of the anti-defection law in 1985. One Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MP, Koel Mallick, resigned earlier this week.

This, even as the DMK has been unclear on its stance on the key bills which it had stridently opposed three months ago. With the government seemingly preparing to bring back the Constitution (131st Amendment Bill) for implementing the Women’s Reservation law and

the Delimitation Bill, the Opposition is hoping the Wangchuk issue could bring all parties on one page.

It is to be seen whether this issue alone has enough fuel to keep the parties together and sustain their campaign against the government, given that Wangchuk is now away from the protest site and is replaced by CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke.

The Congress, for one, has been indifferent to the CJP protest given that Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi has been raising the same set of issues for a while and held two public engagements, in Kota in June and in Dehradun Friday. But with Sonia Gandhi nudging the party to publicly express solidarity with Wangchuk — invoking the fact that Indira Gandhi had in 1984 flown to Leh to persuade Wangchuk’s father, Sonam Wangyal, to end a similar hunger strike — the party changed tact.

AICC general secretary K C Venugopal issued a statement first and Rajya Sabha MP Pawan Khara went to Jantar Mantar and met Wangchuk.

On Saturday, Rahul Gandhi

broke his silence. He had refrained from commenting on the CJP and the Jantar Mantar protest all these weeks. Those close to him were and are of the view that CJP is a front of the AAP. “The core tenets of the Modi government are *Asatya* and *Hinsa*. The removal of Sonam Wangchuk ji from Jantar Mantar while he was on a non-violent hunger strike is wrong. Paper leaks, the rising cost of education, and student suicides are critical issues for India’s future. No amount of force can deter India’s students, and those of us who love and believe in them, from raising these issues,” he said in a post on X with the hashtag “ChhatronKiGoonj” — the campaign he has been spearheading.

Wangchuk, given his image as an apolitical social activist, had drawn a steady stream of Opposition leaders to the protest venue. All of them slammed the government move Saturday. The interesting reaction, however, was of NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar. At a time when there are signals of an invisible BJP hand behind the two NCP factions, Pawar hit out at the gov-

ernment saying it was “irresponsible” in handling Wangchuk’s agitation and accused it of acting like a spectator rather than addressing the genuine demands put forth by students. “The government moved the activist to the hospital as the situation went beyond its control. Despite this, the protest would continue,” he said.

From AAP to Shiv Sena (UBT), TMC, Samajwadi Party and the Left, the other Opposition parties said Wangchuk’s removal from Jantar Mantar was an assault on democracy.

“Such arrogance is not right,” AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal said. “In a democracy, peaceful dissent deserves engagement, not silence,” said TMC chief Mamata Banerjee.

Hitting back at the Opposition, BJP’s national IT Department in-charge, Amit Malviya, said: “The opportunists in the Opposition have suddenly woken up this morning, after a comfortable night’s sleep and a hearty breakfast, to question why Sonam Wangchuk was shifted despite his deteriorating health and the Delhi HC’s directions.”

ST panel

has long been raised by RSS-affiliated organisations and sections of the BJP.

A Government Resolution (GR) issued by the state’s Tribal Development Department on July 16 said the committee, headed by Tribal Development Minister Ashok Uike, will examine the constitutional and legal position governing reservation and welfare benefits for STs after religious conversion, study the approach followed by the Centre and other states, and recommend a policy for Maharashtra.

The GR, however, does not

specify any deadline for the committee to submit its recommendations.

Uike did not respond to phone calls or text messages.

The issue is legally distinct from that of Scheduled Castes (SCs). While SC reservation is linked to religion under the Constitution (Scheduled Castes) Order, 1950, there is no such restriction for STs. Under Article 342 of the Constitution, STs continue to be recognised as STs, irrespective of the religion they profess.

The issue has figured in the Sangh Parivar’s tribal outreach agenda. The demand gathered momentum in May, when a large Sangh-affiliated Adivasi

Messi

To spot the deity, Lionel Messi, who would be on stage for five fleeting minutes.

Each entry to the hall came at \$82, and not all of the 10,000-odd crowd would be granted access to the hall. But they prayed and waited, with anxious yet jubilant eyes.

Some were wrapped in flags of their country, most in shirts of their favourite players. A Spain fan wore a curly wig like Marc Cucurella, the full-back who has a cult following. There were other celebrities, Rodri

and Emi Martinez, Novak Djokovic, Kevin Durant and Tom Brady, in the whistle-stop show. But all that mattered was Messi.

The most ubiquitous name on the shirt was No 10, Messi. Those in the Argentina line wore the blue and white stripes; some in the Spain queue wore Messi’s jerseys, too. The same No 10, but in the red and purple of Barcelona. “We will cheer for both Messi and Spain,” blared Nehemias Coellar. “It’s a cruel choice, I know. Maybe I want to see Messi win, because this would be his last World Cup. Lamine (Yamal) is still young and has time to win more in his life.”

Vikram-1

launch, India has become just the third country, after the US and China, to have launching capabilities in the private sector.

Saturday’s launch mission was named Aagaman, meaning ‘arrival’. The company said it signified the arrival of a new era in India’s space sector, in which “Indian innovation, engineering and enterprise come together to provide reliable access to orbit”.

Skyroot had flown Vikram-S rocket, an earlier version of the Vikram-1, to sub-orbital space in 2022. Another private company, the Chennai-based Agnikul, has also carried out a sub-orbital flight of its Agniban rocket, the world’s first to be powered by a 3-D printed engine, in 2024.

In sub-orbital flights, rockets usually fly without any satellites, enter into space, and then fall off onto the Earth under the impact of gravity. They do not attain an orbit around the Earth, and are largely meant for technology demonstration.

Vikram-1, on the other hand, has now become a full-fledged satellite launch vehicle, having deposited its payloads in the intended low-Earth orbits at an altitude of about 450 km.

“This is a defining moment in India’s space journey,” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a post on X. “The growing participation of our private sector is opening new frontiers and accelerating innovation. This achievement will encourage countless youngsters to dream bigger and innovate fearlessly,” he said.

Soon after the launch from ISRO’s launch facility at Sriharikota, the young co-founders of Skyroot, Pawan Kumar Chandana and Naga Bharath Daka, had a conversation with Modi over phone. Modi, who has held several meetings with young space entrepreneurs in the last few years, had sent a signed postcard with the message “Vande Matram” that was carried on Vikram-1.

Commending the company on its success, Modi said his government’s decision to open up the space sector to private players was seen by many to be risky, and thanked the Skyroot founders for proving him right. “...because of you, my decision has been proven right. Now my

team will also accept that we should trust the youth of the country, we should give them work and they will do it. And, you have done it,” he told them.

The launch survived a few anxious moments in the morning, when the countdown had to be halted just five minutes ahead of the scheduled launch. However, it was resumed soon thereafter, the launch, initially slated for 11:30 am, happened at 12:05 pm. It was a smooth launch, and the rocket was able to deploy the satellites in their orbits in about 20 minutes.

Vikram-1 is a multi-stage rocket, rising up to about seven storeys, and is powered by a propulsion system developed in-house, including 3-D printed engines and high-thrust solid fuel motors. It is designed to carry small satellites, weighing up to 350 kg, to low-Earth orbits.

ISRO Chairman V Narayanan, former chairpersons S Somnath, A S Kiran Kumar, K Radhakrishnan, astronaut Shubhanshu Shukla, and Pawan Goenka, chairman of INSPACE (Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre) were present at the mission control in Bengaluru. In Delhi, Science and Technology Minister Jitendra Singh, who is also the minister in charge of the Department of Space, witnessed the launch live.

“They have always been extremely innovative and creative. It is not an empty payload like many first missions carry. Here we have an experimental payload... If the PM had not opened the space sector, we would not have witnessed this. This marks India’s entry into the highly competitive global space sector. For India, sky is no longer the limit,” Jitendra Singh said.

Lt Gen A K Bhatt (retd.), Director General, Indian Space Association, said: “The successful deployment of such complex, IP-heavy payloads prove our private ecosystem is now building critical global infrastructure for space sustainability and high-resolution Earth intelligence.”

While the name of the rocket pays homage to the father of India’s space programme, Dr Vikram Sarabhai, the solid engines have been named ‘Kalam’ for the rocket man, former President Dr APJ Abdul Kalam, and the liquid engine ‘Raman’ for the physicist, Dr C V Raman.

nity, as per the Constitution framed by Dr B R Ambedkar.”

The question assumes particular significance in Maharashtra, where STs account for 9.35% of the state’s population. According to the 2011 Census, the state’s ST population grew from 85.77 lakh in 2001 to over 1.05 crore. While 97.2% of the STs identified as Hindus, the Census also recorded 1.13 lakh Muslims, over 20,000 Christians and nearly 21,000 Buddhists, besides smaller numbers of Sikhs and Jains. Between 2001 and 2011, the Muslim ST population grew by 49.1%, Buddhist STs by 114.8% and Jains nearly six-fold, while the Christian ST population declined by 34.8%.

cause he plays for a club I love so much. He has a chance to achieve something historic,” he stopped and added in an unusually menacing tone: “We’re going to try to make sure that doesn’t happen this time.”

But viewing the game through a Messi-Yamal prism is myopic vision. It’s a multi-layered contest, spoilt for theme. The escape artists with the touch artistes, the unbreakable versus the unbeatable, expression of individual supremacy pitted against triumph of collectivism, the colonised against the former colonialists, friends against friends, Messi for his country of birth against one that shaped him. And Spain manager Luis de la Fuente in a battle of wits with his former apprentice Lionel Scaloni. Both shared a warm hug during the event, and probably would after the game, irrespective of Sunday’s result.

Both sides have individuals other than Messi, who leads the golden boot with eight strikes and four assists, and Yamal, to define games. But heroes have sprung for Argentina in clutch moments.

Argentina wouldn’t mind Spain hogging the possession, as they prefer to, but would look to storm them in short, explosive bursts, like the calm seas that suddenly produce savage waves.

De La Fuente snubbed a reporter when asked if Spain were the favourites. “There are two super teams. There are many similarities in behaviour and talent in footballers. No one is a favourite, not in a final,” he said. But whatever the script or climax, the protagonist would be Messi.



Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



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Rekha Gupta
Chief Minister, Delhi

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EXPRESSspecial

Day after taking charge as top cop, Kumar sends out message on ‘corruption-free force’

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 18

A DAY after taking charge as the Delhi Police Commissioner, Anurag Kumar sent out a strong message at his first meeting with senior officers, including Special Commissioners, Joint Commissioners and Deputy Commissioners of Police, saying that corruption would no longer be tolerated in the force. *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Kumar underlined that until 2005, when he last served in the Delhi Police, the force was largely free from corruption. He warned that officers found involved in corrupt practices would face strict action, sources said.

He said the force at that time was more professional than it is today, and added that steps needed to be taken to improve the Delhi Police's image and restore professionalism.

Kumar's remarks on corruption come in the wake of a recent setback faced by the Delhi Police when two inspectors were arrested by the CBI in separate corruption cases. A head constable rank personnel is allegedly found to be involved as a part of a gang.

Saturday's meeting, which began around 1 pm, lasted about 40 minutes at the Police Headquarters in the Capital. During the meeting, Kumar issued a slew of directions on tackling corruption, curbing gangster activity and extortion, improving policing, and strengthening traffic management.

According to a source, Kumar also reviewed the process of transfers and postings in the force. He stressed upon the need to bring greater transparency to the process at both the district level and at the Police Headquarters (PHQ).



Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar. X:/@DELHIPOLICE

He also warned that personnel involved in illegal activities would face strict action.

Kumar last served in the Delhi Police as the Deputy Commissioner of Police (North) in 2005 before moving to the Intelligence Bureau. He was posted at the Headquarters in Delhi, and looked after Jammu and Kashmir before the current posting.

The source said Kumar was clear, precise and direct in the instructions he gave to his subordinates and district police chiefs at the first meeting as the Delhi Police Commissioner. He also directed officers to take concrete measures to improve the city's traffic condition,

underlining that much work needed to be done to address such concerns.

In a sudden move, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) on Friday removed 1992-batch IPS officer Satish Golchha as the Delhi Police Commissioner and replaced him with Kumar, a 1994-batch IPS officer. Government sources said the Centre was unhappy with the growing number of corruption cases, involving the Delhi Police, as well as the handling of the Cockroach Janata Party protest, which they believed could have been managed more professionally.

On Saturday, environmental activist Sonam Wangchuk, who has been on an indefinite hunger strike at Jantar Mantar for 20 days, was removed from the protest site and admitted to Safdarjung Hospital.

Two district judges suspended by HC within a week amid ‘disciplinary proceedings’



Judges Veena Rani and Vinay Singhal. EXPRESS

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 18

THE DELHI High Court on July 15 suspended another district judge within a span of a week. Judge Veena Rani was posted at the Saket district court.

Earlier, on July 10, the Delhi High Court on its administrative side, through its Registrar General Arun Bhardwaj, had issued an order placing DHJS (Delhi Higher Judicial Service) judge Vinay Singhal under suspension. A similar order dated July 15 was also passed against DHJS judge Rani. Both orders place the two respective judges under "immediate suspension".

In the order suspending Judge Veena Rani, it was stated, "Whereas a disciplinary proceeding against Ms. Veena Rani, an officer of Delhi Higher Judicial Service is contemplated. Now, therefore, this Court in exercise of the powers conferred by clause (a) of sub-rule (1) of Rule 3 of the All India Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1969 read with Rule 27 of Delhi Higher Judicial Service Rules, 1970, hereby places the said Ms. Veena Rani under suspension with immediate effect."

Judge Veena Rani was serving as a district judge on the commercial side, of commercial court number 8 at Southeastern district court of Saket.

With disciplinary proceedings ongoing against the two, the

Delhi High Court has directed both not to leave the city without prior permission of the competent authority.

Additionally, for the time that the High Court's suspension order against the two remain in force, Judge Singhal's headquarter shall be the office of the Principal District and Sessions Judge at Tis Hazari Court and Rani's headquarter shall be the office of Principal District and Sessions Judge at Southeast Saket court, according to the order.

Judge Singhal was earlier serving as a senior civil judge in Tis Hazari Court (West District). He was also a metropolitan magistrate at Tis Hazari Court overlooking the jurisdiction of Mukherjee Nagar, and Sadar Bazar. In 2021, Vinay Singhal was posted from Additional Sessions Judge (POCSO) to ASJ (Electricity), Central District. In 2023, he was posted at a labour court in Rouse Avenue Court before he moved to Tis Hazari as a commercial judge.

A commercial judge is a specialised judicial officer who presides over business, financial, and corporate disputes rather than criminal or general civil cases. They resolve conflicts regarding contracts, intellectual property, banking, bankruptcy, and corporate mergers, ensuring that commercial matters are resolved efficiently and with expert legal knowledge.

‘UNPROFESSIONAL CONDUCT ON PART OF PROBE OFFICER’

Gurgaon court slams cop for ‘casual’ probe in property case

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 18

A CITY court in Gurgaon recently rapped an investigating officer (IO) over the alleged lapses during the probe into a high-stakes real estate dispute in Sushant Lok. The dispute arises from two parties allegedly securing bank loans against the same plot using conflicting documents.

While granting interim anticipatory bail to a 52-year-old woman accused in the case, Additional Sessions Judge Dr Gagan Geet Kaur pulled up the IO. In its order dated July 15, which was uploaded Saturday, the court said that it "is constrained to observe casual and unprofessional conduct on the part of the IO concerned that he did not enquire into original sale deed ... from complainant and no enquiry is made about the bank accounts of the seller and purchaser with regard to the transfer of consideration amount."

The case stems from an FIR registered at the Sushant Lok Police Station on May 19 this year, alleging encroachment and illegal construction on his plot.

The court noted that the

The court noted the matter is "of more serious concern as the loan has been obtained against the same property from 2 different banks by two persons"

matter "does not appear to be a matter of simple case of transfer of the same property," but rather "is a matter of more serious concern as the loan has been obtained against the same property from two different banks by two persons".

When prompted by the court to verify the original documents, the IO's submitted reports revealed that a private bank held the 1993 sale deed, which had been legally deposited by Suman Lata, the accused, in March.

On the other hand, a public sector bank reported that the complainant had secured a loan last July using a certified copy of the 1993 deed, supplemented by a July 2024 police DDR (Daily Diary Register), claiming the original document was lost.

Highlighting discrepancies between the two documents, the court observed that the accused's copy bore an authentic treasury officer's seal and date, while the copy submitted by the complainant lacked any such validation.

The certified copy retrieved by the IO from the tehsil office had a barcode instead of a traditional treasury stamp, prompting the Judge to declare, "This discrepancy raises a serious question on the genuineness and authenticity of the sale deed."

The Judge also questioned why the police did not investigate the alleged role of the registering Tehsildar.

The court noted that the police had violated a prior April order that had mandated that "if the investigating agency on the basis of facts wishes to arrest the accused, it will serve a notice u/s 35(3) BNSS, one week in advance".

Determining that no custodial interrogation was warranted, given the purely documentary nature of the evidence, the court granted interim bail to the complainant, directing her to formally join the police investigation on June 23.

• Skywatch

Forecast: July 19, 2026
Generally cloudy sky; spell of very light to light rain

MAX: 35-37

1.8°C above normal

MIN: 28-30

0.8°C below normal

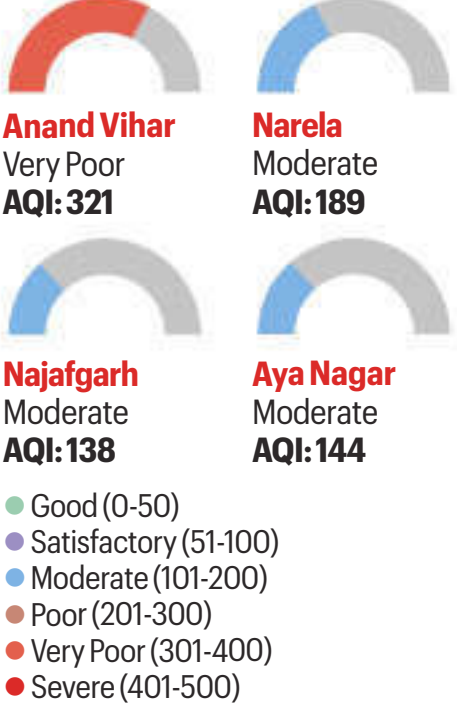
• **Sunrise:** 5:36 AM (July 20)

• **Sunset:** 7:20 PM (July 19)

• **Moonrise:** 11:33 AM (July 20)

• **Moonset:** 10:38 PM (July 19)

• AQI Tracker



CM: Govt to induct 2,800 e-buses in next two years

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, July 18

IN A move towards achieving clean air, the Delhi government plans to induct 2800 air-conditioned low-floor electric buses in the next two years, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said Saturday.

Gupta said the induction of these electric buses will also reinforce the government's goal of expanding the city's public bus fleet to nearly 14,000 buses by 2028-29. "This will enhance the availability of public transport while promoting clean energy-based mobility and making a significant contribution to improving the capital's air quality," she said.

Gupta said the government is aiming to rollout these modern buses from April next year. "Entire fleet is expected to be integrated into Delhi's public transport system by August 2028," Gupta said in a statement.

Of the total fleet, 1,400 buses will be 12 metres long and the remaining 1,400 will be 9 metres long. The 9 metre buses will be particularly useful on narrow roads and in rural areas, helping extend public transport beyond the main corridors and improving last-mile connectivity, she said.

As per officials, government had submitted its requirement for 2,800 electric buses to Convergence Energy Services Limited (CESL) last year. "Based on operational experience with the Delhi Electric Vehicle Interconnector (DEVI) buses, the requirement was later revised and it was decided to procure an equal number of 12-metre and 9-metre buses. CESL adopted a nationwide competitive bidding process for the induction of all 2,800 buses, which will help ensure bus operations at competitive rates," the statement said.

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मिर्गी दौरे

EPILEPSY/SEIZURES/FITS

R. S. RAM DIG Police, BSF, My wife Reshma used to suffer from 150 seizures a month. I took her to several major hospitals and medical colleges, and prescribed many expensive allopathic medicines for years, which had numerous side effects and no relief. Doctors told me that these medicines would last a lifetime, and if I missed taking them even for a day, I would experience seizures. As soon as I saw an advertisement for Neeraj Clinic, I immediately made plans to go to Rishikesh (Haridwar). The Ayurvedic doctor there listened to me very carefully checked my wife Reshma's pulse for 10 minutes, administered the first dose of the Ayurvedic medicine with his own hands. My wife's illness was serious and she was taking many allopathic medicines. So, the allopathic doctors there also examined her and gave her two free allopathic medicines, and discontinued all her allopathic medications. and congratulated me profusely. He instilled such confidence in my wife that she would recover that it was as if nothing had happened. I immediately started her on the medicine, and since then, she hasn't had a single seizure and is completely healthy. My wife and I are also very grateful to the doctors and staff of the clinic. There is great power in Medicines and Prayers.

1. Sudden falling on floor
2. Face turning to one side
3. Clenching of fist
4. Eyes becoming Glossy
5. Protruding tongue between the teeth
6. Foaming in mouth
7. Bending of neck
8. Jerks for a second
9. Fainting and Headache
10. Seizure during menstrual period in women
11. Fainting with "Oh-Oh/Go-Go" sound
12. Absence for a few seconds

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अधिस्चना

(38वें दीक्षान्त समारोह)

चौधरी चरण सिंह विश्वविद्यालय, मेरठ का 38वाँ दीक्षान्त समारोह बुधवार, दिनांक 22 जुलाई, 2026 को नियत है। दीक्षान्त समारोह की अध्यक्षता माननीय कुलाधिपति महोदय/ महामहिम राज्यपाल उ०प्र० श्रीमती आनंदी बेन पटेल जी द्वारा की जायेगी। समारोह के अति विशिष्ट अतिथि उत्तर प्रदेश के माननीय उच्च शिक्षा मंत्री श्री योगेन्द्र उपाध्याय जी, विशिष्ट अतिथि उत्तर प्रदेश की माननीय उच्च शिक्षा राज्य मंत्री श्रीमती रजनी तिवारी जी तथा मुख्य अतिथि प्रो० (डॉ०) हिमाशु पादक, सचिव DARE एवं महानिदेशक ICAR होंगे। दीक्षान्त समारोह में पदक, प्रमाण पत्र एवं विभिन्न पाठ्यक्रमों की उपाधियों प्रदान की जायेगी। समारोह का कार्यक्रम तथा अन्य विवरण विश्वविद्यालय की वेबसाइट www.ccsuniversity.ac.in पर पृथक से अपलोड है।

कुलसचिव

ON DAY 21 OF HUNGER STRIKE, POLICE SWOOP ON JANTAR MANTAR STAGE, WHISK SONAM WANGCHUK AWAY TO HOSPITAL

Wangchuk gone, spotlight moves to Dipke

Cockroach Janta Party founder says he will continue Wangchuk's hunger strike, ups ante, attacks Prime Minister directly

Pragynesh, Sakshi Chand, Srirupa Goswami & Swapnil Joglekar
New Delhi, July 18

FOR THE first time in nearly three weeks, the stage at Jantar Mantar was without Sonam Wangchuk. Hours after the Delhi Police took away the Ladakhi activist to Safdarjung Hospital on Saturday morning, the protest he had anchored with a 20-day hunger strike was left without its central figure.

By 9 am, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke had stepped into that vacuum. Rushing to the protest site after alleging he was briefly detained while Wangchuk was being taken away, Dipke announced that he would begin an indefinite hunger strike and sharpened his attack on the Centre. "I was dragged on the street. I was beaten up by the police," he alleged. "Once they lifted up Sonam sir from here, that is when police said that now you can go. We are going to continue the protest."

Sharpening his attack, he said: "They took him like you take away criminals. They thought the andolan (movement) would lose steam without Sonam sir. Now, instead of him, I will sit on an indefinite hunger strike."

"It was not just shameless how they took Sonam ji away. The Delhi Police cited a Delhi High Court order about his health. But the court said (to admit him) if his condition was dire. Sonam sir was clear that he was stable. The medical reports show that his vitals are fine," he said.

About an hour later, when social activist Yogendra Yadav reached the protest site and climbed the stage to show solidarity, Dipke was moved to tears. Holding up a copy of the Constitution, he said, "If you're concerned about Sonam sir, you would have taken him away with dignity. If you don't join the Jantar Mantar (protest) even now, then nothing (good) can happen to this country," he lamented as tears rolled down his eyes.

● Security stepped up at Jantar Mantar

- Multiple layers of security checks in place; bags being scanned, visitors being frisked
- Riot control vehicle on standby near the site
- As crowds swell, over 200 personnel deployed, senior officers are doing regular checks to monitor the situation, said officers

Behind him, stood CJP members, holding up Wangchuk's photo.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Dipke attacked the Prime Minister: "... Instead of sacking Dharmendra Pradhan, they forcibly dragged Sonam Wangchuk. They attacked students... Now it is very clear that Narendra Modi does not want to sack Pradhan. So he is also resilient," he alleged. "Once they lifted up Sonam sir from here, that is when police said that now you can go. We are going to continue the protest."

Asked about Monday's protest march to Parliament for which they are yet to get police permission, he said, "The Delhi Police didn't have permission to take Sonam Wangchuk away... Sonam sir didn't give his consent... the 20th July march is on."

Tensions spiked briefly in the afternoon when a woman hurled what appeared to be ink at Dipke while he was addressing a gathering. Police sources later said she was removed from stage. The speeches continued into the evening.

Addressing the crowd around 4.30 pm, Dipke said: "Modi's goons dragged him away this morning... (Delhi Police) plan to crack down tonight... If you move away from here today, understand that the protest will end. We will fight this struggle together."

Where Wangchuk lay until Saturday morning, his photograph occupies the spot on stage. Protesters said that when the white sheets shielding the police operation were pulled away, the only thing left on his mattress was his book.



Where Sonam Wangchuk lay until Saturday morning, his photograph occupies the spot. PRAVEEN KHANNA

‘(Cops) said they were doctors, took away Sonam Sir forcibly’: Protesters on police operation

Pragynesh, Swapnil Joglekar & Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, July 18

IT WAS about 6.30 am on Saturday. As most of Delhi was waking up, Seattle-based software professional Prashanth Mishra, 48, who came to India a month ago and joined the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest, was about to take a sip of his morning coffee.

Suddenly, he noticed a group of men carrying white sheets approaching the stage where activist Sonam Wangchuk lay on a raised platform. "Some of them said they were doctors. But the doctors were supposed to come only at 8.30 am, so I was alarmed," he said.

In the next few minutes, Prashanth said the group took over the stage, made a makeshift curtain, and took Wangchuk away to Safdarjung Hospital. The men were Delhi Police personnel dressed in civilian clothes.

Prashant claimed he was dragged away. "My phone broke... Sonam sir was resisting the police but he was forcibly

taken away."

Sonu, 27, who came two days ago from Uttar Pradesh's Gonda to join the protest, said he was charging his phone when he saw men going towards Wangchuk. "They were kicking away the boards on the stage. When I came running, they told me 'tumhara koi kaam nahi hai yaha (you don't have any work here).'"

"Haven't seen anything like this. It's like one moment he was there, and then he was not. Once we removed the curtains on stage, only his book was left on his mattress," he said.

From around 9 am, supporters, seemingly galvanised by Wangchuk being taken away, continued to stream into the site, with the crowd swelling to nearly 800 by evening.

People from different cities gathered at Jantar Mantar and vowed to join the July 20 march. Aanya, a college student from Rajasthan, said she joined the protest with her father and brother over "corruption". "I am fed up with the government. As students we need to raise our voices," she

said, adding that her friends had been affected by the alleged NEET exam paper leak.

Her father said the crowd had increased since morning. "Politicians haven't paid heed to students and consider them cockroaches... So many cockroaches will gather here, including some senior cockroaches like us, that the government won't be able to ignore this anymore," he said.

A 17-year-old, who is about to join college, said she got to know about Wangchuk being picked up while she was at her home in Faridabad.

"I got an alert on a WhatsApp group of students and came here. I have been here before, and will keep coming till Dipke and others are protesting," she said.

Arvind Maurya, a lawyer at the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court, said he had come to Delhi for the July 20 protest.

"When I reached around 7 am, I got to know that Wangchuk had been taken away from the protest. So I immediately came here," he said.



Security stepped up outside Safdarjung Hospital. GAJENDRA YADAV

Will continue our vigil here: next to Sonam's stage, 3 PhD students remain on protest fast

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, July 18

FOR NEARLY three weeks, the focus of the protest called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) at Jantar Mantar in Delhi over paper leaks and alleged irregularities in the conduct of NEET and other entrance tests, has been activist Sonam Wangchuk's hunger strike. Supporters gathered around the stage and cameras remained trained on him amid concerns over his health for days.

With Wangchuk taken to Safdarjung Hospital now, the movement's most recognisable face may no longer be physically present at Jantar Mantar. Yet, just a few metres from the stage, three young researchers continue to lie on thin mattresses, surviving only on water and determined that the protest will not lose momentum in his absence.

Neha Bora (29), a PhD scholar in Theatre and Performance at Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU); Aameen, pursuing his PhD at Dr B R Ambedkar University Delhi; and Manish Kumar (30), a Political Science PhD scholar at the University of Allahabad, began their water-only hunger strike the same time as Wangchuk.

Even as they have suffered significant weight loss over the course of three weeks, Saturday's events strengthened their resolve to continue their agitation. "It was heartbreaking to witness what happened this morning. It is unfortunate that the government chose to act this way," said Neha, referring to Wangchuk's removal from the protest site. "For every day that Wangchuk sir is kept in the hospital, we will remain here. That is our answer to what happened," she said.

Manish added, "We will make them answer for what they did."

A banner is placed outside their tent which mentions their vitals: Manish has lost 10.45 kg, Aameen has lost 9.85 kg, and Neha 7.55 kg over the course of three weeks.

The protesters alleged that the electricity supply to the protest site had been cut, leaving volunteers with no option but to use handheld fans to help the fasting students tackle the sweltering Delhi heat.

Even as slogans could be heard near the stage, the atmosphere around the three scholars was subdued. Volunteers periodically checked on them, ad-



The scholars began their indefinite fast the same time as Wangchuk. SAKSHI CHAND

justed pillows beneath their heads and encouraged them to save energy.

Referring to the High Court order, directing the government to monitor the health of Wangchuk, Manish questioned the police action. "The court order they cited nowhere says that we have to be removed from here. They are interpreting it incorrectly. We are not going anywhere," he said.

Neha also serves as the All India President of the student outfit All India Students' Association. She recalled waking up to chaos on Saturday. "I was asleep. Manish and another friend were trying to wake me up when we saw Sonam being taken away under a shield made of white bedsheets," she said.

She claimed that police personnel tried to enter the enclosure where the three scholars were lying. "They were pushing and trying to break our tent. They were also trying to get past the ropes around us, but people immediately formed a human chain around us and they could not succeed," she alleged.

No response from the Delhi Police was available regarding this.

Around four to five doctors examine the fasting students every day, according to volunteers. One doctor is deputised by the government, while the others are part of the medical arrangements made by the protesters themselves. Family members, too, make regular visits to check on these protesters.

Aameen's sister is among the frequent visitors. Sitting quietly beside Manish through the day on Saturday was his wife, Seema, a PhD scholar at Lucknow University.

"The family is extremely worried," she said, adding that despite repeated requests from relatives, Manish has refused to end his fast.



Abhijeet Dipke after the ink attack at Jantar Mantar on Saturday. PTI

‘Blue is my colour’: Dipke after ink attack at Jantar Mantar

Pragynesh
New Delhi, July 18

IT WAS around 1:20 pm. Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke was addressing the crowd at Jantar Mantar on Saturday. He claimed that the Delhi Police "tactfully" removed climate activist Sonam Wangchuk earlier in the day from the site. "You say you were concerned about his health. If you weren't doing anything wrong, *Toh wardi mein kyun nahi aaye* (why didn't you come in uniform)," he questioned.

A woman kept moving closer to the stage as he spoke. Once she was at the stage, close enough to Dipke, she threw ink at the CJP founder.

The 32-year-old was taken by surprise. Identified as Barkha Trehan, she was dragged away from the stage by CJP supporters and taken to the Parliament Street police station, said officers.

Trehan, who describes herself a men's rights activist, chanted 'Jai Shree Ram,' while being taken away from the protest site, officers added. She alleged that she was beaten by the CJP supporters as she left the venue. On her X account, Trehan has heavily criticised CJP in her posts. In her bio, she describes herself as a "Hindu entrepreneur", and the 'Voice of Men.'

The last time she was seen at Jantar Mantar was on December 25, 2025, when she participated in a protest organised by her NGO 'Purush Aayog,' supporting former BJP MLA Kuldeep Senger, who was accused of raping a 17-year-old girl in Uttar Pradesh's Unnao, according to officers. She is a regular on TV debates and also writes for media outlets.

Referring to an earlier attack in Jaipur, when he was slapped during a CJP protest, Dipke said that he won't be deterred by such attacks. Soon after the incident, referring to the colour of the ink that was thrown at him, he posted on his X account, "Blue is my colour."

Meanwhile, police said that officers merely removed Trehan from the protest site and did not detain her. According to police, they let her go and no case was registered.



Barkha Trehan, the woman who threw ink on Dipke. EXPRESS

‘No trust’: Wife wants Wangchuk moved from Safdarjung; says march in ‘cities across India’

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 18

GITANJALI ANGMO, wife of activist Sonam Wangchuk, said on Saturday afternoon that nothing should be given to her husband orally or intravenously without her consent. She said that doctors who have been attending to Wangchuk through the period of his fast at Jantar Mantar were being denied access to him, and demanded that the activist should be allowed to go to a medical facility of his choice.

"This morning, without informing Sonam or me, he was forcibly taken from the protest site (at Jantar Mantar) to Safdarjung hospital. Yesterday (Friday) evening, doctors from Safdarjung checked on Sonam Wang-

chuk and found his vitals to be normal. His potassium was 4.3 (milliequivalents per litre); right now they are telling us it is 2.9, which is life-threatening. We have asked the doctors for his reports, which they have not shared," Angmo told reporters outside Safdarjung hospital around 1 pm.

"We do not want anything to be given to him orally or through IV (intravenously) without my consent. There is a problem of trust, and a lack of transparency. Secondly, why are they not letting our phones inside (the hospital building)? Why is there such heavy police deployment? It seems like this is not Safdarjung hospital, but Safdarjung prison," she said.

Wangchuk's 20-day hunger strike had "recast the image of



Gitanjali Angmo. AMIT MEHRA

Gen Z", Angmo said. "Earlier they were lamented, but Gen Z has shown how a peaceful protest can be conducted... Sonam Wangchuk joined this protest because the demand for a clean and competent education system is just, and should be met," she said.

Angmo said that the march planned by Wangchuk on the

first day of Parliament's Monsoon Session on Monday would also take place in cities across the country, and that she would represent the activist if he was unable to join himself. "The protest so far has happened without violence, so they have no reason to stop the march on Monday. The march will not only take place in Delhi, but in various cities across India. And if Sonam's health does not permit it, I will represent him," she said.

In a letter to the Medical Superintendent of Safdarjung hospital, Angmo asked for her husband to be discharged so that he could be taken to a different medical facility. "We want Sonam shifted to a medical centre of our choice. We asked your team to share his reports

with us, digitally or physically, and they refused. The doctors who have been monitoring him for the past 20 days are not being allowed to meet him. This lack of transparency has shaken our trust in your hospital. Kindly complete the discharge formalities at the earliest," she wrote.

In the evening, Angmo told Saurav Das, a spokesperson of the CJP: "Sonam's vitals are currently normal. He has not broken his fast, even though he has been offered coconut water and IV. He wants to send the message to the youth that we have to take this movement to its end, by marching to Parliament on Monday. The youth have continued the movement in a peaceful manner after he was removed (from the protest site), and he is proud of that."



Protesters at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Saturday. TASHI TOBGYAL

down, ketones are produced as a byproduct. This changes the

pH of the body, which is linked to several bodily processes, all

of which get affected. The body now produces so many ketones that they accumulate and make the blood acidic."

The bulletin from the hospital also stated that Wangchuk's blood glucose levels were low, which indicates that he doesn't have enough sugar in his body to use as fuel. Also, the urine ketone level had increased from '1+' at the time of admission to hospital to '3+' by the afternoon, indicating that his body is breaking down muscles and using it for generating energy — leading to the formation of ketones.

The bulletin from Safdarjung said Wangchuk was continuing to turn down essential medical interventions.

"Although intravenous

fluids were advised, but the patient has refused all intravenous fluids, oral rehydration fluid, or any other medication. He is being continuously monitored and counselled for treatment," the hospital said.

By evening, an expert from the neighbouring AIIMS had also assessed Wangchuk and concurred with the opinion of the treating team at Safdarjung that Wangchuk needed oral or intravenous fluid and electrolyte therapy. However, the Safdarjung bulletin noted that "Despite repeated counselling by the treating team and the independent expert regarding the urgent need for treatment, the patient has declined... The patient's family has also not yet provided

consent for the recommended medical intervention."

Dr Chatterjee said that in a situation of long fasting, the first step is to administer an IV fluid with electrolytes to restore the electrolyte balance in the patient's body. After that, the person should be given food if they are able to eat, or nutrition through nasal tube.

"At present, any damage to his health seems reversible, and can be resolved in a few days. However, the situation is at a stage where things can still go wrong, his organs, and then his brain, can start getting affected, which could lead to him slipping into a coma. These conditions are serious, and may not be reversible," he said.

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 18

THE 21-DAY-LONG hunger strike has started affecting activist Sonam Wangchuk's health, with his sugar levels and potassium levels dropping. The ketone levels in his urine have also started increasing, indicating that his body is now using his muscles to fuel itself, according to a health bulletin issued by Safdarjung hospital on Saturday evening.

The activist was forcibly admitted to hospital at 7.40 am on Saturday morning, "as per the recommendations of the team of doctors looking after him", according to sources in the Union Health Ministry. The

sources underlined that the Delhi High Court had, on July 15, said that doctors could take "whatever medical intervention required" in the interest of Wangchuk's health.

The health bulletin issued by Safdarjung hospital on Saturday evening said Wangchuk was showing signs of dehydration — his own treating physician Dr Satish Lamba too had said the same earlier. Dr Lamba had recorded normal blood pressure, blood sugar, pulse rate, and oxygen levels for Wangchuk on Friday.

The Safdarjung hospital bulletin said that a "blood gas analysis" — which is a test to analyse several blood parameters such as pH, oxygen,

and carbon dioxide levels — showed that Wangchuk was in "compensated acidosis".

Dr Suranjit Chatterjee, a senior internal medical specialist who is not part of Wangchuk's medical team, told *The Indian Express*: "When the body is starved, it starts to utilise its muscles, which leads to the formation of acids. This condition is called acidosis. However, the body is also very good at repairing itself, which is what 'compensated' refers to. It means Wangchuk's body is still fighting." Dr B K Tripathi, a former head of medicine at Safdarjung hospital, said: "When there is a lack of calories, the body starts utilising its protein reserves. When the proteins are broken

X



X



ONE
DAIRY
LEADER.
TWO
ICONIC
TEAMS.
ONE ICONIC
FINAL.

MIKEL MERINO
MIDFIELDER

Amul Doodh
Peeti Hai Duniya



Classifieds

PERSONAL

I,ISHA W/O-SUNNY ALAWADHI R/O-16A, UPPER GROUND-FLOOR, ROAD NO.44, WEST PUNJABI BAGH, DELHI-110026, have changed my name to ISHA ALAWADHI. 0040866885-4

I, Aatish S/o Anil Kumar Mavi R/o H.N.270, Tila Shahbazpur-5, Teela, Ghaziabad U.P. 201102 Change my Name to Aatish Mavi for all purposes 0040866798-1

I, HEERA SINGH, S/o Sh. Balwinder Singh R/o C-236, Near Gurudawara, Tagore Garden, New Delhi-110027, have changed my name to HEERA SINGH SABHARWAL. 0040866846-9

I, hitherto known as MUKESH KUMAR alias SHIV NARAIN, S/O sunderlal, residing at, house no-186, ajitvihar, burari, delhi-110084, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MUKESH KUMAR. 0040866864-11

I, TAMANNA KUMARI D/O ASHOK KUMAR R/O B-366, BLOCK-B, VIKAS VIHAR, VIKAS NAGAR, UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110059 declare that name of mine is wrongly written as Tamanna in my 12th Class educational documents. My actual name is Tamanna Kumari for all purposes. 0071048546-1

I, SALIM, S/O-NASRUDDIN, r/o-Kirbani Masjid Wali Gali, Humdar-Nagar, Balrampur, Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh-202001, has changed my name to SALIM AHAMAD permanently. 0040866846-2

I, Gogender Kumar, S/O OM Parkash, R/o H.No.-399, Village-Badli, Delhi-110042, have changed my name to Yogender Kumar. 0040866864-3

I, LALITA DEVI W/o Shri Parkash Gupta R/O House No-143, State Bank Nagar, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110063 have changed my name to LALITA GUPTA 0040866882-11

I, Mohammed Alam, S/O Peer Baksh R/O-F-286 Abul Fazel Enclave Part-2 Shaheen-Bagh, Jamia-Nagar Okhla New Delhi-110025, Have changed my name to MD. ALAM Permanently 0040866882-1

I, Bhoomi Sharma, D/o Shri Vijay Mohan Sharma, R/O 103-A, Ground Floor, Jawahar Gali, Circular Road, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, hereby declare that my name is recorded as "Bhoomi" in my Class X (10th) Certificate and as "Bhoomi Sharma" in my Aadhaar Card. Both names refer to one and the same person. Henceforth, I shall be known and use the name "Bhoomi Sharma" for all purposes. 0040866817-1

I, SHAN MOHAMMAD, S/O-MOHD DILDRAR, R/O-B-380, Old Seema Puri, Jilimil, Shahdara, Delhi-110095, has changed my name to SHAAN MOHD permanently for all future purposes. 0040866846-11

I, Anju Gupta D/O Braham Parkash Gupta, W/o Ankur Aggarwal R/O C-9/111, Sector-7, Rohini, Delhi have changed my name to Anju Aggarwal. 0040866882-4

I, Atar Singh S/o Palto Ram, R/O Firahead, Post- Khas, Feera Hedi, Saharanpur, Distt-Saharanpur (U.P.) -247001, have changed my name from Atar Singh Tyagi to Atar Singh. Henceforth, I shall be known by the name of Atar Singh for all future purposes. 0071048572-1

I, Mohammad Nadeem, S/O-Mehfooz Khan, R/O-1965, Gali-Wali Beg, Mohalla Qabristan, Turkman-gate, Delhi-110006, declare that my father Mehfooz Khan alias Lal Khan Both names are one and the same-person. 0040866846-4

I, Ashish Seherawat, S/o Jogender Singh, R/O D-147, First Floor, Amstoria Society, Sector-102, Gurugram (Haryana)-122505, have changed my minor daughter's name, from Anaya to Anaya Seherawat. 0040866864-5

I, SUFIA PARVEEN SULTANA W/O MOHD JALAL ANSARI R/O B-372 STREET No.-29, MAHAVIR ENCLAVE-2 NEW DELHI 110059 I HAVE CHANGED MY NAME SUFIA PARVEEN SULTANA TO SUFIA PARVEEN FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES. 0040866842-1

I, Suchitra Jauhari, W/O-A N Jauhari, R/O-House No-88A, Sector-5, Rachna-Vaishali, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, have changed my name to Suchitra Verma, for all, future purpose. 0040866846-13

I, Jitendra Ram S/o Kanhaiya Ram R/o VILL.- POST Khalpura, Khalpura Bala, Saran, Bihar-841211, have changed my name to Jitendra Ramanand 0071048609-1

I, Vandana Shukla W/o, Sh. Akhilesh Shukla R/O H.No. G-99, Angoori Sadan, Street No.14, Near Gayatri Temple, Ganga Vihar, New Delhi 110094 have changed my name from kumari AwadheshtDuby to Vandana Shukla for all purposes 0040866812-1

I, TUSHAR AGARWAL S/O KAILASH AGGARWAL R/O H.NO. B-6/36 SECTOR-3 ROHINI DELHI-110085, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO TUSHAR AGGARWAL FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040866846-6

I, Dimple Chauhan, S/O. Devender Chauhan, R/O J-5/122, Second & Third floor, near-Singh Sabha Gurudwara, Rajouri Garden, New-Delhi-110027, have changed my name to Dimple Singh, for all Purposes. 0040866864-7

I, Preet Rathore, S/o Mr.Narendra Singh, R/O H.No.62, First-Floor, Village-Munirka, New-Delhi-110067, have stated that my mother's name is incorrectly-written as Dimple in my documents. Her correct name is Dimple Bai, for all, future purposes. 0040866885-1

I, Guddo W/o Laxmi Narayan R/O House No.1673 I, Bapa Nagar Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005, I have changed my name from Chandra Kala to Guddo for all future purposes. 0040866842-3

I, DHARMEDER KUMAR MEHTA, S/o-Jhngi Ram Mehta, R/o.Flat.No-702, Rose-Tower Fragrance Dream Homes Siddharth-Vihar, Sector-3 Vijay-Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009, have change my name DHARMEDER MEHTA. 0040866882-8

I, Ritika D/o Jyoti Singh R/o B-128, Mohamadpur, R.K.Puram(Main), Delhi-110066, have changed my name to Ritika Singh. 0040866882-6

I, POOJA TAGRA, W/o-SANJEEV KUMAR, R/o-D-2/65, SECTOR-11, ROHINI, DELHI-110085, have changed my name to POOJA PASRICHA 0040866885-3

I, Aatish Mavi S/o Anil Kumar Mavi R/o H.No.270 Tila Shahbazpur-5 Teela, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh 201102 have lost my Original 10th Marksheets of Year 2019 ROLL no. 0397522 UP Board. If Found Please Contact No. 9654900012 0040866796-1

I, Sangita Yadav, W/o Rakesh Yadav, R/o H.No-5, Nagla Soomra, Post-Kinawa, Po-Bilram, Kasganj, UP-207123, have my name to Sangeeta Kumari. 0040866846-8

I, Syed Mushahid Sauban S/o Mr.Syed Mohammad Quasim Jafri, R/O H.No. 236, Gali no.-20, Zakir-Nagar, Jamia-Nagar, South-Delhi, Delhi-110025, inform that my Father's name Syed Mohammed Qasim wrongly mentioned in my passport but actual my father's name is Syed Mohammad Quasim Jafri for all future purposes. That Syed Mohammad Qasim and Syed Mohammad Quasim Jafri are one and same-person. 0040866864-0

I, Lakshmi Narasamamba W/o No JC-59996-P Rank Ex SUB MAJOR (HONY) Lieutenant P Satyanaranya Murty R/O 361, Vasant Enclave DDA Flats, VTC: Vasant Vihar Delhi-110057 have changed my name to Pataballa Lakshmi Narasamamba vide affidavit date 16/7/26 before Delhi. 0071048545-1

I, Khushboo, daughter of Premal Sharma, residing at B/192, Tigri Extension, New Delhi-110062, have voluntarily changed my name to Khushboo Sharma. Henceforth, I shall be known and identified by this name for all purposes. 0050293470-1

I, Kavitha W/o Sasun Chittaruv, R/O Flat No-404, 4th Floor Tower-F Microtech Greenburg Sector-86 Gurgaon-122004, Have Changed My Name To C Kavitha. 0040866846-1

I, Rajo W/o Brahm Sawroop, R/O H.No.399, Village-Badli Delhi-110042, have changed my name to Rajawanti. 0040866864-2

I, SRI PARKASH GUPTA, S/o-Narain Das Gupta, R/O-House-No-143, State Bank Nagar, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110063, have changed my name to SHRI PARKASH GUPTA. 0040866882-10

I, SUNNY, S/o-SHAM ALAWADHI, R/o-16A, UPPER GROUND-FLOOR, ROAD.NO.-44, WEST PUNJABI-BAGH, DELHI-110026, have changed my name to SUNNY ALAWADHI 0040866885-5

I, Anil Mavi S/o Chahat Ram R/o 270 Tila Shahbazpur, Ghaziabad U.P -201102 Change my Name to Anil Kumar Mavi for all purposes 0040866802-1

I, Mahesh Kumar, S/o Sh. Jugal Kishor R/O P-95A, First Floor, Vishnu Garden, New Delhi-110018, have changed the name to Mahesh Kumar Agarwal. 0040866846-10

I, Tamanna Siddhant Sharma, W/O-Siddhant Sharma, R/O G 13-a, South Extension Part-2, Andrews-ganj South, Delhi-110049 Have Changed My Name to Tamanna Nagpal AI Future. 0040866882-3

I, ESHA LATIF W/O MOHD ZAID SALEEM R/O 1217 BARADARI BEHIND NOVELTY CINEMA, DELHI, NORTH DELHI 110006 , have changed my name to ESHA LATEEF Permanently 0071048548-1

I, REGUNATHAN PILLAI is dependent parent of AKHIL R NATH residing at JA52F, HARI ENCLAVE, HARI NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110064 have changed my name from REGUNATHAN PILLAI to REGHUNATHAN PILLAI R vide affidavit (DL5630023204988V) dated 17/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. 0040866832-1

I, Mukesh Kumar S/o B-S. Aggarwal R/o-170, Bharat Apartment, Sector-13, Rohini, Delhi-110085 have changed my name to Mukesh Kumar Garg for all purposes. 0040866773-1

I, SUNIL JAIN S/O SARUP SINGH JAIN, R/O C-3, SECOND FLOOR, PANCHWATI, AZADPUR, ADARSH NAGAR, DELHI-110093, have changed my name to SUNIL KUMAR JAIN 0040866846-3

I, Soumya Khatwani, D/o Bhagwan Das Daswani, R/O Lane No.2A, Padam Hira Bhawan, Pushpraj Colony, Satna, Madhya Pradesh-485001, have changed my name to Soumya Daswani. 0040866864-4

I, hitherto known, as KM BHARATEE GUPTA, W/O-ARPIT GUPTA, R/O-330-331, 1ST-FLOOR, POCKET-11B, SHRI BALAJI ENCLAVE, SECTOR-23, ROHINI, DELHI-110085, have changed my name, and shall hereafter be known, as BHARTI GUPTA. 0040866882-13

I, Amal Biswas, S/o Bhim Biswas R/o H.No.A-18, Shiv Mandir, Khadar, Sarita Vihar, New Delhi-110076, my name is mentioned in my Pan card, Aadhar card & Bank account as Amal Biswas, have changed my name to Amalendu Biswas for all future purposes. 0040864596-2

I, ABHIK KUMAR BHATTACHARYA, S/O-SRUIB KUMAR BHATTACHARYA, R/O-Flat.No-J-89, Dilishad-Colony, Jilimil, East-Delhi, Delhi-110095, has changed my name to ABHIK BHATTACHARYA permanently, for all future, purpose 0040866846-12

I, Kalpana W/o Atar Singh, R/o Firahead, Post- Khas, Feera Hedi, Saharanpur, Distt. Saharanpur (U.P.) -247001, have changed my name from Kalpana Tyagi to Kalpana. Henceforth, I shall be known by the name of Kalpana for all future purposes. 071048576-1

Ranjeet Singh S/o Ompal Singh Residence-9, Kaparaita, Post Barai, District-Etah, have changed my name Ranjeet Singh to Ranjeet SinghChauhan for all future purposes. 0040866806-1

I, Jagdish Kumar Tuteja, S/o-Parkash Chand, R/o-3084/4, Gali, No-10, Ranjeet-Nagar, Delhi-8, have changed my name to Jagdish Kumar 0040866846-5

I, GOPAL, S/O KANCHHI SINGH, R/O H.NO.72, GALI NO-6 SECTOR-1, RAKSHA ENCLAVE MOHAN GARDEN UTTAM NAGAR, DELHI-110059, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO GOPAL SINGH. 0040866864-6

I Chinmay Jain R/O N-5 West Jyoti Nagar Delhi-94 have changed my name to Chinmay Jain from Chinmey Jain. 0130066934-1

I, Muneda Shahi, W/O-MD. Alam, R/O-F-286 Abul-Fazal Enclave Part-2, Shaheen-Bagh, Jamia-nagar Okhla, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to MUNIDA SHAHI Permanently 0040866882-2

I, MOHAMAD JALAL ANSARI, S/O LATE ID MOHAMAD ANSARI, R/O B-372 STREET NO.-29, MAHAVIR ENCLAVE-2, NEW DELHI-110059, I HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM MOHAMAD JALAL ANSARI TO MOHD JALAL ANSARI FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040866842-2

I, mohd yusuf s/o sahabuddin, R/O jai vihar phase-1 Najafgarh new delhi -110043, have changed my name, from mohd yusuf to MD Yusuf 0040866882-7

Puttaraju B E S/O Eralah R/o 988/1, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar, PO-Tiptur, Distt-Tumkur, Karnataka -572201, have changed my name to Madhukumar 0071048612-1

I, Shamsher Singh Manhas S/o Jai Singh Manhas, residing at 12A, Friends Tower, Plot 47, Sector 9 Rohini, Delhi have corrected my name from S. S. Manhas to Shamsher Singh Manhas , Affidavit No. 11148 Dated 15 July 2026 at Notary Public, District Court, Gurugram. 0130066985-1

I, Vikash Yadav S/o Rakesh Yadav R/O H.No-5, Nagla Soomra, Post-Kinawa, Po-Bilram, Kasganj, UP-207123, have my name to Vikas Yadav. 0040866846-7

I, Haseema Begum, W/o-Mohd Moide Alam R/O-G49/D, 3rd Floor Siddika Apartment Shaheen-Bagh Okhla Delhi-110025, Have Changed My Name To Naseema Begum. 0040866864-8

I, Jatin Rathore, S/o Mr.Narendra Singh, R/O-H.No.62, First-Floor, Village Munirka, New Delhi-110067, have stated that my mother's name is incorrectly-written as Dimple in my documents. Her correct name is Dimple Bai, for all, future purposes. 0040866885-2

I Radheshyam Patidar S/o Babulal R/O House No.-663, Ward No.-20, Gram- Kalaliya, Teh- Jaora, Kalaliya (Dewas), Jaora, Ratlam, Madhya Pradesh -457336, have changed my name to Radheshyam 0071048614-1

I, Samir Krishan Modi S/O Late Sh. Krishan Kumar Modi, Aged-56 Years. R/O 31A, Flat No.5, 3rd Floor, Friends Colony (West), PO: New Friends Colony, DIST: South East Delhi-110025, have changed my Name from Samir Krishan Modi to Samir Kumar Modi for all Purposes. 0040866851-1

I, Yash S/o Jyoti Singh R/o B-128, Mohamadpur, R.K.Puram (Main), Delhi-110066, have changed my name to Yash Singh. 0040866882-5

I, BUSHRA, W/O MOHD SHAHZAD, R/O-4931 GALI DARZIYAN BARA HINDU RAO DELHI-110006, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO 'BUSHRA SHAHZAD FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040866864-1

My Husband Actual/Current Name is RAMESH KUNDRA Insteadof RAMESH KUMAR, which is Wrongly-Written in my-Passport, RAMESH KUNDRA @RAMESH KUMAR, both names belong to Same person i.e, my husband, I, Neeru Kundra, R/o-WZ-B/8, Bari Singh Park, New Multan-Nagar, New-Delhi-56 0040866882-9

I, Rinku W/O Sandeep Beniwal R/O M/83, Jhulelal Apppts, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Rinku Beniwal. 0040866851-3

MATRIMONIAL

ALLIANCE for our son, 33 years, Ghaziabad, 5'-8", B. Tech, MBA, associate manager in Delhi, Hindu, Kayasth. Bride from a decent kayasth family, around 29 years. Contact 9318302530, shriaks61@gmail.com 0050292985-2

Seeking suitable alliance for 31, vegetarian, non-alcoholic Arora boy 5'-5" IIT graduate, Principal Researcher in US with good salary. Preferably postgraduate based in US pursuing higher studies or working in suitable professional field. 9041986941 0050293426-

NRI / GREEN CARD

REQUIRE Vegetarian Girl in USA/ India ready to relocate to Sanjose for Bachelor Boy 1987 July 6th, MS, on I-140. Contact : 9930020727. 0071047117-1

SIKH / PUNJABI

Sikh 38M 5'10" B'Tech seeks homely / professional match. Family Delhi based. Whatsapp 9818559090, 9936092227. 0050293425-1

JAT SIKH Well Settled handsome Canada PR Sandhu Boy, born May 1994/Height 5'-8 1/2", Civil Engineer Canada.

Working-Market Analyst (work only USA) Real Estate, Annual Income-6 Figures.

Family Business-Petrol Pump (Mohali), Construction company, rental income, Agriculture land.

Family Residence-1 kanal House-Mohali. Alliances are welcome from Punjab, Haryana, and Himachal Pradesh

CONTACT: 9868439607/980000063

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is for the general public information that my Client Shrinivas Sharma S/O Sh. Goutam Sharma and his wife Smt. Rama Sharma Both R/O 4-A/RZ-41, Street No. 5, Dabri, Janakpuri Metro Station, Stiapuri, VTC Palam Village, South West Delhi, Delhi-110045, have debarred, disown and break down all the relationship from their son namely Saurabh Sharma and his wife Smt. Manita Sharma, from their all movable and Immovable properties either self acquired or ancestral, situated all over India due to their misconduct, disobedience and misbehavior attitude. My client will not be responsible in future for their acts which is done by them. Sd/- AJAY KR. SINGH (Advocate) Seat No. P, Patiala House Courts, New Delhi-110001

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is inform public at large that my Clients Shri Chandan Roy and Mrs. Aditi Mukherjee (M-9688326427) both resident of C-344, Vojana Vihar, Delhi intend to purchase into the first floor property No. H-112, situated at Haur Khas, New Delhi comprising of 3 Bedrooms with 3 attached bath Rooms, Kitchen, Front and Rear Balcony along with 2 car parking with separate Gate and one servant quarters still parking, in the said property alongwith proportionate undivided, indivisible and impartible ownership rights in the said plot of land admeasuring 188 sq. yards namely the property bearing No. H-112, situated at Haur Khas, New Delhi from its Owners namely Anand Kumar Gautam son of Late Ram Swoop resident of 136, Gautam Nagar, New Delhi-110089 and Neha Sehgal wife of Shri Nitish Sehgal resident of 95-B, Gautam Nagar, New Delhi-110049. In case any authority/tribunal or persons is having any objection of any nature what so ever regarding sale of this property, my client will not be responsible in future for their acts which is done by them. My clients qua the said sale property. Sd/- Pradeep Mahajan (Advocate) En. No. D/358/86 B-215, Vojana Vihar, Vikas Marg Extn, New Delhi-110092

PUBLIC NOTICE

Information is given to general public at large upon instruction from Mrs. Neelam Jyoti, Mr. Jawahar Singh who intend to mortgage Plot No. 5 and 7 out of Khosra No. 1554, 1555, 1575, 1576, 1577, near Singh in the area of village Adwala, tehsil & Distt. Hapur, U.P. 245101 is the owner through Sale Deed dated 11.03.2024 Document No. 2252. Sale Deed dated 09.02.2023 executed by Mrs. Sheela Rani & Mr. Nitish Sehgal alias Harsh Singh in favour of Mrs. Neelam Jyoti in respect of the property, document No. 970, SRD-Hapur. That original prior chain link documents i.e. 1) Original Sale Deed dated 15.04.2010 Document No. 4702, 2) Sale Deed dated 28.03.2017 Document No. 1533, 3) Sale Deed dated 22.12.2011 Document No. 18437, 4) Sale Deed dated 27.03.2012 Document No. 4502 and 5) Sale Deed dated 28.08.2012 Document No. 10901 are missing and not traceable. An online F.I.R. has been lodged on 08.07.2025 by Mr. Dushyant Kumar Jyoti, R.N. No. 430288/2026, Gaurpur P.S. East Distt. Any person who finds these documents is requested to return to above mentioned address. Further, For Plot No. 6: Mr. Jawahar Singh who is the owner through Gift Deed dated 21.04.2023 executed by Mrs. Shakra vide Doc. No. 3427, SRD-Hapur. Prior chain i.e. Sale Deed dated 15.04.2010 Document No. 18437, is missing and has been mentioned above. And Plot No. 8: Mrs. Neelam Jyoti is the owner of Plot No. 9 through Sale Deed dated 06.12.2023 executed by Mr. Girish Singh Bhat vide Doc. No. 11679 who was the owner by virtue of inheritance from the demise of Mrs. Bhawani Devi who was the owner through Sale Deed dated 28.10.1985 executed by Mr. Gayendra Singh Jyoti self and as attorney of Mr. Subhash Chand Jyoti and others vide Doc. No. 13833 which was the original through Sale Deed dated 22.12.2011 executed by Mr. Gayendra Singh Jyoti self and as attorney Mr. Subhash Chand Jyoti and others vide Doc. No. 18437. Any person(s), institution(s) having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person(s)/institution(s) shall not be binding upon the said property or Aditya Birla Capital Ltd. Sd/- Mohd K. Hussain (Advocate) D-21, Basement, Block D, Jangpura Extn, New Delhi-110014, 8010391672

PUBLIC NOTICE

Information is given to general public at large upon instruction from Mr. Rajinder Singh who intends to mortgage Plot No. 3 area measuring 980 sq. fts. & Flat No. C, area measuring 1958.12 sq. fts. total area measuring 1958.12 sq. fts., both situated in the colony known as Punjabi Bazar West, New Delhi-110026 who was the owner through Sale Deed dated 16.09.2013 executed by Mr. Indar Pal Singh Document No. 3638 SRD-JA who was the owner through Sale Deed dated 14.12.2012 executed by Mr. Sewa Singh Document No. 6303 and Sale Deed dated 17.12.2012 Document No. 5302. That Original prior chain documents i.e. 1) Sale Deed dated 16.05.1989 executed by Mrs. Daya Wati in favour of Mrs. Indar Kharsarda Flat No. C, Document No. 5633, 2) Sale Deed dated 28.05.2008 executed in favour of Mrs. Norma Evers in respect of Flat No. C, Document No. 2764, 3) Sale Deed dated 21.09.2012 executed in favour of Mr. Indar Pal Singh in respect of Flat No. C, Document No. 4940, 4) Sale Deed dated 17.12.2012 executed in favour of Mr. Indar Pal Singh in respect of the Flat No. C, area measuring 980 sq. fts., Document No. 5302, 5) Sale Deed dated 17.05.1989 executed in favour of Mrs. Gernons Flat No. 3, Document No. 5648, 7) Sale Deed dated 11.05.2007 executed in favour of Sanjay Kumar and Deepshah Mathotra half share of Flat No. 3, Document No. 2632, 8) Sale Deed dated 10.05.2007 executed in favour of Sanjay Kumar and Deepshah Mathotra half share of Flat No. 3, Document No. 2632, 9) Sale Deed dated 04.10.2007 executed in favour of Sanjay Kumar Flat No. 3, Document No. 4631, 10) Sale Deed dated 29.11.2007 executed in favour of Neena Grover Flat No. 3, Document No. 3341, 11) Sale Deed dated 28.10.2012 executed by Neena Grover in favour of Sewa Singh Flat No. 3, Document No. 4034. Online F.I.R. has been lodged on 16.07.2025 by Mr. Rajinder Singh vide LR No. 453598/5-Punjab Bazar, New Delhi. Any person(s)/institution(s) find the same may please return to the above mentioned address. Misuse of the same shall be liable for legal action under relevant provisions of the law of the land. Any person(s), institution(s) having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 10 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person(s)/institution(s) shall not be binding upon the said property or Kotak Mahabank Bank Ltd. Sd/- Mohd K. Hussain (Advocate) D-21, Basement, Block D, Jangpura Extn, New Delhi-110014, 8010391672

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client, Deepak Kumar Verma, son of Rajendra Prasad Verma, resident of B-45/177, Guru Nanak Pura, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi-110092, has disowned and debarred his daughter Anushka Verma from all his movable and immovable properties due to her misconduct. My client will not be responsible for any of her actions or transactions. Sd/- V. K. Singh (Advocate) Ch.No. D-623, Karkardooma Court, Shahdara Delhi

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E-Tender Notice No. 20-MCW-CCat-PEH-2026-27, Dhanbad, dated 16.07.2026 E-Open Tender in Two Packet System is invited in IREPS Portal for execution of the following work by Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer (Co-ord.), East Central Railway, Dhanbad: 1. Name of Work : C-Category Heavy Body Repair of BOXN & BOXNHL Wagons at Patherdih (PEH) depot of Dhanbad Division. 2. Contract Period: 12 Months. 3. Location of work : Patherdih (PEH) Depot of Dhanbad Division, 4. Advertised Tender Value : ₹12,16,53,760.30/- (Rupees Twelve Crore Sixteen Lakh Fifty Three Thousand Seven Hundred Sixty and Thirty Paise) Only. 5. Cost of Tender Document : 0.00 (Nil). 6. Earnest Money (As per NIT) to be deposited : ₹24,33,100/- (Rupees Twenty Four Lakh Thirty Three Thousand One Hundred) Only. 7. Tender Publishing Date : 15.07.2026, 8. Date & Time for submission of E-Tender : From 23.07.2026 to 06.08.2026 up to 12:00 hrs. 9. Date & time of opening of E-Tender : 06.08.2026 at 12:30 hrs.. 10. Website particulars : <http://www.ireps.gov.in> (No manual tender will be accepted against e-tendering). Sr. Div. Mech. Engineer (Co-ord)/ ECR/Dhanbad PR/0571/DHN/Mech.T/26-27/40

PUBLIC NOTICE

Meender Pail Saini S/o Sh. Munshi Ram Saini Alottee of Application No.177883 under Rohini Residential Scheme, 1981, had submitted FDR No.15391 dated 25-04-1981 amounting to Rs.750/- It is hereby informed that the aforesaid original FDR has been lost/misplaced in this regard- 1. Lost Report No. DD No. 2013 dated 19-1-2006 has been lodged at Police Station Vikas Puri New Delhi-110018 2. An Intendly Bond has also been executed regarding loss of the said FDR. If anybody has any objection/claim regarding the aforesaid FDR or finds the same, he/she may contact the undersigned within 15 days from publication of this notice. Address: B-17, 1st Floor, New Krishna Park, Vikas Puri, New Delhi-110019 Mobile No.9819244492

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is informed to general public that my client, Naseema W/o Moineuddin R/o 201, Gali No. 6, Laxmi Nagar Delhi has disowned and delinked her relation with elder son Mohd. Asif and his family R/o Gadda Colony, Jaitpur, Delhi and has debarred them from all her movable and immovable properties and family relations, affairs and dealings due to his acts, conduct and behavior and they shall have no authority, right or permission to represent my client or her movable or immovable properties in any manner. My client shall not be responsible / liable for any such act, deed or transaction to any person/s dealing with them in future. ARVIND BHARDWAJ Advocate Ch.No. 627, Karkardooma Court, Shahdara, Delhi-32

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client, Deepak Kumar Verma, son of Rajendra Prasad Verma, resident of B-45/177, Guru Nanak Pura, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi-110092, has disowned and debarred his daughter Anushka Verma from all his movable and immovable properties due to her misconduct. My client will not be responsible for any of her actions or transactions. Sd/- V. K. Singh (Advocate) Ch.No. D-623, Karkardooma Court, Shahdara Delhi

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EXPRESS special

US new immigration rule threatens stay of over 3 lakh Indian students on F-1 visa

Experts say rule will not only impact F-1 status but also affect optional practical training

Divya A New Delhi, July 18

OVER THREE lakh Indian students studying in the US on F-1 visa are set to be affected by the new regulation of the Department of Homeland Security (DHS), which mandates that they transition to the new system “automatically” and have their “authorised stay capped at a maximum of four years”. Experts point out that there is still a lack of clarity, and processes will become clearer once the rules become applicable in mid-September. However, they say the new rule may complicate matters for existing students. This rule fundamentally changes how international students maintain lawful status in the US, says Bangalore-based Sukanya Raman, US Immigration Advisor at the law firm, Immigration Desk. “Instead of remaining in F-1 visa status for as long as they comply with their academic programme, students now face fixed admission deadlines and must file for an extension of stay to complete longer degrees,” she says. The DHS on Thursday announced a rule that eliminates “duration of status (D/S)” — a provision that allowed foreign students, exchange visitors and media representatives to extend their stay without being subject to additional screening. International students in the

US are largely on F-1 visas. Holders of F (student visa) and J (exchange visitor) visas can remain in the US for as long as they maintain their student status; their stay is marked as “D/S”. If they need more time to complete a programme, they can request their educational institution to extend the duration of their stay. However, the new rule demands that students be admitted for a fixed period matching the length of their academic programme, with a maximum initial admission of four years. Those who take longer to complete their degrees have to formally petition the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) for an extension of stay. The post-graduation grace period to prepare to depart the US or apply for a status change has also been halved from 60 days to 30 days. As of January 2025, there were about 300,000 Indian students in the US, mostly in graduate (Master’s) programmes in STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics) fields. According to the US State Department report, in 2024, 90,129 Indians obtained F visas. The US government claims that this shift restores integrity to the nation’s immigration system, combats rampant visa abuse, and strengthens national security through regular vetting. Experts say the new rule will not only impact the F-1 status but also affect other related issues such as optional practical training (OPT). For F-1 students, the duration of stay has been considered as the time the individual took to complete their academic programme and any post-completion OPT, plus a 60-day grace period.

“Students will need to ensure that their underlying F-1 status remains valid throughout any period of OPT,” says Mumbai-based immigration lawyer Surabhi Singh. However, OPT itself has not been eliminated by the final rule. Students remain eligible to apply for the existing 12-month post-completion OPT, and STEM graduates may still seek the 24-month STEM OPT extension, say immigration experts, even as they add that “the interaction between the fixed admission period and OPT/STEM OPT has not yet been fully addressed in the final rule”. There is no indication yet that students will be required to depart the US and re-enter in order to apply for OPT, Singh says, adding that the existing framework governing OPT applications has not been amended and students should continue to be able to apply for OPT from within the US while maintaining valid F1 status. However, Singh says, “If the student’s fixed period of admission is due to expire before or during OPT, they may need to obtain an extension of stay or otherwise maintain valid F1 status in accordance with future DHS/USCIS guidance.” Explaining how this will likely pan out for existing international students, an immigration attorney based in New York says: “During the transition period, it appears that existing F-1s who have a pending application for post-completion OPT or STEM OPT employment authorisation when the regulation takes effect,



REKHA GUPTA

A Visionary Leader

Wishing Rekha Gupta Ji a very happy Birthday

SMT. REKHA GUPTA

Chief Minister, Delhi

From a 25-Bed Facility to Southeast Asia's Landmark: Where It All Began

DR. R.N. KALRA entered medicine in 1967, at a time when India had almost no dedicated cardiac infrastructure. Patients needing serious intervention routinely had to travel abroad. That absence — that gap between what Indian patients needed and what their country could offer — became the founding idea behind Kalra Hospital.

"The infrastructure for cardiovascular treatment in the country was practically non-existent," Dr. Kalra recalls. "Since observing cardiac patients through every minute of their treatment is decisive, they are among the most critical patients in existence. I saw an opportunity to help my own people and provide them with the best facilities. That was my key motivation."

What began as a modest 25-bed facility in Kirti Nagar, New Delhi has since grown into a full multispecialty hospital, with two additional branches — one in Dwarka Mor and another in Najafgarh— each with 50-bed capacity, running to roughly 150 beds across the group. The flagship facility hosts the region's first modular operation theatre, advanced ICUs, a drive-in casualty for rapid emergency access, a state-of-the-art cardiac catheterisation lab, and a central cardiac monitoring system that tracks patient vitals around the clock.

More than eighty percent of the hospital's staff, Dr. Kalra notes with quiet pride, have stayed on for years — carrying forward the same institutional values of accessibility and personal attention that he built from the very beginning.

What Keeps Him Going — After Seven Decades

"I start my day with meditation and gratitude to God for his benign blessings," Dr. Kalra says. "A daily walk in the park or light exercise at home is also part of my regimen. I joined the medical profession in 1967 and ever since — from my student days and internship — I have worked from 9 AM to 9 PM every day. Even today, after more than seven decades of my life, I work for sixteen hours every day. My profession is my passion. My availability, my affinity to patients, and a personal touch — these are what differentiate Kalra Hospital from the rest."

It is a statement that sounds extraordinary, but those who have worked with him say it is simply accurate.

The Pandemic: When the Doctor Became a Warrior

The test of any institution's character is what it does when the system around it breaks down. COVID-19 broke down nearly everything.

"During the peak of the pandemic, people used to call me 24x7," Dr. Kalra recalls. "I made it a point to attend every call, considering the gravity of the situa-

FOUR DECADES OF TRUST

What began as a 25-bed facility in Kirti Nagar is today one of Delhi's most respected cardiac and multispecialty institutions — built on consistency, ethics, and a personal touch that no technology can replace.



HEALING THE CAPITAL

When public ambition and private commitment work in the same direction, an entire city's health changes.

tion and the panic. Some hospitals provided beds at exorbitant rates. Some others sold oxygen cylinders at very steep prices. I adopted zero tolerance to such malpractices — I issued strict instructions that if anyone was caught indulging in any unethical act, they would be fired there and then."

For three months at a stretch, Dr. Kalra slept only two to three hours a night. "In the morning, I used to set out of the house like a warrior going to the front, telling my family that I didn't know when I would return — because the entire medical fraternity was the most vulnerable due to constant exposure to infected patients."

The hospital managed close to double its usual patient load, implemented strict COVID and non-COVID segregation protocols, applied for its own oxygen plant to reduce dependence on external supply chains, and continued running neighbourhood health camps in underserved slum clusters — offering free check-ups, medicines, and, where needed, free treatment even after the camp ended.

"The greatest challenge of all," he says quietly, "was the fact that we couldn't save everyone."

Delhi's Public Health Push — and Where Private Hospitals Fit

With CM Rekha Gupta's administration rolling out 1,139 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, digitising hospital records through HIMS, filling over 1,350 long-vacant nursing positions, and upgrading ICU and diagnostic capacity at major government hospitals like GTB, the question for private institutions is: where do they fit in this new landscape?

Dr. Kalra's answer is immediate and unambiguous.

"I think it is a welcome and necessary push. No single system — public or pri-

A Birthday Tribute — and a Conversation About the City She's Building

Delhi wakes up today to celebrate a leader who has, in a little over a year in office, moved faster on public health reform than the capital has seen in decades. **Chief Minister Smt. Rekha Gupta** turns another year older on July 19, and the most fitting tribute to her — from those who have watched Delhi's healthcare landscape transform up close — is not a garland or a felicitation, but a frank conversation about what this city's health future looks like when public ambition and private commitment work in the same direction.

Kalra Hospital, one of Delhi's most trusted cardiac and multispecialty institutions, joins thousands of Delhi residents in **wishing Chief Minister Rekha Gupta a very happy birthday**. Under her watch, the Ayushman Arogya Mandir network has begun replacing the old Mohalla Clinic model. Ayushman Bharat has finally arrived in Delhi after years of absence, government hospital ICUs are being upgraded, and a digitised hospital experience is becoming real for ordinary patients. These are not small moves. They are structural shifts — and private hospitals like Kalra have watched them with genuine admiration.

It is against this backdrop that we sat down with **Dr. R.N. Kalra** — cardiologist, Medical Director and CEO of **Kalra Hospital**, and a man who has spent over four decades building trust, one patient at a time — for a wide-ranging conversation on cardiac care, institution-building, and what it truly means to serve a city.



Dr. Ankit Kalra

Consultant - Cardiology, MBBS, MD, DNB, Director - Kalra Hospital

patients who are young.

"Lifestyle is the biggest driver," Dr. Kalra says. "Poor diet, smoking, alcohol, late nights, lack of exercise, rising obesity — all layered on top of genetic risk factors already common in our population."

His advice to the young is the same as it has always been: start living a healthy life, control diet and weight, exercise for twenty to thirty minutes daily, keep away from tobacco and any substance abuse, and get a lipid profile done annually.



Dr. Ankur Kalra (MD)

Cardiologist at the Cleveland Clinic & University professor at the Cleveland Clinic

"This is precisely where public health infrastructure and private specialist care need to work in tandem. Primary centres and awareness campaigns can catch risk factors early; we can then manage the more advanced cases with catheterisation, monitoring, and long-term follow-up."

A Family Practice, Now in Its Second Generation

Dr. Kalra has not built alone. Both of his sons have followed him into medicine and now play increasingly senior roles in the hospital group.

Dr. Ankur Kalra holds MD, FACP, FACC, and FSCAI qualifications and serves as Associate Professor of Clinical Medicine and Director for Interventional Cardiology Quality and Innovation at the Indiana Uni-



THE WARRIOR DOCTOR

When COVID-19 broke everything around him, Dr. R.N. Kalra worked three months on two hours of sleep a night. Zero tolerance for price-gouging. Zero holidays. Zero excuses.



A CITY'S HEALTH DEPENDS ON BOTH

Primary centres catch problems early. Specialists save lives when they arrive late. Delhi finally has a plan for both — and Kalra Hospital has been quietly building its end of that equation for over forty years.

versity School of Medicine in the United States — bringing international academic cardiology experience back into the institution's practice. Dr. Ankit Kalra, MD and DNB in cardiology, is similarly involved in strengthening clinical operations.

"My two sons have followed in my footsteps and are highly qualified doctors," Dr. Kalra says. "From here onwards, it is for them to take forward my dream and passion. They — along with our team of highly experienced specialists — are taking the vision and mission of Kalra Hospital to its next level of global standards."

What's Next: Robotic Surgery and the Road Ahead

The hospital's next major step on the technology front is the introduction of robotic surgery — though Dr. Kalra is characteristically measured about it.

"People are still more comfortable with conventional procedures for now, so that transition will take time and patient education," he says. "As for the government's moves to integrate large hospitals and build specialised institutes, I see that as a positive signal for the sector as a whole. It tells private players that the overall direction of health policy in Delhi is toward more integrated, higher-quality care — which is the same direction we have been building toward for over four decades."

The Defining Principle

Asked, finally, what he sees as the defining principle behind Kalra Hospital's identity after everything it has been through, Dr. Kalra does not hesitate.

"Availability. Affinity to patients. And a personal touch."

"I have worked long hours since my earliest days in this profession because I see medicine as a calling, not simply a job. More than eighty percent of our staff have been with us for years, and it is that continuity and culture of care — as much as our infrastructure — that has carried this hospital to where it is today."

His message to young doctors joining the profession is the same one he has held to himself for nearly six decades: "Be honest. Be compassionate. And success will follow."

On her birthday today, Chief Minister Smt. Rekha Gupta is building the kind of city where that message has a fighting chance of being true — for every doctor, and for every patient they serve.

Kalra Hospital operates multispecialty facilities in Kirti Nagar, Dwarka Mor, and Najafgarh, New Delhi, under the leadership of Dr. R.N. Kalra, Dr. Ankur Kalra, and Dr. Ankit Kalra.

No House panel meet on higher education Bill, govt focus on women quota law, delimitation Bill

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 18

A MEETING of the Joint Committee of Parliament on the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025, aimed at restructuring the higher education sector, scheduled for Monday has been cancelled.

This comes a day after the BJP-led NDA government decided to put the contentious 130th Constitution Amendment Bill, which seeks to remove ministers arrested for serious offences for 30 consecutive days, on the back burner to muster up numbers for rolling out the women's reservation law and delimitation Bill. On Monday, the Joint Committee was supposed to adopt its final report on the VBSA Bill, which has drawn criticism from multiple quarters, including allies in the NDA.

However, a communication to its members Saturday said, "Members are informed that the sitting of the Joint Committee on the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025, scheduled to be held on 20.07.2026 (Monday) from 1000 hrs onwards for Consideration and adoption of the draft report on the Viksit Bharat

Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025, stands cancelled. The date of the next sitting will be intimated in due course."

Taking a dig at the Narendra Modi government after the development, Congress's communication in-charge Jairam Ramesh said, "Just two days before the Monsoon Session of Parliament begins, two JPCs on very controversial Bills — one of which requires Constitutional amendments and the other of which is a clear case Constitutional overreach — have put off adopting their reports. The humiliation suffered by the Modi Govt in the Lok Sabha on April 17, 2026 clearly has cast a long shadow that persists in spite of the Union Home Minister's bluff, brag, and bluster."

TMC MP Sagarika Ghose, who is on the 31-member panel, termed the development "a big win for the Opposition". Ghose wrote on X, "Unprecedented. Was looking through the parliamentary record and could not find any instances of any other Bills which after reaching the 'Clause by Clause' deliberation stage were then placed on the back burner as has happened with two Bills now... The NDA



A joint committee examining the contentious 130th Constitution Amendment Bill on Friday deferred adopting the report ahead of the Monsoon Session of the Parliament. FILE

coalition is creaking. Ally trouble for Shri Narendra Modi & Shri Amit Shah. No wonder the desperate search for 'rebel' MPs."

Earlier, the Joint Committee meeting scheduled for Friday (July 17) was also deferred as the TDP-ruled Andhra Pradesh government had raised objections to some clauses in the proposed legislation. The 31-member panel is chaired by BJP MP D Purandareswari. The Madhya Pradesh government had also raised concerns over some of the clauses in the Bill, sources said.

The VBSA Bill seeks to form a higher education commission merging the University Grants Commission (UGC), the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) and the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE). The Opposition had objected to the proposal, calling it an "excessive centralisation of higher education".

Members of the Congress and the DMK, besides several universities, have objected to provisions in the Bill which they say grants the Centre sweeping

powers to override policy disagreements with state governments and undermines the autonomy of the state institutions and universities. With the Opposition as well as some allies in the NDA expressing strong reservations against the proposed Bill, the Central government is not keen to push it without bringing multiple stakeholders on board, sources said.

"The government wants to keep the contentious Bills on hold for the time being as it is keen to gather support and numbers for the smooth clearance of the 131st Constitution Amendment Bill for implementing the women's reservation law and the delimitation Bill. Its priority is the Bills which were defeated in the April session," said a senior BJP MP. Party leaders said securing a two-thirds majority for the women's quota law and delimitation Bill is the "top priority" for the government; it does not want to push contentious issues and upset the regional and smaller parties.

On Friday, the Joint Committee of Parliament examining the 130th Constitution Amendment bill, also expected to adopt its

final report, deferred the move apparently to hold wider consultations on contentious clauses. Its chairperson, BJP's Aparajita Sarangi, is learnt to have agreed to get the Opposition on board for adopting the report unanimously. The Opposition, which had boycotted the House panel meeting, opposed the Bill saying its provisions are undemocratic, anti-federal and contradict the bedrock principle of natural justice by punishing public representatives purely based on custody rather than conviction.

The BJP has been in discussions with non-Congress Opposition parties, including the DMK and the NCP(SP), to manage the required majority for passing the women quota law and delimitation Bill. Since the defeat of the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill in the Lok Sabha in the April session, 37 Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs from Opposition parties have defected to the BJP — making it the largest floor-crossing from the Opposition to the Treasury side in Parliament since the enactment of the anti-defection law in 1985.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Ready to quit in an hour if rebels return to Didi, says TMC MP

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, July 18

FOR THE first time since a wave of defections and dissidence hit the TMC after its defeat in the West Bengal Assembly polls two months ago, party national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Saturday dared the rebels to return to the party fold, saying he would resign from all posts within an hour of them doing so.

Abhishek, being blamed by the rebels and the turncoats for everything that is wrong with the party — alleged corruption and poll strategy — said, "Those who left the party and are now abusing or blaming me today, I challenge them to return to Didi (TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee). If they do so, I will resign from my party posts within one hour... But they will not do that. They have already struck a deal with the BJP. The arrangement is simple: leave the party, join the rebel camp or the BJP, seek protection from the ED, CBI, and other investigating agencies, and then start blaming and abusing Abhishek Banerjee."

With a month of the TMC's defeat in the Assembly polls, the Mamata Banerjee-led party, which had been in power for 15 years, suffered a series of rebellions — first with 60 of its 80 MLAs breaking away under Ritabrata Banerjee and claiming to be the "real TMC", and then with 20 Lok Sabha MPs merging with a little-known outfit, Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and backing the ruling BJP-led NDA at the Centre.



TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee

Four Rajya Sabha MPs have since quit, with three being re-nominated to the Upper House by the BJP in the bypolls.

A majority of the rebels, including Mamata's closest and oldest aide Madan Mitra, have blamed her nephew, Abhishek, for their decision. The rebel camp has also laid claim to the party symbol and bank accounts, stating that it is the "real TMC" before the ECL, a claim the Mamata camp is fiercely resisting. Referring to Mitra's exit a day after his wife and sons were summoned by the ED in a jobs scam, Abhishek said, "I want to say something to those who leave the party the moment they receive a notice from the ED, CBI, or any investigating agency. If you have done nothing wrong, then face the probe."

"I have been summoned repeatedly by the CID and other agencies. There are so many FIRs against me that I have even asked the High Court to direct the DGP to provide me with the complete list. I have never run away. For us, protection from the ED or the CBI is not important. The only protection that

matters is the trust and support of the people..." he said.

Asserting that he was ready to take responsibility for "any shortcomings", Abhishek also said that he was ready to accommodate any rebels that if they return to the party fold before July 21 — the Martyrs' Day rally to mark the 1993 police firing on Congress workers.

"I want to tell everyone who disagrees with me that people are not fools. If I receive credit for the Trinamool's victory in 2024, then I am equally ready to accept responsibility for any shortcomings. My doors remain open. Anyone who wants to return before the July 21 programme can come back, and I will ensure that they are accommodated. Those facing serious allegations should not expect political protection by changing sides, because the people will ultimately deliver the final verdict," Abhishek said.

Responding to this, Akhruzzaman, the party's chief whip in the Assembly and a leader in the rebel Ritabrata Banerjee camp, said, "We had repeatedly tried to tell Didi that she should choose between her blood relation and her dedicated workers. She chose the former, and now the damage is done."

Meanwhile, BJP leader Sukanta Majumdar said Abhishek's comment "lacked credibility". "He had thrown many such challenges before, but never acted on them... I can guarantee this: the TMC will ultimately have no one in its fold except *pishi* and *bhaipo* (aunt and nephew)."

NOTICES TO OWNERS WENT UNANSWERED: DISTRICT ADMIN

Abhishek's office demolished for 'violations', TMC plans to move HC

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 18

THE SOUTH 24 Parganas district administration on Saturday started demolishing the party office of TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee in Amtala after it was found to be constructed allegedly without an approved building plan and in violation of applicable rules, sources said.

Central forces, police, administrative officers and the fire brigade reached the site early morning and cordoned off part of the road. As the area is densely populated, police cleared the road and nearby shops and buildings to prevent untoward incidents. Three bulldozers were deployed to demolish the five-storey building, which locals said Abhishek used during events in Diamond Harbour.

District administration sources said that according to a complaint, the office was allegedly built illegally without an approved building plan. Two notices were issued on June 30 and July 7, summoning people who reportedly own the building — Amit Banerjee, Moti Mallick, and Sushanta Mandal — to appear with documents on July 15. No one allegedly turned up, sources said, prompting the demolition order. The local administration said the property was bought in the name of the company Leaps and Bounds.

As bulldozers began tearing down the structure, officers, along with police, broke open



The partially demolished office in Amtala. PTI

the locks of the gates and entered the building. "The administration has initiated proceedings strictly in accordance with the provisions of the law. Notices were served after receiving complaints regarding alleged unauthorised construction, and the matter is currently under adjudication. Any further action will be taken only after the hearing and in compliance with the relevant legal provisions," a senior South 24 Parganas district administration official said.

Reacting to this, Abhishek said that the office was built legally on purchased land after clearing all permissions and said that the TMC will move the Calcutta High Court against the demolition. "The district administration has not shared the copy of the complaints that were filed. The land was purchased, and the building was constructed ac-

cording to an approved plan. It has all the valid permissions and documents. We will place all these documents before the Calcutta High Court," the Diamond Harbour MP said.

He said that the party wrote to the Officer on Special Duty to CJJ, enclosing videos which he claimed showed BJP workers vandalising the premises during the demolition. "We will apply for an urgent hearing on this matter in the high court. We will also move the Supreme Court," Abhishek said.

Meanwhile, BJP workers celebrated on the streets and tried to enter the building, but were stopped by the local police. BJP MLA Agniswar Naskar said, "We heard the building has come up illegally and there was no building plan. The administration has decided to demolish it. We welcome the move."

NEW, SEPARATE CATEGORY

SIR Phase-3: Over 84,000 deleted for 'other' reasons in two states, one UT

Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 18

IN THE ongoing third round of the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls so far, over 84,000 electors have been deleted in two states and one UT for "other" reasons — a separate category that was not mentioned in the first two phases of the exercise. The EC did not respond to a request for comment on when the new category was rolled out and what kinds of electors are covered in it.

On May 14, the EC had announced the third phase of the SIR, to be conducted in 16 states and three UTs in stages until December this year. As per the EC schedule, draft rolls of Odisha, Mizoram, Sikkim, Manipur, Dadra and Nagar Haveli & Daman and Diu, and Uttarakhand were published in the first two weeks of July.

The press notes released by the state/UT Chief Electoral Officers show the draft electoral rolls saw a 7% decrease overall, with 32.08 lakh names being removed. While most of those deleted have been categorised as deceased, shifted/absent or enrolled at multiple places, a new category has been mentioned in Odisha, Uttarakhand and Dadra and Nagar Haveli & Daman and Diu — "others". Uttarakhand CEO BVRC Purushottam told *The Indian Express* the "others" category was rolled out in the third phase of the SIR through the BLO app, which is the EC's central app used by BLOs to process enumeration forms. "These are the electors who refused to submit or sign their enumeration forms," the CEO said.

● In a press note on July 14, the Uttarakhand CEO said that 71.33 lakh electors had made it to draft roll, or 89.51% of the pre-SIR electors. Of those deleted, 4.77 lakh were found to have shifted, 1.56 lakh absent, 1.24 lakh deceased, and 69,231 were listed as "others" (other reasons).

● In Odisha, the CEO's press note, on July 5, said that 3.13 crore electors, or 93.97% of the

● Phase-3 so far	
State/UT	% deleted
Odisha	-6.02%
Mizoram	-5.27%
Sikkim	-8%
Manipur	-7.58%
Dadra and Nagar Haveli & Daman and Diu	-29.64%
Uttarakhand	-10.38%
Total	-7.09%

pre-SIR electorate, had filled the enumeration forms and thus made it to the draft roll, while 8.32 lakh were found "deceased", 10.07 lakh "shifted/absent", 1.58 lakh "enrolled at multiple places in the electoral roll", and 14,000 of the deleted were in the "others" category.

● The UT of Dadra and Nagar Haveli & Daman and Diu also had 1,106 electors deleted in the "others" category, as per its CEO's press note on July 10.

The reason for the deletion gains significance as the EC maintains that genuine electors who have been deleted in the draft roll can be added back to the final roll during the one-month claims and objections period. The deletions followed a one-month enumeration phase in which the EC's BLOs were to go house-to-house to verify the status of all electors and get enumeration forms filled by them. Those who were found to have died, shifted, absent or enrolled elsewhere were marked as such by the BLOs and deleted in the draft roll.

While the "other" category was not used in the first phase of the SIR, which was rolled out by the EC in Bihar in June 2025, it was mentioned as a part of a different category in two UTs in the second phase that covered nine states and three UTs from October 2025. One of the categories under which Puducherry and Lakshadweep had labelled deleted voters in their draft rolls published in December last year was "shifted/absent/others". This time, Manipur has also used this category in its draft roll.

'Address fundamental issues': Mehbooba-led PDP declines Omar's Jantar Mantar invite

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 18

SAYING IT would not be in the fitness of things for the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) to "participate in a protest whose raison d'être is solely and exclusively the demand for statehood", former chief minister Mehbooba Mufti declined the National Conference's invitation to join the Jantar Mantar protest.

Mufti said an "honest and meaningful political process can only begin by addressing fundamental issues". Calling Article 370 the core issue, Mufti, in a letter to NC president Farooq Abdullah, called for convening an all-party meeting to seek the release of political prisoners and revocation of the ban on socio-political organisations, including Jamaat-e-Islami, as a first step.

"It would be a grave injustice, a disservice, and a sheer betrayal to reduce the honourable aspirations of the people of J&K to the petty, myopic, short-sighted, and detrimental demand for statehood alone," Mufti said in her letter to Abdullah. "Protesting in unison solely for statehood would only legitimise and sanitise the illegal act of revoking J&K's special status and could be viewed as a direct endorsement of August 5, the darkest day in our collective history."

The NC is planning a sit-in at Jantar Mantar on July 20, the first day of Parliament's monsoon session, to press for restoration of statehood. All NC legislators and MPs will take part in the protest. NC MP Aga Ruhullah Mehdi, however, said he had not been invited and would not



PDP president Mehbooba Mufti termed demand for restoration of statehood without focus on special status a whitewash. FILE

be part of a protest that asks for anything short of Article 370.

Mufti termed the demand for restoration of statehood without focus on special status a whitewash. "Not only does this half-hearted demand echo and legitimise the BJP's odious narrative of relegating Article 370 to the back burner, but it also risks whitewashing the illegal and unconstitutional hakirri carried out in stealth on August 5, 2019," she said. "The overwhelming mandate that the NC earned was not merely to help restore statehood. Had that been the case, the BJP and its proxies would have enjoyed far greater electoral success."

Calling J&K's special status an emotive issue, Mufti accused the NC of normalising the constitutional changes of August 5, 2019. "As Kashmir's senior-most leader, I am certain you realise not only the emotive but also the practical significance of Article 370 for our people..." Asking the National Conference to take a cue from the Ladakhi leadership, Mufti said, "We must rise above partisan politics and come together to fight for Article 370."

How Martyrs' Day shapes rebel groups' battle for TMC legacy

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 18

THE END of the 15-year Mamata Banerjee-led TMC regime in West Bengal has not only altered the state's political landscape but has also cast a shadow on the TMC's Martyrs' Day event, which the party has traditionally held on July 21 every year.

For the first time since the TMC was founded on January 1, 1998, the party stands divided into three factions, each claiming ownership of its political legacy and preparing to observe July 21 separately. Unlike previous years, none of this year's July 21 events will be held on Central Avenue in Kolkata, where Mamata organised the annual rally for nearly two decades.

The Kolkata Police has imposed prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS, 2023, across parts of central Kolkata, including the traditional venue of the Martyrs' Day rally. The order, issued by Kolkata Police commissioner and executive magistrate Ajay Nand, came

into effect on July 2 and will remain in force until August 30. Police cited intelligence inputs suggesting that multiple political programmes could trigger violence and disrupt public order.

Weeks after its Assembly poll defeat in May, the TMC witnessed its first split when over 60 of its 80 MLAs, led by LoP Ritabrata Banerjee, formed a separate bloc, claiming to be the "real TMC". The second split of the TMC took place when 20 of the party's 29 Lok Sabha MPs joined the little-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI). Later, the crisis gripping the TMC deepened further after its four Rajya Sabha MPs resigned. Three of them subsequently joined the BJP.

The TMC faction led by Mamata and her nephew Abhishek Banerjee is now referred to in state political circles as the 'Kalighat Trinamool' in a reference to the party founder's home in south Kolkata's Kalighat. The Calcutta High Court has permitted the Mamata faction to hold its event to com-



The Mamata Banerjee-led TMC organised the annual rally on July 21 in Central Avenue, Kolkata, for nearly two decades. FILE

memorate Martyrs' Day near central Kolkata's Birla Planetarium between noon and 3 pm, with a maximum of 2,500 participants. Justice Sougata Bhattacharya directed police to make adequate security arrangements.

The Ritabrata faction will organise its event on the day in front of the Gandhi statue on Mayo Road, while the state Congress will hold its pro-

gramme near Shaheed Minar. The NCPI has also announced that it will mark the Martyrs' Day, although it has yet to announce its venue.

The Ritabrata-led rebel TMC faction has instructed the district party workers to attend the Gandhi statue rally wearing specially designed badges. Senior rebel leaders, including Firdhad Hakim, Arup Biswas and Sandipan Saha, have held meet-

ings to ensure a large turnout on July 21. Abhijit Sinha is coordinating mobilisation in Birhum, while state party president Biplob Mitra is overseeing preparations in north Bengal.

Sources said a meeting was held recently at the Assembly involving MLAs aligned with the dissident camp. Later, Ritabrata held closed-door discussions with Hakim and Biswas. Sources said Hakim suggested that, besides ensuring a large turnout at their own programme, efforts should also be made to prevent district workers from attending Mamata's rally. Despite the court's permission, Mamata has expressed doubts over whether the administration will remain impartial. During a Facebook Live session, the former CM alleged that decorators and sound system operators associated with her party event could face intimidation.

"We are grateful to the court for granting permission. But I know they may intimidate the decorator and the microphone operator. I request the adminis-

tration to act impartially. We can deliver speeches without microphones if necessary. If needed, I will address the gathering standing on a rickshaw or a handcart. The meeting will take place."

For the Congress, this Martyrs' Day is an opportunity to revive its organisational strength in the state. The party has announced plans to organise its July 21 event on a much larger scale than in previous years. The party has maintained that after founding the TMC, Mamata "appropriated the legacy of that movement". In the changed political scenario, the Congress now says it intends to reclaim that legacy.

"We have been observing this day with respect for 33 years... Mamata led the movement then as a Congress leader. Later, after leaving the party, she observed Martyrs' Day under a different flag. Over time, those events became more about political power than remembering the martyrs," state Congress chief Shubhankar Sarkar said.



जल संसाधन विभाग

विकसित भारत - समृद्ध बिहार



श्री सम्राट चौधरी

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

के कर-कमलों द्वारा

बागमती-बूढ़ी गंडक रिवर लिंक योजना के अन्तर्गत बेलवा (शिवहर जिला के पिपराही प्रखंड) - मीनापुर (मुजफ्फरपुर) लिंक चैनल (बेलवाधार) निर्माण कार्य

का

उद्घाटन

अध्यक्षता

श्री विजय कुमार चौधरी

माननीय उप मुख्य (जल संसाधन) मंत्री, बिहार

मुख्य अतिथि

श्री बिजेन्द्र प्रसाद यादव

माननीय उप मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

विशिष्ट अतिथि

श्री श्रवण कुमार

माननीय मंत्री, ग्रामीण विकास, सूचना एवं जन संपर्क विभाग, बिहार-सह-प्रभारी मंत्री, शिवहर

श्रीमती श्वेता गुप्ता

माननीय मंत्री, समाज कल्याण विभाग, बिहार

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

जिले के माननीय सांसद, माननीय सदस्य, बिहार विधान मंडल एवं अन्य सम्मानित जनप्रतिनिधिगण

दिनांक : 19 जुलाई 2026

समय : 11:00 बजे पूर्वाह्न

स्थान : बेलवा, पिपराही प्रखंड, शिवहर

In India since 2014, Burundi woman with invalid visa arrested in Kutch

Brendan Dabhi
Ahmedabad, July 18

A BURUNDI woman who had been living in Gujarat for 12 years could be deported since she has overstayed her visa by several years, police officials said, adding that her passport was also found to be invalid.

Diane Niyomwungere, 36, was detained from a Vipassana centre, where she had enrolled in a programme, earlier this month in Kutch district, Special Operations Group (Kutch West) inspector AD Parmar said. She has reportedly expressed threat to her life if sent back. The Burundi national came to India on a student visa. She and her two brothers enrolled at Vadodara's Parul University in 2014.

She, however, dropped out of college in 2016-17, citing a hike in fees that year, Parmar said. "Niyomwungere and her brothers then began to work. Her student visa was valid till 2018. At the time of her detention, she was employed by a private company as a helper in Vadodara," Parmar said. "As she was undergoing some mental health issues, the firm owner asked her to spend some time at the Vipassana centre near Mandvi, Kutch. She was enrolled in a fortnight-long course."

The Centre had informed the Mandvi police station about

Niyomwungere's stay. All foreigners living in Kutch, considered a sensitive district because of the presence of an Indo-Pak border, must be reported to authorities as per the rules, the official said. When police examined her credentials as per the protocol, they found not only had her visa expired, but also her passport, the official said.

Inspector Parmar added: "Niyomwungere had applied for a new passport. But she never went back to the Burundi embassy to complete the process... Also, she has declared that she feared going back to Burundi because she claims she would be killed there. She wants to live in Canada with her mother and stepfather. She claims her father was murdered in Burundi."

Notably, police also found a refugee card issued to her allegedly by UNHCR (Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees), which is valid till 2027. Niyomwungere was questioned at the Joint Interrogation Centre on July 7. They said they did not find any adverse events associated with her during her stay in India.

"Police are in consultation with the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO) for the next steps," Inspector Parmar said, adding that "she faces deportation."

Pune civic body peon held for duping engineers of lakhs on job promise

Manoj More
Pune, July 18

A PEON working in the Pune Municipal Corporation's (PMC) education department allegedly ran a fake job racket by promising civic jobs using forged appointment letters and fake signatures of officials, the civic body and police said.

The Shivajinagar police arrested the peon, Shivanand Patil, after the PMC administration lodged an FIR on Friday. Police are searching for three other alleged accomplices in the case.

"We have arrested the peon and are searching for three others allegedly involved in the racket. We have registered an FIR and are investigating whether more people were cheated," said Police Inspector Girish Dighavakar of Shivajinagar police station.

The alleged fraud came to light after a complainant approached PMC Additional Municipal Commissioner Prajit Nair with evidence of payments made to Patil and his associates, along with fake appointment letters carrying forged stamps and signatures of civic officials.

Nair said the complainant was initially hesitant to approach police. "The complainant was reluctant to file a complaint due to personal reasons. However, we filed an FIR after examining the evidence submitted by him," he said. Nair said the PMC has so far found three cases in which candidates were allegedly promised posts of junior engineers.

One complainant was alleg-

edly cheated of Rs 45 lakh, while two others lost Rs 15 lakh and Rs 10 lakh, respectively. "We believe there could be more people who were duped in a similar manner. We hope they will come forward," Nair said. The PMC official said that when the first complainant threatened to approach the police, Patil allegedly issued cheques towards repayment of the Rs 45 lakh taken from him. However, the first cheque bounced, after which the complainant approached the civic administration.

In its complaint, the PMC alleged that Patil, along with other private individuals, cheated the complainant between May 24, 2022, and May 23, 2025, on the pretext of securing him a junior engineer's job. The PMC has suspended Patil pending a departmental inquiry. Nair said similar complaints had surfaced in the past but police cases were not filed as accused persons allegedly attempted to settle matters by promising to return the money. The complainant told *The Indian Express* that he came in contact with Patil in 2022 when he was facing financial difficulties in his business. "Patil introduced me to two other people and promised me a civic job as a junior engineer. They asked me to pay Rs 45 lakh. I borrowed the money from my father," he said.

PMC Commissioner Naval Kishore Ram said the civic body acted after receiving the complaint and lodged an FIR after conducting a preliminary inquiry. "Further probe is underway to find out whether more citizens were cheated," he said.

Reconstitute Ram temple trust as 'public trust': Nirmohi Akhara moves SC

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, July 18

THE NIRMOMHI Akhara has approached the Supreme Court seeking a direction to the Centre to reconstitute the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Theerth Kshetra Trust, which manages the affairs of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, as a "public trust".

In its application filed before the apex court, Nirmohi Akhara has sought directions declaring that the existing structure and composition of the trust as a "private trust" was inconsistent with the spirit and intent of the top court's November 2019 verdict in the Ram

Janmbhoomi-Babri Masjid land dispute case. The application has been filed in the disposed of matter in which the apex court on November 9, 2019, delivered a landmark verdict that paved the way for the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya. The 2019 verdict also directed the Centre to allot a five-acre plot to the Sunni Waqf Board for building a mosque. The Nirmohi Akhara filed the plea through Mahant Raja Ramchandracharya Ateet Guru Raghunath Das.

It has sought a direction to the Centre "to suitably recast the scheme and reconstitute the trust as a public trust."

3 minors among 9 dead in Ahmedabad factory blast

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, July 18

NINE PERSONS were killed and six others injured in a blast and fire at an illegal firecracker unit in Ramol area of Ahmedabad on Saturday, officials said.

About 15 people were inside the premises at the time of the blast and subsequent fire that took place around 3:30 pm. Police said that personnel at the camp of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) rushed to the spot after the explosion and began rescue operations before the fire brigade teams arrived.

"The RAF personnel from the nearby camp provided immediate assistance, and local police along with the AMC's fire teams reached the site and brought the fire under control," Sector-2 Joint Commissioner of Police Jaypal Singh Rathore said. The firecracker unit, set up in an open area, was operating without a valid licence.

According to a statement from the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC), the fire has been brought under control and cooling work was carried out to prevent further flare-ups.

The bodies as well as the injured persons were dispatched to two hospitals by ambulance. Dr Rakesh Joshi, Superintendent of Ahmedabad Civil Hospital, said that one woman was brought dead and five injured, including four men and one woman, remained under treatment. Of these, four persons



Rescue efforts underway after the explosion at the firecracker unit in Ramol area of Ahmedabad on Saturday. BHUPENDRA RANA

have burn injuries while one suffered from smoke inhalation.

A statement from the AMC said of the nine people taken to its LG hospital in Maninagar, four were declared dead on arrival, while four died during treatment. "All these patients were taken to the hospital with nearly 95% burns," said the AMC, which runs the hospital.

Among the dead were three children — Ravina Charan, 12, and a seven-year-old boy and a 10-year-old girl who are yet to be identified. The fourth victim was identified as Azhar Ali, 24.

LG Hospital Superintendent Leena Dabhi said the condition of the injured woman — Ramlaben Prahladbhai Dodiya, is stable.

DCP Rathore, said, "The incident occurred in the eastern area of Ahmedabad city, behind the RAF camp in the Ramol police station jurisdiction, on the

Ramol-Gatrad Road. A person named Mehul Dodiya was operating an illegal firecracker factory in an open field near the canal. The factory's licence had already been cancelled, but the factory was operational."

Rathore said the Ramol police will register a case of culpable homicide not amounting to murder and under relevant sections of the Explosives Act. Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) teams have been summoned to the site, the DCP said.

An AMC statement said, "In this incident, 1 mini fighter, 2 water bowlers (20 KL capacity), 2 Bolero Rapid Intervention Vehicles (RIV) and 1 ambulance have been deployed at the spot by the fire department. The operation was led by Chief Fire Officer Amit Dongre, 2 Additional Chief Fire Officers, 1 Deputy Chief Fire Officer, 1 Divisional Fire Officer, 1 Station Fire Of-

ficer and 1 Sub Officer."

"The exact cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained," the AMC said. Ahmedabad Mayor Hitesh Barot, Standing Committee Chairman Kamlesh Patel, and other office bearers reached the spot and took stock of the situation.

PM, CM condole deaths

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel condoled the death of people in the fire accident and announced ex-gratia to the affected people.

"Extremely saddened to hear about the loss of lives due to a mishap at a fireworks factory in Ahmedabad, Gujarat. My thoughts are with the bereaved families in this hour of grief. Praying for the speedy recovery of the injured. The local administration is providing all possible assistance to those affected. An ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh from PMNRF would be given to the next of kin of each deceased. The injured would be given Rs 50,000," PM Modi said in a post on X.

CM Patel, too, wrote on X, "The news of the tragedy at a firecracker factory in Ahmedabad is deeply saddening. I pray to God to grant peace to the souls of those who lost their lives in this accident. I extend my deepest condolences to their families... The state government will provide financial assistance of Rs 4 lakh to the families of the deceased and Rs 50,000 to the injured."

EXPRESS special

Stone Age to Sangam era, Tenkasi settlement thrived across millenia

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 18

ON THE banks of the Vaippar river in Tamil Nadu's Tenkasi district, archaeologists are slowly uncovering the story of a settlement that appears to have survived — and evolved — for thousands of years.

At Malayadipatti near Karivalamvanthanallur, where excavations have been underway since April, each trench is adding another layer to a remarkably continuous sequence of human occupation.

From tiny microlithic stone tools left behind by some of the region's earliest inhabitants to expansive Sangam-era brick structures, iron-working evidence and craft-production debris, the site is emerging as one of southern Tamil Nadu's most significant archaeological landscapes.

Unlike northern Tamil Nadu, where archaeology has established a clearer transition from the Microlithic to the Neolithic and then the Iron Age, Karivalamvanthanallur appears to follow a different trajectory. Archaeologists say the evidence points to continuous occupation from the Microlithic period through the Iron Age and into the Early Historic and Historic periods, bypassing the Neolithic or Chalcolithic phases — a cultural sequence that mirrors discoveries at sites such as Mangudi, Sivagalai and Adichanallur.

The excavation, being carried out by the Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology (TNSDA), has opened 18 trenches so far and forms part of the state's broader archaeological programme that also includes Keeladi.

The site's importance was first recognised nearly a century ago after Roman coins were reported from the region. The then Tirunelveli Deputy Collector, L A Cammiade, surveyed the area, while the Madras Museum's 1932-33 annual report documented glass beads and burial urns collected from local residents.

Those early references have now acquired fresh significance as archaeologists uncover evidence suggesting the settlement was not merely inhabited over centuries, but also functioned as a manufacturing centre.

The discoveries made so far point towards an organised in-

Microlithic tools to Early Historic brick structures found during excavation point to uninterrupted cultural sequence



The red-slipped burial pot decorated with painted peacocks found in Tamil Nadu's Tenkasi district

dustrial settlement.

Archaeologists have recovered hematite used for iron extraction, iron implements, large quantities of glass beads, terracotta figurines, graffiti-marked pottery, hopscotch pieces, black-and-red ware and ceramics associated with the Early Historic period.

A long-lived settlement

One of the excavation's most significant finds is a large brick structure measuring about 8.7 metres by 4.2 metres, built with bricks measuring 40 x 20 x 7 centimetres. The structure, which includes descending steps, is believed to have served either as an underground granary or a rainwater harvesting tank.

Its design has prompted archaeologists to consider the possibility of sophisticated water management despite the settlement's proximity to the Vaippar river. Soil analysis is expected to help determine its precise function, while carbon-dating samples have been sent to Beta Analytical Laboratory in Florida for scientific dating.

The dimensions and style of the bricks resemble those found at Keeladi, Alagankulam and Poompuhar, suggesting that the structure belongs to the Early Historic or Sangam period.

Another discovery has drawn attention because it appears to bridge archaeology

and ancient Tamil literature.

Archaeologists unearthed a red-slipped burial pot decorated with painted peacocks on its shoulder.

Molar and premolar teeth recovered outside the vessel, along with a black-and-red ware pot placed beneath it, suggest it served as a burial urn.

Researchers note that peacocks have previously been associated with burials at Porunthal and even in Harappan Cemetery-H contexts.

Similar vessels discovered at Harappa, Hulas and Bhirrana depict peacocks with recumbent human figures enclosed within their bodies, suggesting ritual significance. Sangam literature, particularly Akananuru, also refers to decorating memorial stones with peacock feathers, lending literary resonance to the archaeological evidence.

The significance

The excavation is only half-way through, but it has already yielded an expanding inventory of artefacts that reflect everyday life, craftsmanship and trade.

More than 100 artefacts have been recovered over the past three months, according to School Education and Tamil Development Minister A Rajmohan.

In a post on X, the minister said archaeologists had unearthed microlithic stone

tools, shell bangles, terracotta spindle whorls used in weaving, terracotta discs, terracotta and coral beads, a gold bead, rectangular gaming pieces, iron artefacts and copper coins. He also said excavations had revealed Sangam-era square brick structures, intact pottery, black-painted lidded vessels and perforated bowls.

Rajmohan said the structural evidence suggested that "iron tool-making, bead manufacturing, shell bangle production and weaving workshops were available in the region during the Sangam period".

The minister said the discoveries highlighted the "technological sophistication, artisanal excellence and economic vitality" of ancient Tamil society.

Expressing confidence in the excavation, Rajmohan said continued archaeological work and scientific studies would further establish "the antiquity of the Tamils before the world."

The evidence emerging from Karivalamvanthanallur increasingly suggests that this was not simply a habitation site but a specialised production centre connected to wider trade networks.

Located along an ancient route linking the eastern and western coasts, the settlement appears to have combined habitation, manufacturing and commerce over successive historical periods.

The findings also add another chapter to Tamil Nadu's growing body of archaeological evidence that has steadily reshaped understanding of the region's antiquity.

Sites such as Keeladi revived public interest after carbon dating pushed the beginning of the Sangam era further back than previously believed, while Sivagalai yielded iron implements dated to 3345 BC, among the earliest known evidence of smelted iron.

As archaeologists continue excavating the remaining trenches and undertake specialised analyses of ceramics, metals and organic samples, Karivalamvanthanallur may yet reveal how one settlement endured across millennia — its people adapting, manufacturing and leaving behind a continuous archaeological record stretching from the Stone Age to the flourishing urban culture of the Sangam age.

• BRIEFLY



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with BSF jawans at Jumagachh Border Outpost in Siliguri on Saturday. ANI

WEST BENGAL

Shah reviews BSF post security, inaugurates projects worth Rs 77 cr

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah on Saturday reviewed security arrangements along the border fencing in the sensitive national boundaries of north Bengal, as well as inaugurated development projects worth Rs 77.06 crore for the BSF. He inspected indigenous and state-of-the-art border security technologies including a radio-based fence breach detection system, which instantly alerts personnel by broadcasting pre-recorded messages whenever the fence is tampered with, the MHA said. Shah laid the foundation for three BSF projects worth Rs 47 crore, as well as for "the construction of a 4-km border fence at a cost of Rs 30 crore" on land acquired for two border outposts in Bengal — through the virtual mode. ENS

PM condoles death of Deve Gowda's wife

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi Saturday condoled the death of former prime minister H D Deve Gowda's wife, Chennamma Deve Gowda. "Deeply pained by the passing of Smt Chennamma Ji, wife of former Prime Minister Shri Deve Gowda Ji. She was admired for her humility and passion towards serving society. In this hour of grief, my thoughts are with Shri Deve Gowda Ji and his family. Om Shanti," he wrote on X. Chennamma died on Saturday after suffering massive cardiac arrest at a private hospital in Bengaluru. She was 89. PTI

NCB seizes 5kg heroin from near Jammu LoC

NCB SEIZED 5 kg high-grade heroin near the LoC in J&K's Poonch Saturday. Estimating the international market value of the seized narcotics at Rs 25 crore, officers said a person suspected to be involved in heroin smuggling from across the LoC has also been arrested. The seizure followed a planned operation at a forward Kalsiyani village in Poonch's Haveli tehsil, officers said, adding that the seized heroin was meant for further supply into the hinterland. Investigations to identify its intended recipients are underway, officers said. ENS

Sleeping pills, venomous krait, Rs 20L cover: Wife among 4 held for murder

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 18

ATUL PANWAR (35) and his wife, Damini (30), had built a modest life together in Meerut's Hastinapur. They married for love in 2019 and had a six-year-old son.

For the past four months, the family had been living in a rented house in J Block Colony. They opened a private school in April, hoping to establish a livelihood.

On Friday morning, Atul was found dead.

Damini, police said, told neighbours he had been bitten by a snake while he was asleep. She claimed she found him motionless when she went into the room to serve him tea. His body bore bite marks on his hands and legs.

By then, local residents had gathered at the house and, police said, several reported seeing a snake in the room. Damini told police that because of the summer heat, she and their son had slept outside while Atul slept in the room.

Atul was rushed to the Community Health Centre in Hastinapur, where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

The case might have ended there as another accidental snakebite death. Instead, a series of questions raised by the victim's family set police on a path that would expose a far more chilling story involving Atul's wife, her alleged lover, two snake charmers and a Rs 20 lakh life insurance policy.

Police said Atul's family took his body to their village in Bhandora, Meerut, for the last rites. His father, however, was suspicious and insisted on a post-mortem examination despite Damini's objections.

Police then sent the body for an autopsy and began reconstructing the events leading up to Atul's death. They analysed phone records and interviewed people close to the family, and found that Damini had been in frequent contact with Tushar alias Nikky (35), the driver employed at the school.

When confronted with the evidence, police said, Damini broke down and allegedly admitted to plotting her husband's murder with Tushar, her alleged lover.

Four persons — Damini, Tushar, and the two snake catchers, Sonu and Uday Kumar — have been arrested in connection with the case. Additional Superintendent of Police (Meerut) Abhijeet Kumar said. According to police, on Thursday night, Damini allegedly mixed sleeping pills into Atul's milk before he went to bed. After he fell into a deep sleep, she allegedly called Tushar, who arrived at the house with Sonu and Uday and the venomous snake -- a krait -- they helped procure.

Police alleged that Sonu and Uday released the snake onto Atul's bed, allowing it to bite him. They then allegedly left the reptile on the bed to make the death appear accidental.

Tushar allegedly told police that he and Damini had been in a relationship for a long time and had conspired to kill Atul.

Police said the investigation suggests the alleged motive was Damini's affair as well as Atul's Rs 20 lakh life insurance policy. Investigators alleged that Damini and Tushar had agreed to pay Sonu and Uday Rs 5 lakh from the insurance proceeds for their role in the alleged murder. Police claimed the two snake catchers had already been paid Rs 15,000 in advance. Police further claim this was not the first attempt on Atul's life.

About 20 days before his death, police said Tushar deliberately rammed Atul's motorcycle with a car in an attempt to kill him. Atul survived the collision with minor injuries because he was wearing a helmet. When Tushar later informed Damini that the attempt had failed, she allegedly discouraged Atul from pursuing a police complaint, saying there was little point because the vehicle's registration number had not been identified.

Protests, shutdown rock Doda over man’s death in police firing



Security personnel march during a shutdown in Doda on Saturday. PTI

Arun Sharma
Jammu, July 18

THE JAMMU & Kashmir Police have constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) after the death of a local youth in an alleged police firing earlier this week triggered protests and a shutdown in Doda. The incident has also led to an "open" FIR against unnamed people.

According to the police, 30-year-old auto driver Arif Hussain from Cheeka village in Doda was fatally shot during a scuffle between police personnel and alleged cattle smugglers in the picturesque Jai Valley near Baderwah in Doda district late Thursday night. While sources claim it was a case of accidental discharge, locals are demanding an independent investigation.

An FIR has been registered against unidentified assailants for attempted murder, voluntarily causing hurt or grievous hurt to a public servant to deter them from discharging duty, assault on a public servant, theft and other offences under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

While police have not issued a detailed statement on the circumstances surrounding Hussain's death, sources said the incident occurred after police set a checkpoint following a tip-off about alleged bovine smuggling.

Around midnight, police allegedly noticed suspicious movement and questioned some people who, according to sources, attacked the team and tried to snatch their weapons. During the scuffle, a service weapon allegedly went off, injuring Hussain and three policemen. The suspects then fled, sources said.

Police said all four were taken to the Baderwah Sub-District Hospital and later referred to Government Medical College Hospital in Doda, but Hussain died on the way.

"A SIT led by the Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDPO), Baderwah, has also been constituted to look into the incident," a senior police officer told *The Indian Express*.

The shooting triggered protests and a shutdown in Doda, prompting authorities to suspend internet services in the district and neighbouring Kishtwar. Shops remained shut in Doda town and the adjoining areas of Thathri, Gandoh and Kishtwar following a bandh call by the Seerat Committee, Majlis-i-Shoura and Anjuman-i-Islamia. The bandh passed peacefully, with no incidents reported.

Hussain's body was handed to his family after a post-mortem on Friday, and he was laid to rest in Bhalla that evening.

‘Stripped and beaten up’ inside school hostel: Dalit student recalls ordeal

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, July 18

A DALIT student in Jharkhand was hospitalised after allegedly being assaulted and subjected to threats of sexual assault for nearly four hours inside a government residential school hostel over allegations of stealing a mobile phone and money.

An FIR has been registered against six students, though no arrests have been made. The incident has sparked protests against the school and hostel authorities. On July 14, some students allegedly barged into the 16-year-old youth's room while he was asleep, gagged and dragged him to another room, where he was stripped and assaulted.

"Three persons hit me with belts while others filmed it. They then rubbed salt on the wounds and hit me. They also threatened to sexually assault me," he told *The Indian Express*. A purported clip of the incident shows the student pleading with the accused while being made to strip and do push-ups and sit-ups.

He alleged the accused also

used casteist slurs during the ordeal and threatened him into silence. "They also took away my phone," the youth said. "I was silent for two days, but when I could no longer bear the pain, I called my father using someone else's phone."

The youth's family has been protesting, demanding the arrest of the accused, invocation of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, and action against the school. "My son has been subjected to casteist slurs earlier, too," his father alleged.

When contacted, the local police station in charge, M D Iffar Ahmed, said an FIR had been registered and the investigation is underway. On the demand for invoking the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, he said one of the accused students was also a Dalit, but declined to share further details, citing the ongoing investigation.

The administration has ordered the suspension of the accused, while the youth is undergoing treatment at a government hospital.

Man dies by suicide after killing wife and 3 children in Raipur

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, July 18

A 50-YEAR-OLD man was found dead by hanging after allegedly murdering his wife, son and two daughters in Raipur, police said on Saturday.

The incident is said to have occurred on Thursday in Sanjay Nagar where Sajid Ali alias Sajju lived with his family.

Before allegedly hanging himself, Sajid allegedly murdered his wife Rabia Bano, 45, son Irshad Ali, 20, and daughters Shahida Begum, 15, and Irshaba Parveen aged 12. The door of Sajid's house was locked since Thursday.

Neighbours and family alerted the police on Friday who broke open the door to find the bodies. Assistant Police Commissioner Navneet Patil told *The Indian Express* that the motive is being probed. No suicide note was left and his mobile is being checked for leads.

‘Our future is at stake’: Jauhar varsity students begin indefinite sit-in over demolition notice

Maulshree Seth
Rampur, July 18

STUDENTS OF Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Uttar Pradesh's Rampur district on Saturday launched an indefinite sit-in outside the university's main gate, demanding that the demolition order against 38 campus buildings be withdrawn and the counselling centre established by the district administration outside the campus be removed.

The protest comes days after the Rampur Development Authority (RDA) ordered the demolition of 38 out of the university's 40 buildings, alleging they were constructed without the required approvals.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, protesting students said the agitation was aimed at protecting the future of thousands studying at the university.

Mehroza Khan, a law student at the university said, "Our career and future are at stake. We have decided to stage this sit-in because we want the government to reconsider its decision to demolish the university. We would not be able to continue our studies elsewhere, especially at colleges located far away."



Students protest outside Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur on Saturday. EXPRESS

Another student said, "Our first demand is that no demolition should take place. The administration has also set up a counselling centre outside the university to facilitate admissions elsewhere. That should also be removed because we do not want to leave this university."

"The biggest thing is that we get fee concessions here. Stu-

dents from SC/ST backgrounds receive a 50 per cent concession. Students who have lost their parents also get concessions. There are professional courses like B.Pharm and D.Pharm which many of us would not be able to pursue elsewhere," they added.

Political parties stepped up their campaign over the issue. A day after the Congress raised the

matter, AIMIM held protest marches across the state against the proposed demolition.

AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi said issue was "not about Azam Khan but about safeguarding Muslims' right to higher education", alleging that the BJP and the RSS did not want Muslims to become educated. "This is not about who

built the university. The question is why they do not want Muslims to become teachers, engineers and doctors. They may have ended Azam Khan's politics and prevented his son from contesting elections, but the university will remain. Thousands of Muslim students are graduating from here, which benefits the country," Owaisi said.

Samajwadi Party Rampur MP Mohibullah Nadvi was prevented from entering the campus. After waiting outside the main gate for around 15 minutes, he said he had come carrying party chief Akhilesh Yadav's message of support but decided not to enter as it might disturb the students after speaking to the Vice-Chancellor.

The ruling alliance also weighed in, with UP minister and Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) chief Om Prakash Rajbhar taking a swipe at the Samajwadi Party. "Had the SP government intended to protect the university, it should have legally transferred the land. Instead, it allowed the university to continue without doing so, and today Azam Khan is facing the consequences," Rajbhar said.

Terror case: Court grants bail to activist Khurram Parvez

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 18

A DELHI court on Saturday granted bail to Kashmiri human rights activist Khurram Parvez in a terror case lodged against him, officials said.

Earlier, the Delhi High Court on June 10 granted him bail in another Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) case — a terror conspiracy case lodged by the NIA four and a half years after his arrest. Following this, he only had one pending case against him, in which he has been in jail. On Saturday, Sessions Judge Piltamber Dutt of Patiala House Court granted him bail in that case too, paving the way for his release. A detailed order, however, is awaited.

The HC on June 10 had also held that the prolonged period that Parvez spent in custody, along with the slow progression of the trial and his disability, justified his release, despite stringent bail curbs under the UAPA. In the second NIA case against him, he was formally arrested in 2023 while in custody.

उत्तर प्रदेश स्टेट मेडिकल फेकल्टी, लखनऊ
5, सर्वपल्ली मॉल एवेन्यू रोड, लखनऊ-226001
युवना

उत्तर प्रदेश स्टेट मेडिकल फेकल्टी से सम्बद्धता प्राप्त सहवर्द्ध और स्वास्थ्य देख रेख (केरामेडिकल) प्रशिक्षण केंद्रों को सूचित किया जाता है कि शैक्षणिक सत्र 2026-27 में NCAHP नई दिल्ली द्वारा निर्धारित 05 डिप्लोमा पाठ्यक्रम यथा डिप्लोमा ऑफ एनेस्थीसिया एण्ड ऑपरेशन थियेटर टेक्नीकॉलॉजी (D.AOTT), डिप्लोमा ऑफ रेडियोग्राफि टेक्नीकॉलॉजी (D.R.T), डिप्लोमा ऑफ डायग्नोसिस टेक्नीकॉलॉजी (D.D.T), डिप्लोमा ऑफ हेल्थ इनफार्मेशन मैनेजमेंट (D.HIM) एवं डिप्लोमा इन मेडिकल लैबोरेटरी टेक्नीकॉलॉजी (D.MLT) में ही प्रवेश मान्य होगा। उक्त डिप्लोमा पाठ्यक्रमों में प्रवेश एवं पढ़न-पाठन NCAHP, नई दिल्ली द्वारा निर्धारित मानकों, सीटों की संख्या एवं करिकुलम के अनुरूप ही किया जायेगा। उपरोक्त डिप्लोमा पाठ्यक्रमों के अतिरिक्त अन्य किसी डिप्लोमा पाठ्यक्रम में प्रवेश की अनुमति नहीं है।

महत्वपूर्ण लिंक:-
<https://ncahp.abdm.gov.in/Curriculum>
<https://ncahp.abdm.gov.in/Resources/ImpLetters/IntakeCapacity15May2026.pdf>
<https://ncahp.abdm.gov.in/Resources/ImpLetters/IntakeCapacityDHIM08June2026.pdf>
<https://ncahp.abdm.gov.in/Curriculum/DMLTCurriculum.pdf>

सचिव

OFFICE OF THE COMMISSIONER
CENTRAL GOODS & SERVICES TAX, GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
BLOCK 'C' & 'D', NEW C.G.O. COMPLEX, GST BHAWAN, NH-IV, NIT, FARIDABAD (HR)

"PENSION ADALAT"

Central GST Commissionerate Faridabad, Government of India will hold "Pension Adalat" on 24.07.2026 (Friday) at 12:00 PM for redressal of grievances of Pensioners of erstwhile Central Excise & Service Tax Commissionerate, Faridabad - I, II & CGST Commissionerate, Faridabad, If any.

Venue : Conference Hall, O/o Commissioner CGST Commissionerate Faridabad, Block - 'D' New CGO Complex, NH-IV, NIT, Faridabad.

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COMMISSIONER
(Central Goods & Services Tax, Faridabad)

Government of India
Ministry of Textiles

Appointment for the Posts of 02 Sr. Consultants & 02 Consultants For
National Technical Textiles Mission

Applications are invited for filling up following 04 contractual posts under National Technical Textiles Mission of Ministry of Textiles:

- (i) Sr. Consultant (Innovation and Start-ups)
- (ii) Sr. Consultant (Data Analytics)
- (iii) Consultant / Specialists (Scientific Research)
- (iv) Consultant (Skilling and Training)

The detailed information regarding eligibility, qualification, experience, emoluments, last date of receipt of application, etc. for submission of the applications for the above posts are available on the websites of Ministry of Textiles www.texmin.gov.in & <https://nttm.texmin.gov.in>.

Last date of application: 24th July, 2026

July, 2026
Ministry of Textiles,
New Delhi

CBC- 41101/11/0005/2627

National Highways Authority of India
(Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Government of India)

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public is hereby informed that the revised user fee rates approved by the Competent Authority that are to be charged for the use of section from km 0.340 (Design chainage) to km 22.136 (Design chainage) (length 21.796 km) of NH-248A (Rajiv Chowk to Sohna Road), w.e.f. 19.07.2026(00:00hrs) at Ghamroj Fee Plaza (Km. 13.000), Village Ghamroj, District Gurugram in the State of Haryana are as following:-

Category of Vehicles	Fee for single Journey (Rs.)	Fee for multiple (max. no of two one way) Journey within a day (Rs.)	Fee for monthly pass Valid for 50 Journey (Rs.)	Commercial Vehicles registered within the district (excluding vehicles plying under National Permit) (Rs.)
Car/ Jeep/Van or Light Motor Vehicle	135.00	200.00	4480.00	65.00
Light Commercial vehicle, Light Goods Vehicle or Mini Bus	215.00	325.00	7235.00	110.00
Bus or Truck (Two Axle)	455.00	680.00	15160.00	225.00
Three-Axle Commercial Vehicle	495.00	745.00	16540.00	250.00
Heavy Construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (ME) or Multi Axle Vehicle (MAV to Six Axles)	715.00	1070.00	23775.00	355.00
Oversized Vehicle (Seven or more Axles)	870.00	1300.00	28945.00	435.00

The rates of monthly pass applicable for local non-commercial vehicle and residents within a distance of 20 Km. from the user fee plaza for the FY 2026-27 shall be Rs. 360/- & Annual pass for non-commercial vehicle for FY 2026-27 shall be Rs. 3075/- subject to revision every year as per provisions of The National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules, 2008 and its amendments, if any.

Project Director
PIU- Rewari, Plot No.-20, Sector-32, Institutional Area, Gurgaon-122003,
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Official Website of Chief Electoral Officer, Haryana:
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Ordinary life is passe, our curated images are glowing perfection, we all pay a cost



SHIVANI SIBAL

A FRIEND I bumped into recently at a birthday party explained to me, almost apologetically, why she hadn't gone away on a summer holiday.

It was not information that required self-admonishment. She had not committed a crime. She had merely stayed home. And yet, her tone carried a faint air of failure, as though her family's summer break had somehow not been fully lived, as it hadn't been framed by smiling family photos at airports, exotic locales, and beautiful, lazy sunset meals. One of the oddest pressures of modern life is the need to produce a persuasive and consistent visual record of living well.

It is not just that we live among endless images of people having fun all the time. It is that these images now seem to suggest an increasingly narrow script for what happiness, beauty, motherhood and success are meant to look like. The modern female face, in particular, has been undergoing a curious homogenisation: the same cheekbones, the same lips, the same skin tone, the same studied glow. The range of what is called 'beautiful' appears to be shrinking, and in inverse proportion to the available interventions. Certainly, women make such choices for all sorts of reasons: vanity, fun, insecurity, boredom, hope. Every day, we make rational decisions inside an inherently irrational system. But the system remains the system.

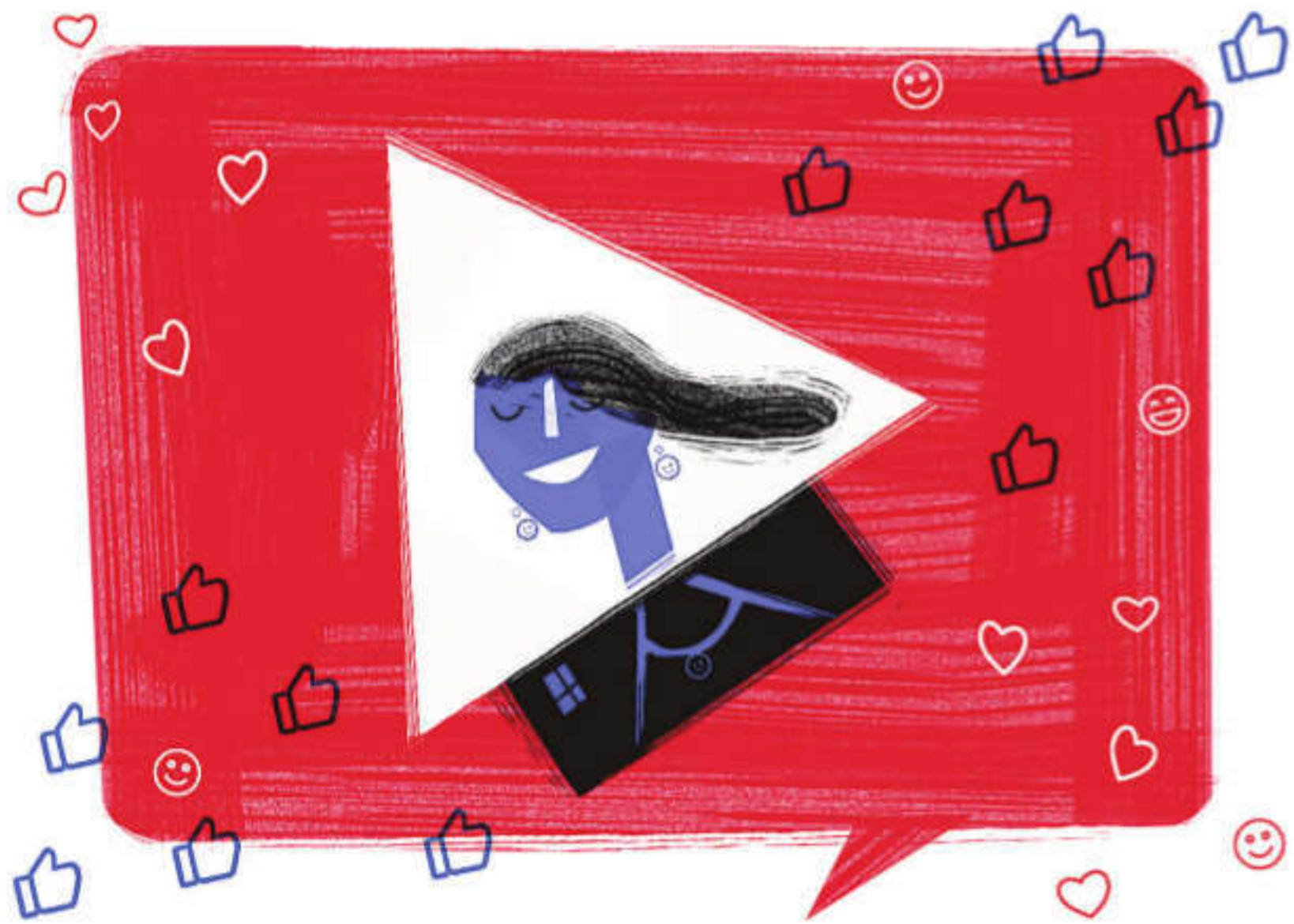


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

And if beauty has become homogenised, so too has the visual record of what it means to live a good life. We all know by now what this life is supposed to look like, because its images are delivered to us all day long. The terrifyingly wonderful summer holidays, where no one seems sick of each other, never bickering, where the children are never annoying, where the light is always perfect. The healthy lunches everyone seems to be having at, obviously, beautifully curated tables. Modern mothers, presenting as slender project managers with

glowing skin, with a Pilates-toned arm, totting a child while gazing into a laptop, then taking an older child to some genius-level chess championship, and still making it for a margarita with their girlfriends in the evening and posting an impossibly glamorous photograph — airbrushed within an inch of life — of it afterwards. Ordinary life is passe. Humblebragging is on speed.

With all of the messy bits of life wiped out, these images suggest not just glowing perfection; they suggest that it can be achieved with some kind of frictionless sor-

cery, without any apparent trade-off.

This is where modern womanhood has become particularly exhausting. We are not merely meant to cope; we are meant to make coping look easy.

What this conceals, of course, is cost.

The cost that is everywhere: In the dark circles behind the concealer, in the marriages being held together by women who have been taught from the cradle that they must "adjust", in the management of children being raised as projects, in the body forever under audit. In the constant comparisons that this curated glimpse into another's life naturally produces. In trying to keep up, in failing to keep up, in the exhaustion of checking for likes. The distance between what life looks like on the outside and what it feels like on the inside has never been greater.

There is something absurd about it, and I would have said comically so, if it were not so toxic. Modern lore sells discomfort and self-erasure as empowerment, provided it is presented stylishly enough and gathers enough approval. It reminds me of what it feels like to wear high heels: wobbling and aching while looking fabulous, insisting the whole time that it is comfortable. Women have always been asked to carry too much, but now they are denied a grimace while carrying it.

Is anyone enjoying doing this? And are they really having as much fun as they claim to? It seems unlikely to me. More likely, we have got used to keeping those high heels on all the time.

The point is not to celebrate collapse, or to sneer at beauty, effort or pleasure. It is to be more honest about the price of perfection, and more suspicious of the images that ask us to admire it.

Sibal is the author of Equations (2021)

The cockroach toolkit gang



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

TOMORROW IS the day that protesting cockroaches will march from Jantar Mantar to Parliament, so I have no choice but to write about the Cockroach Janata Party's protest. I have said before in this column that they should be heard because they are raising important issues. They are right when they say that the education system is defunct and failing our future generations. They are right to demand that the man most accountable for the mess should resign. And, if you spend an afternoon wandering about Jantar Mantar these days, you will meet many young people who speak of the despondency and defeat spreading through the ranks of young Indians. This is true in the cities, and it is true in the villages. But nobody in the exalted echelons of Lutyens Delhi seems to be listening.

This privileged enclave, in which only the most powerful Indians have always lived, is now occupied by a new class of people. They are not descended from the traditional ruling class. They despise us 'elitists' for having been born privileged. They pride themselves on being low of caste and humble of origin, so they should be able to better hear the voices of people who have been protesting in Jantar Mantar for more than two weeks. Judging from the silence of the Prime Minister and his ministers, it appears they have chosen to remain deaf and to allow their battle to be fought by their own cockroach warriors on social media.

This lot is linguistically challenged and bereft of ideas. So, they make their case by hurling accusations at the protesters. They are propped up by foreign agents. They are working with the same toolkit as the ladies of Shaheen Bagh. They support Khalistan. They are anti-national to the core. These charges reminded me of how little has changed in the Indian political discourse since I first started covering politics when Indira Gandhi was prime minister. She was so obsessed with the 'foreign hand' (CIA) that it became a joke among foreign correspondents. Then a KGB spy master defected to the West in the nineties and revealed in his memoir that several ministers in Mrs Gandhi's cabinet and several venerable leftist editors were in the pay of the Soviet Union.

It is ironic that Narendra Modi's supporters and social media combatants are as obsessed with the 'foreign hand'. What I find curious is why our strongman prime minister is allowing these 'foreign agents' to spread across our beloved Bharat Mata with 'toolkits' in hand to destroy the great successes he has wrought in the past twelve years. The 'foreign agent' they seem to hate most is Abhijeet Dipke, who founded the Cockroach Janata Party. Number two on the hit list is Sonam Wangchuk. I pray that by the time you read this, he is still alive. I believe that fasting to death is less effective than staying alive, so I hope he breaks his fast.

If you have been following the way in which the Modi government handles dissent and dissidence, you would have noticed that the standard operating procedure is to launch a smear campaign against those who dare to dissent. The strategy appears to be that if you damage the reputation of dissidents, then whatever they say will be treated as garbage. And it will act as a warning to future dissidents. They will think twice about challenging anything that the government does because they know that if they do not end up in jail, they will end up in disgrace.

Meanwhile, what happens next? If Sonam Wangchuk is still with us, there will be a march to Parliament tomorrow, and there is every likelihood that the government will pretend it did not happen and the opposition will do its best to exalt it. Instead, would it not be a real act of nationalism for both the opposition and the government to come together and set up a parliamentary committee with the task of suggesting reforms from the primary school level to the university level? I have said it before, and I shall repeat it over and over again, that the economic reform India needs most urgently is a total restructuring and re-imagining of our education system.

A number of studies have shown that children who can only afford government schools come out barely able to count and read. How long can we allow our politicians and bureaucrats to build third-rate schools for the people while sending their own children to private schools? How long will we tolerate the ugly truth that every political leader and bureaucrat who can afford to would rather send his children to mediocre foreign universities than to the best Indian universities? How long will we allow coaching centres to replace colleges? How long will we tolerate examinations that get cancelled at the last hour because someone or other manages to corrupt them with leaked papers?

If a bi-partisan committee is set up to examine these things and bring real reforms, then the Cockroach Janata Party would have achieved something truly significant. Until then, let us pray that Sonam Wangchuk remains alive and strong enough to join the march tomorrow. He has said that if he dies, his ghost will be on this march. We do not need any more ghosts than we already have. We need political leaders brave enough to disagree and dissent against the government when it is clearly wrong.

No, no, no, it's only football. But England-Argentina history begs to differ



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY MURARI & SAPTARSHI BASAK

THE WORLD Cup might not be ours, but the Falkland Islands definitely are," was Downing Street's response after Argentina's football team unfurled a banner proclaiming "*Las Malvinas son Argentinas* (The Falkland Islands are Argentine)" upon eliminating England to reach the final.

That the outgoing Keir Starmer government felt compelled to reaffirm British sovereignty over the archipelago off the coast of Argentina, and that the PM himself has urged FIFA to investigate the players who displayed the banner, are enough to illustrate how England versus Argentina has long been a proxy for unresolved questions of territory, nationalism, and historical memory.

It wasn't always like this. Football arrived in Argentina in the 19th century with British immigrants, and the Scottish schoolmaster Alexander Watson Hutton is widely regarded as the "Father of Argentine football".

Even when the two sides met in their 1966 World Cup quarter-final — where Argentina captain Antonio Rattín refused to leave the pitch for six minutes after being sent off, sitting in protest on a red carpet for Queen Elizabeth II, before England manager Alf Ramsey branded the Argentine players "animals" — the rivalry was a footballing one. That changed for good, 16 years later.

The Falkland Islands have been under



continuous British administration since 1833, though the roots of the enmity stretch further back to the British invasions of Buenos Aires in the early 19th century. Argentina has long claimed that it inherited the islands' sovereignty from Spain after independence.

In 1982, military dictator Leopoldo Galtieri's decision to invade the islands — to shore up domestic support amid economic turmoil — ended in a British victory under Margaret Thatcher, hastening the dictatorship's collapse and Argentina's return to democracy. But the "*Malvinas*" remained deeply embedded in Argentina's national consciousness. Every football match against England thereafter was played under the shadow of a war neither side had left behind.

If the Falklands War gave the rivalry its political charge, the next meeting gave it its mythology. In the 1986 World Cup quarter-

Argentina players celebrate their victory over England in the 2026 FIFA World Cup semifinal in Atlanta

final, Diego Maradona produced two of the most famous goals in football history within the space of four minutes. The first was the infamous "Hand of God", and the second, a solo run shredding through half the England team. Argentina won 2-1 before going on to lift the World Cup, and Maradona himself described the victory in his autobiography as a symbolic "revenge" for 1982, noting that his team knew Argentine soldiers had died in the conflict, "shot down like little birds".

And if the 1986 meeting had a hero, the next World Cup encounter in 1998 found the villain. David Beckham, sent off for kicking Diego Simeone after the Argentine provocatively touched his head while he lay on the ground, became the scapegoat for England's penalty shootout defeat. It didn't take him long to find redemption when he scored the winning penalty in England's 1-0 victory

over Argentina at the 2002 World Cup.

All that brings us to Atlanta 2026.

In London, Nigel Farage called for the Royal Navy to be readied; in Buenos Aires, Vice-President Victoria Villarruel branded the English "usurping pirates", invoking a viral anthem that binds the "*Malvinas*" to Maradona and Messi. The diplomatic temperature had already risen when Argentina formally protested the movements of British warship *HMS Medway* earlier this month.

The drama has also reached the Premier League, where many of the Argentine players holding that banner share dressing rooms with their English counterparts, such as Enzo Fernández with Reece James and Trevoh Chalobah at Chelsea. But when Chelsea celebrated Fernández's 85th-minute equaliser on social media, a fierce backlash prompted the club to delete the post.

A former foreign-policy aide to Thatcher has called for the UK work visas of every Argentine EPL player involved in the banner display to be revoked. Even during the 74-day Falklands War, Tottenham's Ossie Ardiles and Ricky Villa faced hostile chants, but no calls for exclusion from English football.

As football historian Jonathan Wilson has observed, the rivalry is a "strange, quasi-Oedipal relationship that manifests itself in football". Some have tried to cool it down. Minutes after the final whistle, Argentine President Javier Milei insisted the victory was "just a football match". Even before kick-off, Argentina manager Lionel Scaloni declared it was "a football game and that is all".

Forty years earlier, Maradona had offered almost exactly the same reassurance. Confronted by reporters seeking to link football to the Falklands, he replied: "No, no, no. It's only football." History begs to differ.

Murari is Senior Assistant Editor and Basak is Deputy Copy Editor, The Indian Express

What my mid-life identity shift looked like



SHE SAID
BY KARISHMA S KAUSHIK

I WOKE UP thinking of the evening that had been. A farmhouse party with friends, that is, my husband's friends and their partners. An early start to the evening. A riverside sunset with a glass of kokum sherbet. Splash time in the pool and table tennis. Delicious snacks passed around. Followed by dinner.

It had, in many ways, been familiar. I had known these friends for years. We had met on many occasions. Evenings had played out similarly. And yet, this one felt different.

I retraced the moments in my head.

Dressing up at home, I looked forward to the evening. In just a few hours, I was dangling my legs over a stream. Soon after, I jumped into the pool; getting into my swimwear needed no coaxing. When a song I liked played, I found myself doing a 'little jig', unbeknownst to how it looked or who was looking. I joined in for a game of table tennis. When my topspin was on point, my cheers were boisterous. When I missed a sitter, the jeers got me laughing.

The evening felt light. I felt content. But what exactly had been different?

For as long as I can remember, I have always been passionate about my academic and professional life. Over nearly two decades, I have built and straddled many professional identities — doctor, scientist, educator, leader — and for each role and opportunity, I have given it my all. At each stage, the circle of people I interacted with consisted almost entirely of other doctors, scientists, and educators. I did wear personal hats such as mother, wife, and daughter, but even with those, my professional identities loomed large and dominant.

Consequently, when planted in social settings, such as an evening with friends, I would find myself without my moorings. Very quickly, and no sooner after the initial pleasantries, I found myself struggling to make small talk. What do I talk about, if not medicine or science? I found it hard to go along with the flow of the evening. How could I just 'be' without my professional

identity? When a new acquaintance asked, "What do you do?" or an old friend enquired, "How is work going?", it would bring forth a mix of relief and anxiety. I could finally bring the conversation to my comfort zone, my work, yet soon after, my mind would be ablaze with conflicting thoughts: what would they be thinking about what I said? Did I speak too much about my work?

Then, a little over a year ago, I decided to quit full-time employment, write a book for girls in science, and start my own medical and scientific consultancy practice. What this meant almost immediately was that I started spending more time at home. My days involved writing my book and building my consultancy, but also planning meals with more attention and prepping breakfasts. As the days chugged on, I became a 'more present' parent and partner. Long conversations with my teenage son. Interesting coffee concoctions — with my husband. A year in, I was a renewed person. Rekindled connections with old friends (from school

While my career had given me a deep sense of purpose and direction, it, over the years, had become my dominant identity. So much so that I struggled to draw out the 'person' I was in social and casual settings

and college, that is). Gym time, not merely to keep the scales in check, but also to genuinely care for myself. Instagram. Reading. And all this while my book was published, and I signed on a handful of consultancy projects. However, I noticed — both in the way I viewed and approached them — that my professional pursuits were now just another facet of my life.

So, what exactly had shifted?

As I reflected, I determined that the 'shift' was in essence a rebalancing of my identities. While my career had given me a deep sense of purpose and direction, it, over the years, had become my dominant identity. So much so that I struggled to draw out the 'person' I was in social and casual settings — an effect that left me feeling lost. A quick Google search helped me understand. 'Career enmeshment' is the consequence of investing a disproportionate amount of time and energy in one's career. Among other signs of this is finding it harder to connect with people who are not a part of one's work life.

Moving on from a full-time role and not having a conventional job title had helped me undo this enmeshment. The result was that my all-dominating professional identity had shrunk back. My personal identities, and above all, the 'person' I am, had the opportunity to share space. Spending time and energy away from work meant that drawing out the 'person' in me did not need 'work'. I entered social settings as an extension of the person I was. And that is what that looked like that evening — ease, spontaneity, and that 'jig' even if the whole world was looking.

I have often introduced myself as someone who 'wears many hats ...', a tip-off to the many professional identities I have built. Yet, as I discovered at the cusp of mid-life, my biggest identity shift was a rebalancing that brought forth the 'person' within.

Kaushik is a physician and scientist
Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column

Iran executes man convicted of killing security personnel during 2022 unrest

Associated Press
Dubai, July 18

IRANIAN AUTHORITIES said Sunday they have executed a man convicted of killing a member of security forces during the 2022 nationwide protests that erupted after the death of a woman in custody of the country's morality police.

Authorities said the fatal shooting took place during unrest in Tehran, where protesters blocked roads and clashed with security forces.

They said Aref Khoshkar was armed with a pellet gun and fired at security personnel, wounding Salman Amirahmadi, who later died in a hospital. According to the authorities, Khoshkar confessed that he fired the gun from the roof of a house and threw it in a trash bin.

The execution is the latest reported in connection with the 2022 protests, which had spread after Mahsa Amini, a 22-year-old Kurdish woman, died in police custody following her arrest for allegedly violating the country's strict dress code.

Rights groups have criticized the trials over the deaths of security forces during the protests, saying defendants were denied due process.

MOJTABA KHAMENEI SAYS US BREACHES SHOW TRUMP'S SIGNATURE IS 'WORTHLESS'

Iran strikes Gulf states, kills two US military personnel in Jordan

Jana Choukeir & Eman Abouhassira
Dubai, July 18

IRAN LAUNCHED more attacks on Washington's Gulf allies and Jordan on Saturday after a seventh straight night of US strikes on Iranian military targets, including logistics hubs, escalating the war one week after a ceasefire collapsed.

Two US military personnel in Jordan were killed on Friday as they defended against an attack by Iranian missiles and drones, the US Central Command said in a statement on Saturday.

Kuwait came under sustained attack, with a desalination plant hit and operations at Kuwait International Airport suspended due to repeated missile and drone threats.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said it had struck a US military support centre at Camp Arifjan and destroyed a radar facility at Ali Al Salem Air Base. Kuwait Petroleum Corporation later said one of its oil facilities had been hit in "repeated Iranian attacks", causing significant damage



A billboard purportedly threatening US President Donald Trump on a building in Tehran on Saturday. REUTERS

and some injuries, according to the state news agency.

Kuwait's armed forces said they had intercepted Iranian ballistic missiles and drones early on Saturday, adding that a number of firefighters and oil sector workers had been injured while responding to the attacks.

The IRGC targeted a site in

Bahrain where US combat aircraft were gathered at Sheikh Isa Air Base and an intelligence data centre, Iranian state media reported. The Guards said they had also destroyed at least two US fighter aircraft and three other aircraft during a missile and drone attack early on Saturday on the US base in Al Azraq,

Jordan, according to Iranian state TV. Reuters was not able to verify the reports.

Iran launched attacks on Saudi Arabia for the first time in about three months, according to two people familiar with the matter, triggering early warning alarms in Al-Kharj, east of the capital Riyadh, and

at Yanbu on the kingdom's Red Sea coast.

The people said one attack had targeted the Prince Sultan Airbase in Al-Kharj, which hosts US forces.

Saudi state media did not elaborate on what triggered the early warnings and the government media office did not respond to a request for comment. The IRGC made no mention of any attack on Saudi Arabia.

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres was concerned about the escalation, particularly "attacks on civilian infrastructure in Iran and across the region", his spokesperson said on Friday.

Meanwhile, Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said in a written statement on Saturday that repeated US breaches of a memorandum of understanding signed by the presidents of Iran and the US had shown that Trump's signature was "utterly worthless and devoid of credibility."

Khamenei said the United States should know that the Iranian nation and the "resistance front" had "unforgettable lessons" for it. REUTERS

8 killed, more than 60 wounded in Ukrainian drone attack on Russia

Associated Press
Moscow, July 18

EIGHT PEOPLE were killed and more than 60 others were wounded in Russia by overnight Ukrainian drone attacks, Russian officials said Saturday.

Kyiv's forces are continuing their relentless aerial campaign against energy infrastructure and military targets inside Russia, aiming to undermine Moscow's war effort and make Russians feel the consequences of the Kremlin's all-out invasion of Ukraine that is well into its fifth year. Two sprawling warehouses of Russia's major online retailer, Wildberries, were hit by Ukrainian drones overnight, according to Russian officials: one in the town of Kotovsk in the Tambov region, some 360 km from the border with Ukraine, and another one in the city of Elektrostal, about 50 km east of Moscow.

Both caught fire, but Wildberries founder Tatyana Kim said later on Saturday morning that the fire in Kotovsk has been put out. Images and footage released by Russian online outlets showed a fire raging at the Elektrostal facility, with massive plumes of smoke towering over it. A Ukrainian drone also hit an oil depot in the city of Noginsk, just north of Elektrostal, sparking a fire and prompting evacuations of a nearby maternity hospital and a residential building, according to the governor of the Moscow region, Andrei Vorobyov.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in a Telegram post on Saturday that Ukrainian long-range strikes hit two "significant logistical facil-

Russian Defence Ministry said its air defences overnight intercepted 379 Ukrainian drones over 19 Russian regions

ities in the Moscow and Tambov regions." "These facilities were used by the aggressor to supply sanctioned components for the production of drones and navigation equipment," he wrote. An oil facility was also hit, he said.

Seven night shift workers were killed at the warehouse in Kotovsk, and 25 others were wounded, Tambov regional governor Yevgeny Pervyshov said. A total of 37 people were wounded in the Moscow region, Vorobyov said, adding that one of those later died in the hospital.

In Elektrostal, drone debris also hit a kindergarten building, Vorobyov said, sparking a fire that has since been put out. In the city of Vladimir, some 180 km east of Moscow, a Ukrainian drone hit a residential building, sparking a brief fire, Vladimir governor Alexander Avdeyev said. There were no casualties, he added.

Ukrainian special operations also conducted strikes against targets in the Sea of Azov and in occupied territory, Zelenskyy said.

Overall, the Russian Defence Ministry said its air defences overnight intercepted 379 Ukrainian drones over 19 Russian regions, as well as the illegally annexed Crimea, the Sea of Azov and the Black Sea.



Floating festival

Drone view of people riding rafts and inflatable boats during the annual Drina Regatta on the Drina River near Bajina Basta, Serbia, on Saturday. The event, held for more than 30 years, attracts thousands of participants each year. REUTERS

Mount Olympus, home of ancient Greek gods, nominated for UNESCO World Heritage List

Costas Kantouris & Elena Becatoros
Litochoro, July 18

SNOW-CAPPED for much of the year, Mount Olympus, mythological home of ancient Greece's 12 Olympian gods, has captured the imagination through the millennia.

Rising to 2,918 metres from a base practically at sea level, the ancient Greeks believed the throne of Zeus, king of the gods, stood on the highest of its craggy, often mist-shrouded peaks.

Now, modern-day Greeks hope their tallest mountain will be inducted into UNESCO's World Heritage List as a mixed cultural and natural site.

The nomination is to be dis-



A statue of Alexander the Great holding Nike, the Greek goddess of victory, with Mount Olympus in the background. AP

cussed when the World Heritage Committee meets in Busan, South Korea from Sunday through July 29.

"Olympus is our life. It is the place we grew up in," said Evangelos Geroliolios, mayor of Dion-Olympus, based in Lito-

choro, the mountain's main town.

"It is the place we see every day, but at the same time, it is also a place which carries with it myth, history, biodiversity, extraordinary beauty and a very great cultural weight."

It was here that Zeus was said to have established his court after overthrowing his father, Cronus, in a 10-year war that ended the reign of the Titans. Interest in Olympus may receive another boost with the theatrical release this week of Christopher Nolan's "The Odyssey," a new adaptation of Homer's epic, in which the mountain serves as the home of Zeus and the Olympian gods who influence Odysseus' journey. AP

• BRIEFLY

GERMANY

Senior Merz ally resigns after having a surrogate baby in US



Chairman of CDU/CSU parliamentary group Jens Spahn. REUTERS

JENS SPAHN, a senior member of Germany's ruling conservatives, resigned on Saturday after having a baby born to a surrogate mother in the United States, a move at odds with his own party's opposition to surrogacy, according to a letter seen by Reuters. Spahn, 46, the parliamentary leader of Chancellor Friedrich Merz's Christian Democrat party and its sister Christian Social Union (CDU/CSU), drew heavy criticism after news emerged that he had become a parent with his husband through a surrogate mother. Surrogacy is prohibited in

Germany, although it is not illegal to bring up a child born of a surrogate mother outside Germany. REUTERS

NORWAY

Fire destroys 100 homes, hundreds evacuated safely

A MAJOR fire in southern Norway destroyed more than 100 homes Friday and forced hundreds of people to evacuate the area, according to police and the country's public broadcaster. The blaze started in a townhouse in the city of Drammen around 3:30 pm Friday, police said. It then spread through the area and into nearby forests. Firefighters continued their efforts Saturday morning to bring the blaze under control. AP

CHINA

At least 8 killed in landslide, rescue work on

RESCUE CREWS on Saturday raced to find survivors from a landslide in the southwestern Chinese city of Chongqing that killed at least eight people and left 34 missing. The landslide occurred in Pengshui County on Friday morning on the outer edge of the Chongqing municipality, when massive amounts of rocks and soil washed down a slope, burying more than 10 residential buildings, state broadcaster CCTV said. AP

Trump blames Canada for wildfire smoke, says he will add cost to tariffs



Smoke rises from the south flank of the Brunswick Creek wildfire near North Bend, British Columbia, Canada. REUTERS

Reuters
Ottawa, July 18

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Friday blamed Canada for wildfire smoke spreading across the United States and said he would add the "incalculable cost" of dealing with the pollution to existing tariffs on Canadian goods.

Heavy smoke from hundreds of Canadian fires enveloped a swath of the U.S. from the Midwest to the Northeast on Thursday and Friday, prompting warnings to residents to stay indoors.

Trump, who has a combative relationship with Prime Minister Mark Carney, said he would be calling the Canadian leader to find out what he planned to do about the "totally unacceptable" situation.

"We are holding Canada responsible for the fact that they are not properly maintaining their Forests ... and the United States is being unnecessarily invaded by filthy, polluted, and

unhealthy air," he said in a Truth Social post.

"This is Willful Negligence, and becoming a yearly occurrence, costing the United States Billions of Dollars, which cost of this pollution must of necessity be added to the TARIFFS Canada is currently paying."

Canada's minister of emergency management and community resilience, Eleanor Olshewski, said the government has invested C\$12 billion (\$8.56 billion) in forest sustainability and fire prevention since 2020 as the country faces increasingly drier, warmer weather.

She also cited a long history of U.S.-Canadian partnership in fighting wildfires on both sides of their border. "At this time, our first priority is protecting Canadians and keeping communities safe," Olshewski said in a statement. Climate experts say rising temperatures have led to drier timber and more wildfires in recent years in Canada, home to some of the world's largest forest landscapes.

Mali rebels ambush military's convoy, many feared killed or captured

Bamako: Militants and a separatist group ambushed a Malian army convoy in the country's hard-hit north on Saturday, resulting in the killing or capture of scores of soldiers, the rebels said.

The Malian army confirmed the attack, saying that armed groups ambushed the convoy of soldiers and their partners in the northern Gao region. It did not give further details, only saying that "a counterattack is underway." Both the regional al-Qaida affiliate JNIM and FLA, claimed responsibility for the attack in separate statements. AP

• FRANCE HAS THE LARGEST MUSLIM POPULATION IN EUROPE, AND ISLAM IS THE COUNTRY'S SECOND MOST PRACTICED RELIGION

Paris' Grand Mosque celebrates its 100th anniversary, interfaith dialogue

Nicolas Garriga
Paris, July 18

A HUNDRED years ago, Paris erected a monumental mosque to honor Muslim soldiers from French colonies who fought in World War I. It's now an integral part of the capital's bustling Latin Quarter, and as it celebrates its centenary, worshippers are reflecting on being Muslim in today's France.

The rector of the Grand Mosque of Paris sees it as a symbol of interfaith dialogue and France's diversity, but worries about religious tensions in the country linked to conflicts in the Middle East and the polarizing campaign for next year's presi-

dential election.

"It's the responsibility of everyone to see Muslims as a part of the national community," Chems-eddine Hafiz told The Associated Press.

Visitors arriving for 100th anniversary prayers Friday included people from different regions around Paris, those born in France or those who came over the decades from Algeria, Senegal and beyond. Many trace their origins to France's colonial empire.

The Paris City Hall's official tourism website lists the mosque as a top attraction, calling its ornate, carpeted prayer room a "must-see." Inspired by the Alhambra in Spain's Granada, the

mosque has a 33-meter (108-foot)-high minaret that overlooks the Seine River — complementing but not overshadowing the twin towers of nearby Notre Dame Cathedral. The mosque houses a popular tea room and hammam steam baths.

But most of all it is a place of worship and history.

French authorities wanted to honour the "blood spilled" during WWI by Muslim soldiers who died in trenches of Verdun and beyond to defend France, Hafiz said. Most came from colonies in Africa.

"When it was built, French President Gaston Doumergue made a declaration reminding us that France's diversity could



Paris' official tourism website lists the mosque as a top attraction.

only reinforce its national community," Hafiz said, calling it a "beautiful message."

"I believe the political will

and the political message have remained unchanged" since 1926, he said. "The problem lies in people's attitudes. Today, anti-

Muslim acts are still being committed against Muslims. Islam is often misunderstood, and talking about Muslims or Islam can trigger hostility."

Islam is now the second religion in France, which has the largest Muslim population in Western Europe. But the country's Muslims often struggle to gain full acceptance and face discrimination. Stigmas against Muslims worsened after deadly Islamic extremist attacks in France over the past decade. France is in the midst of a campaign for next year's presidential election so far dominated by Marine Le Pen and her far-right National Rally, which has targeted Islam and immigration.

Fatma Chouchane, a volunteer at the Grand Mosque, lamented restrictions on women wearing Muslim headscarves in French schools and some workplaces.

"I ask France to leave these people alone" and let them make their religious choices, she said. Like other worshippers at Friday's prayers, however, she focused on messages of tolerance and celebrating the mosque anniversary.

"It's a symbol, it is the Paris museum for Muslims," she said. "We must all be in solidarity."

For Ibrahim Seye, the mosque was one of the first places he visited after arriving in France from Senegal. AP

NIM, A KEY PROFITABILITY METRIC, REMAINED UNDER PRESSURE

Q1: Most pvt banks post double-digit growth, HDFC lags

•Super Saturday for bank earnings

BANK	PAT (RS CRORE)	PAT GROWTH	NII GROWTH	LOAN GROWTH	DEPOSIT GROWTH
Axis Bank	7,114	23%	8%	19%	18%
HDFC Bank	19,060	5%	7%	15%	15%
ICICI Bank	14,805	16%	13%	20%	14%
IDBI Bank	2,115	5%	10%	22%	10%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	4,123	26%	9%	15%	12%
Punjab & Sind Bank	332	23%	15%	19%	12%
Punjab National Bank	5,253	214%	2%	13%	9%
YES Bank	1,071	34%	18%	18%	14%

NOTE: ALL FIGURES ARE ON STANDALONE BASIS; NII IS NET INTEREST INCOME; ALL GROWTH NUMBERS ARE YEAR-ON-YEAR. SOURCE: EXCHANGE FILINGS

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 18

PRIVATE SECTOR lenders ICICI Bank, Axis Bank, and Kotak Mahindra Bank — three of the top-4 private banks in the country — all reported big increases in their net profit for the April-June quarter, beating analysts' estimates as their bottomlines posted double-digit increases on the back of healthy loan growth.

YES Bank, however, was the private bank which saw the sharpest profit growth of 34% as its bottomline rose to Rs 1,071 crore, driven by 18% rise in net interest income (NII) even as provisions were 39% higher from last year.

Meanwhile, HDFC Bank's performance failed to beat the consensus view, with its net profit up 5%.

All the above five private banks — as well as IDBI Bank, whose profits were also up 5%, like HDFC Bank — reported their Q1 earnings on Saturday. Among public sector lenders, Punjab National Bank reported a three-fold increase in its profit compared to last year to Rs 5,253 crore, primarily due to the year-ago period containing a Rs 5,083-crore tax provision, which had hurt profitability. In the first quarter of the current financial year, while PNB's profits rose sharply, its NII was up only 2%.

Net interest margins (NIM), a key profitability metric, remained under pressure across

banks as they continued to weather the effects of the Reserve Bank of India's 125 basis point repo rate cuts last year.

HDFC Bank

The country's biggest private lender saw its net profit for Q1 rise by just 5% to Rs 19,060 crore, with NII — the interest income going into the bank's kitty after paying out interest to all depositors — up nearly 7% at Rs 33,534 crore.

However, the bank — which has been in the news in recent months due to the abrupt resignation of part-time chair Atanu Chakraborty in March — saw its NIM continue to decline to 3.26%.

On the asset quality front, the gross and net non-performing asset (NPA) ratios rose by 2 basis points and 3 bps, respectively, from March-end to 1.17% and 0.41% as at the end of June.

The NPA ratio measures the size of a bank's bad loans — loans that have gone unpaid — as a percentage of loans it has given out.

While HDFC Bank's provisions were slightly higher in April-June compared to the previous quarter, they were substantially lower from last year when it had used a large part of the proceeds from subsidiary HDB Financial's IPO to clean and strengthen its balance sheet.

Kotak, Axis post 20%+ PAT growth

Kotak's net profit jumped

26% to Rs 4,123 crore as it beat market expectations on the back of its provisions halving from the same period last year, although NII rose only 9% to Rs 7,928 crore.

On the margin front, Kotak's NIM declined to 4.53%, down 12 bps from last year and 14 bps sequentially. Gross and net NPA ratios were up 2 bps each from March-end at 1.18% and 0.27%, respectively.

Similarly, Axis Bank also beat Street estimates as its net profit surged 23% to Rs 7,114 crore, benefiting from a sharp decline in provisions. However, despite healthy loan growth of nearly 19%, NII rose 8% to Rs 14,646 crore.

Like the others, Axis Bank's bad loan ratios were a few basis points higher at the end of June compared to the previous quarter at 1.28% (gross) and 0.39% (net). Its NIM fell by 16 bps sequentially to 3.46%.

ICICI Bank

India's second-largest private bank posted a net profit that was up 16% from last year at Rs 14,805 crore. The better-than-expected bottomline was due to provisions being nearly a third lower than a year ago, while a robust 20% loan growth helped drive a 13% increase in NII to Rs 24,384 crore.

ICICI Bank's NIM rose 4 bps sequentially to 4.36% during the quarter. Its gross and net NPA ratio increased by 2 bps sequentially to 1.38% and 0.35%, respectively.

CORE INFLATION NUMBERS SUGGEST CONSUMPTION IS SUBDUED

India's 3 inflations: Clues from prices on consumption, profits & China dependence

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 18

THIS WEEK, the government released three different measures of inflation — Consumer Price Index (CPI), Wholesale Price Index (WPI), and Producer Price Index (PPI) — for the month of June.

The common theme across all three was that prices rose at a faster rate in June compared to May on the back of higher food inflation and elevated fuel prices, thanks to the weak rains and the West Asia war.

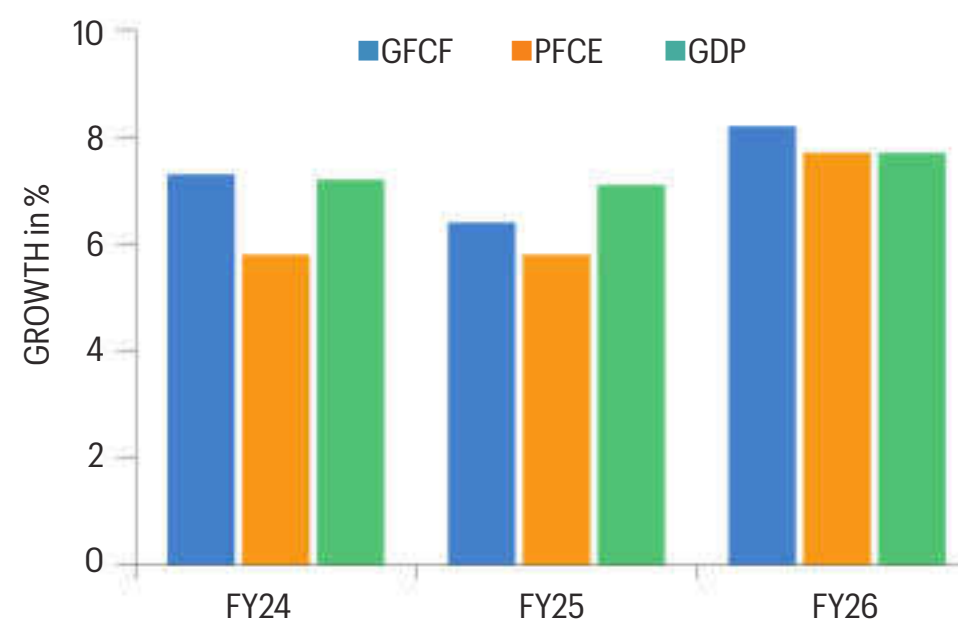
CPI inflation, which is relevant for households, rose to 4.38% from 3.93% in May; WPI inflation, which measures the year-on-year change in wholesale prices, increased to 9.87% from 9.68%; and output PPI inflation edged up to 9.57% from 9.38%. But the price situation in the country is more complex than just an increase in inflation.

Core inflation and consumption

The 4% inflation the Reserve Bank of India targets refers to headline CPI inflation. And while that crossed 4% in June for the first time in 17 months, core inflation was unchanged at 3.9%.

Core inflation measures the year-on-year change in prices for items other than food and fuel, which can be volatile. Households also

Investment growth has outpaced consumption



NOTES: GFCF IS GROSS FIXED CAPITAL FORMATION; PFCE IS PRIVATE FINAL CONSUMPTION EXPENDITURE. DATA IN CONSTANT PRICE TERMS; SOURCE: MOSPI

may not drastically change their consumption of food and fuel just because prices rose or fell — people can't give up eating and necessary travel. This is why focussing on the non-food-non-fuel portion of the CPI can provide more useful information. Economists think core inflation suggests consumption is subdued.

The most widely-used core inflation measure has risen only 20 basis points over the last six months from 3.7% in January. A narrower version of core inflation that also excludes gold and silver jewellery — precious metal prices have

rapidly risen and fallen over the last 12 months or so — has edged up to 2.5%. It was as high as 6% in early 2023.

But how did core inflation fall from 2023 to 2026 even as India recorded a world-beating 7%-plus growth? According to ANZ economists Dhiraj Nim and Sanjay Mathur, the answer may lie in what has been driving India's growth in recent years: investments.

"In the last four fiscal years, gross fixed capital formation (GFCF) growth has consistently driven GDP, outpacing private consumption growth. In other words, the productive capacity

of the economy has grown faster than consumption demand," Nim and Mathur said in a note Wednesday.

The China factor

Also pulling down India's non-food-non-fuel-non-precious metal inflation is falling prices of Chinese goods. According to ANZ, movement in Chinese producer prices is the second-most important driver of this narrow core inflation in India. With China's Producer Price Index (PPI) inflation in negative territory from October 2022 to February 2026, India has been importing 'deflation' from China.

"India's increased supply chain dependence on China means price spillovers are becoming stronger. India's goods imports from China now exceed \$130 billion annually, representing close to 3.5% of India's GDP, ranging all kinds of goods," Nim and Mathur said. The GST rate cuts and the subsequent price reductions of last year also explain why core inflation has been subdued over the better part of the last one year. However, this low base effect will vanish in a couple of months.

Dining out gets expensive

One part of core inflation which has risen sharply since the West Asia war started is prices charged by restaurants

and cafes. From 2.73% in February, restaurant and cafe inflation has risen to 6.94% in June because of higher commercial LPG prices.

With eateries passing on higher costs to diners, the second-round impact of the LPG price hikes is clearly visible, although the cut in cylinder prices earlier this month may rein it in.

Profit margin pressures

Restaurants and cafes are especially sensitive to higher costs. But the manufacturing sector has seemingly stomach the increased input prices, possibly in the face of weak consumer demand.

Consider this: the output PPI — which measures the change in prices received by producers excluding net taxes at the factory gate — for the manufacturing sector declined 0.3% in June from May. At the same time, the sector's input PPI — currently being released on an experimental basis — jumped 2.1% month-on-month in June. Is it absurd to read so much into inflation data? Perhaps not. According to DSP Mutual Fund, inflation is "by far...the cleanest indicator of the underlying strength of consumption", especially with the CPI series having been updated.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Embrace risks, seize opportunities: FM tells entrepreneurs



FM addressed entrepreneurs in Madurai. X/@NSITHARAMANOFFC

ENS Economic Bureau

New Delhi, July 18

INDIA CONTINUES to be the world's fastest-growing major economy and is well placed to contribute nearly one-sixth of global growth in the coming years, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Saturday, as she urged entrepreneurs to shed their hesitation, embrace risk and seize the opportunities created by a rapidly transforming economy. Addressing entrepreneurs at an event in Madurai, FM Sitharaman said India has moved beyond the era of self-doubt and stands at a defining moment, backed by policy stability, digital infrastructure and one of the world's youngest workforces.

"India is today the fastest-growing major economy in the world. We are projected to contribute nearly 1/6th of the global

growth over the coming years," she said, adding that the country has the potential to do even better.

"It need not just be 1/6... Why can't it be 1/4? We can do it." The Union ministers said that the biggest challenge before the current generation is no longer access to information or resources but overcoming the fear of taking the first step. "I urge young entrepreneurs to overcome any hesitation in taking risks and seize the opportunities before them," she said. "India is the place to innovate and do business, backed by a stable government, policy certainty, a predictable tax regime and a responsive, approachable government." FM said India has more than 240,000 DPIIT-recognised startups that have created over 2.3 million direct jobs, making it the world's third-largest startup ecosystem. FE

India amends tax treaty with Sri Lanka to plug avoidance

ENS Economic Bureau

New Delhi, July 18

INDIA HAS amended its tax treaty with Sri Lanka to tighten loopholes in double taxation avoidance and to curb revenue leakage by preventing treaty abuse. The intention for amending the pact has been to eliminate double taxation without creating opportunities for non-taxation or reduced taxation through tax evasion or avoidance through treaty-shopping arrangements.

The amended protocol was brought into force on June 19 this year and has now been notified by the Ministry of Finance. The provisions of the amended protocol will apply in India on income derived beginning April 1, 2027.

The amended treaty between the two countries has included the Principal Purpose Test (PPT). An anti-avoidance tool, the PPT ensures denial of benefits under a double taxation avoidance agreement (DTAA), where it is reasonable to conclude that one of the principal purposes of an arrangement or transaction was to obtain a benefit, directly or indirectly, under a treaty unless the granting of the benefit was in accordance with the object and purpose of the treaty.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Centre defers domestic solar cell sourcing mandate till December 31

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 18

ONE-AND-a-half month after implementing mandatory domestic cell sourcing mandates for all domestic, commercial and industrial solar projects, the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) on Saturday exempted these projects from the mandatory cell sourcing requirement till December 31.

In a memorandum, the ministry said the decision has been taken after detailed deliberations with various stakeholders of the solar industry to ensure a smooth transition to mandatory

domestic cell sourcing mandate. India has a large solar module manufacturing base, nearly 200 gigawatts (GW) per annum.

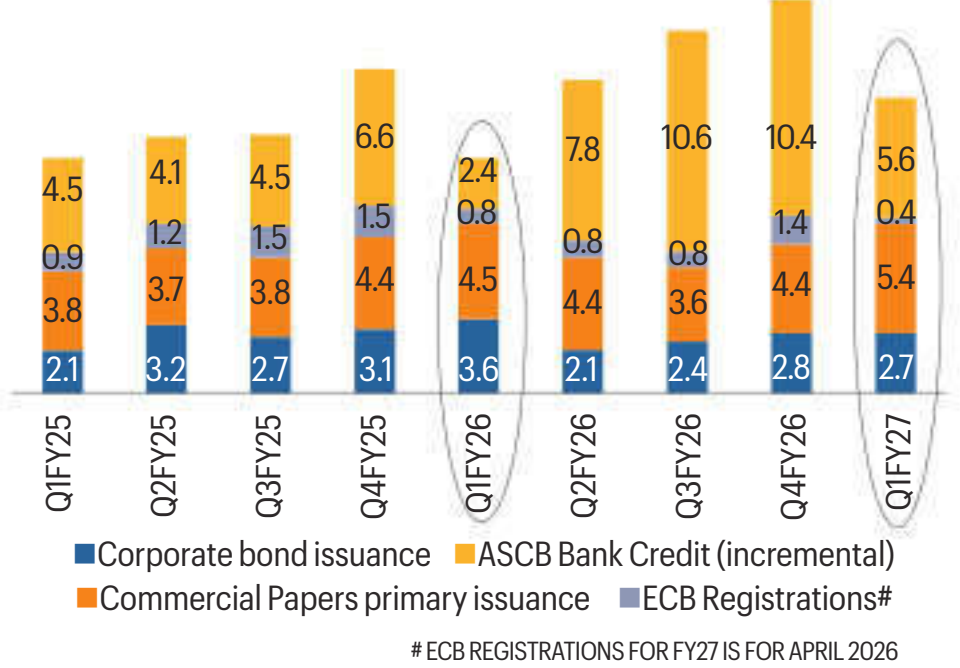
But the manufacturing capacity of cells, the primary constituents of these modules, is far lower at around 30 GW. This means much of the module manufacturing capacity has been built upon imported cells.

Even though the mandatory domestic cell sourcing mandate is aimed at reducing India's dependence on imports and strengthening the domestic solar manufacturing ecosystem, it could disproportion-

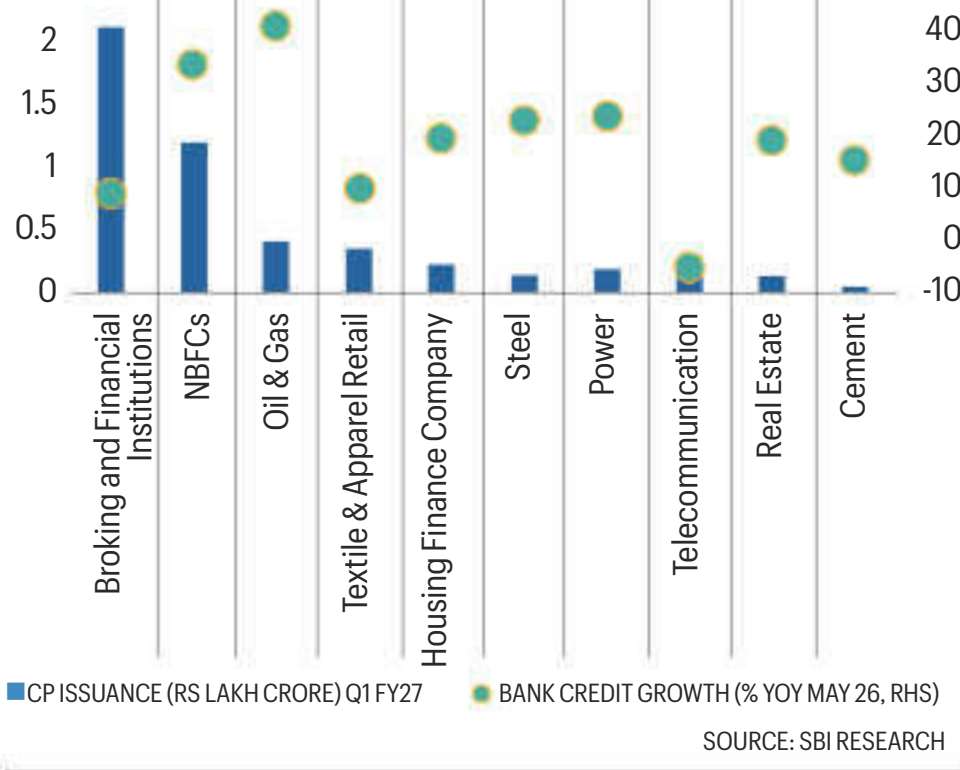
ately affect smaller solar module manufacturers which, unlike larger companies, may not manufacture their own cells. The exemption comes after the government had said on May 25 that there would be "no blanket" relief for domestic cell sourcing mandates despite developers seeking an extension of the deadline. The present exemption effectively extends the May 31 deadline to December 31, giving these projects an additional seven months to commission without complying with the mandatory domestic cell sourcing mandate. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Meaningful growth in Q1 despite headwinds

Issuances of commercial papers (CPs) by corporates soared 19% on-year in the first quarter of financial year 2027 (Q1FY27), with June issuances at 55-month high. Incremental bank credit too rose to Rs 5.6 lakh crore in Q1FY27, against Rs 2.4 lakh crore in Q1FY26, suggesting that the Indian economy has continued to expand meaningfully in Q1FY27 despite several headwinds, SBI Research said. Top sectors with higher CP issuances in Q1 have also showed higher bank credit growth.



Top 10 industries CP issuance and bank credit growth



SOURCE: SBI RESEARCH

• MALWARE ATTRIBUTED TO A NORTH KOREAN HACKING GROUP HAD BEEN DETECTED WITHIN THE PLANT'S ADMINISTRATIVE NETWORK

Data breach revives memories of 2019 cyberattack at Kudankulam

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 18

A DATA breach has exposed information linked to the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNP), India's flagship nuclear project located in Tamil Nadu's Tirunelveli district.

For nearly a month, numerous documents purportedly linked to the plant — including engineering drawings, inspection records, minutes of meetings, technical reports and official correspondence — have been circulating on the dark web after it was leaked by ransomware group World Leaks.

The Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL), which operates the plant, has downplayed the leak, maintaining that documents relate only to non-critical facilities outside the 'reactor island' and pose no risk to nuclear safety.

Yet, the breach has renewed cybersecurity concerns over India's critical and strategic infrastructure, particularly at a time when the government has begun opening up the tightly regulated civil nuclear sector to private participation.

The incident has also drawn particular attention because it is not the first time the Kudankulam plant has been linked to a cyber incident. In 2019, malware attributed to a North Korean hacking group was detected within the plant's administrative network, highlighting the persistent cyber risks facing India's strategic nuclear assets.

WHAT HAPPENED IN 2019?

The 2019 cyber incident was not confined to the KKNP. It also affected the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). The breach became public on October 28, 2019 after some of



The Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL), which operates the plant, has downplayed the recent leak. REUTERS

the plant's data showed up on virustotal.com, an online malware scanning service.

Subsequent investigations by multiple cybersecurity agencies and experts attributed the intrusion to DTrack malware, which was linked to the North Korea-backed Lazarus

Group, "an umbrella name that typically describes hacking activity which advances Pyongyang's interests".

According to cybersecurity analysts, DTrack belongs to the same family of malware that was linked to the 2016 cyberattack on an Indian private

bank's ATM network. It spread across the banking system and forced the replacement of an estimated 2.9-3.2 million compromised debit and credit cards. The DTrack malware reportedly targeted the 'domain controller' of KKNP's online network, exposing credentials such as passwords.

A domain controller is a central server that acts as the 'gatekeeper' of a network and verifies the authenticity of all the other devices on the network. Following the intrusion, Seoul-based IssueMakersLab, an expert group of malware analysts, had claimed that the attack was meant to steal information on India's thorium-based nuclear power, a technology which Indian scientists have been working on for decades. According to IssueMakersLab, the primary entry point for the cyberattack was a group

of senior Indian nuclear scientists associated with the atomic energy programme, including scientists who continued to use official institutional email accounts for research work after retirement.

It claimed that the attackers sent malware-laced links to their official and personal email accounts. It claimed that once the links were opened while connected to the Kudankulam plant's network, the malware spread through the plant's IT systems. IssueMakersLab also claimed that the attackers had prior knowledge of the plant's IP network, helping them penetrate its IT infrastructure.

LITTLE INFORMATION ON OFFICIAL FINDINGS

A day after the information about the 2019 breach became public, KKNP officials issued denials saying no cyber-attack

was possible on the plant's standalone control system. A day later, however, NPCIL admitted an intrusion and said the matter was immediately investigated by specialists from the government's Department of Atomic Energy.

In a statement, the NPCIL said the matter was conveyed by Computer Emergency Response Team-India (CERT-In) when it was noticed by them on September 4, 2019.

"The investigation revealed that the infected Personal Computer (PC) belonged to a user who was connected in the internet connected network used for administrative purposes. This is isolated from the critical internal network.

The networks were being monitored continuously. Investigation also confirms that the plant systems are not affected," the statement read.

HOW HIGH-SECURITY SETUPS WORK

Most high-security setups operate on two "air-gapped", or separate, networks. The first is a standalone control system that runs the core function — reactors in case of a nuclear power plant. The other is an online network responsible for the rest of the functions. Air-gapped networks, however, are not considered foolproof. Such systems have been compromised in the past, including at the Davis-Besse Nuclear Power Station in Ohio in 2003, and in breaches involving classified US military networks in 2008.

Beyond the NPCIL's brief acknowledgment and its emphasis on the plant's air-gapped architecture, little is available in the public domain, even today, about the findings of the investigation into the 2019 malware attack.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

	SH M KUNJO SINGH, DEPUTY COMMANDANT 27 BN BSF 12.02.1950 – 19.07.2002		CONSTABLE SACHIN SRI KHANDAKAR 27 BN BSF 27.05.1980 – 19.07.2002
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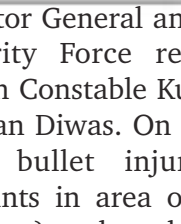
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant officer Sh M Kunjo Singh, Deputy Commandant and Constable Sachin Sri Khandakar on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in area of BOP Pahadnora, Behalabari (Tripura) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

	SH P S CHAUHAN, DEPUTY COMMANDANT 33 BN BSF 04.02.1947 – 19.07.1997		INSP TRILOCHAN SINGH 33 BN BSF 18.03.1949 – 19.07.1997
	HC BHAG CHAND 33 BN BSF 08.04.1953 – 19.07.1997		HC PARAMJEET SINGH 11 BN BSF 05.03.1956 – 19.07.1997

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant officer Sh P S Chauhan, Deputy Commandant, Subordinate officer Insp Trilochan Singh and Head Constables Bhag Chand & Paramjeet Singh on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast triggered, by militants in Bandipur area, (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

	SH VISHWA DEO, ASSISTANT COMMANDANT 59 BN BSF 09.11.1979 – 19.07.2024		HEAD CONSTABLE DAYAL RAM 59 BN BSF 05.06.1975 – 19.07.2024
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant officer Sh Vishwa Deo, Assistant Commandant and Head Constable Dayal Ram on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in Bhuj area, Gujarat.

	CONSTABLE KULWINDER SINGH 35 BN BSF 18.04.1970 – 19.07.1999		Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Kulwinder Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in area of BOP Londi, Samba (Jammu) and made ultimate sacrifice in
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the line of duty.

	LATE NK HARJINDER SINGH In proud memory of Nk Harjinder Singh of 6th Battalion The Dogra Regiment, who made the supreme sacrifice while serving the Nation at Tangdhar (J&K) on 19 Jul 2008. Your act of valour, raw courage & devotion to duty will always remain a source of inspiration and motivation to all of us. "BRAVES DIE, BUT ONLY ONCE" Remembered by Commanding Officer and All Ranks 6 DOGRA
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UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking)
Corporate Identity No. UA40109UP2001SGC025867/2358
Victoria Cross Vijayta Gabar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanwali Road, Dehradun - 248001
Telephone: (0135)-2763672-76, www.uktenders.gov.in

CORRIGENDUM TO E-TENDER NOTICE
This office e-tender specification no. CCP-II/4/2026-2027 invited previously for design, fabrication, supply, erection, testing and commissioning of 33kV D/C overhead Line using lattice towers from Sonprayag to Sri Kedarnath JI (15 Km.) on turnkey basis is hereby extended due to unavoidable reasons. The e-tender can be purchased and submitted upto 17:00 hrs of 03.08.2026. Part-I of the e-tender shall be opened on 04.08.2026 at 15:30hrs.

Other terms and conditions will remain same as per original tender notice. For further details, please visit our website www.uktenders.gov.in.

Superintending Engineer
No: S18/EE(cm)/UPCL/A-2 Dated: 18/07/2026 Corporate (Contract & Procurement-II)
SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATIONS Use LED Bulb to Save Electricity (Toll Free No. 1912)
"Pay Electricity Bill Online 24 x 7 from www.upcl.org" (For information on Electricity theft, informer may report to Toll Free No. 18001804185 / Fax No. 0135-2760911)

UJVN LIMITED

H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Letter No: 591 Date: 18/07/2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

For and on behalf of UJVN Ltd, Executive Engineer (Civil), Pashulok Barrage Rishikesh, invites sealed & separate tender from interested contractors for following work:-

1. Tender Notice Reference: NIT No. 10/2026-27/EE(C)/Pashulok Barrage:- Repair & Maintenance Works of Hathi Kunds at Power Channel of Chilla HEP.
2. Estimated Value of Tender: -Rs. 16,55,684.06 (excluding GST).
3. Date of availability of bid document on website: - 20 July, 2026 from 17:00 Hrs. (IST).
4. Last Date for Submission of Tender: -10 August, 2026 upto 14:00 Hrs. (IST).

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvnl.com"

Executive Engineer (Civil)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF URBAN MANAGEMENT (NIUM), HYDERABAD

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
EOI No.: NIUM-UP/5/2026-PH-NIUM Dt.18.07.2026
Empanelment of Individual Consultants & Subject Matter Experts (SMEs)
The National Institute of Urban Management (NIUM), Hyderabad, invites Expressions of Interest (EOI) from qualified and experienced professionals for empanelment as to provide consultancy, technical advisory, research, project management & capacity building and other professional services for urban development projects.

Interested Individual Consultants and Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) meeting the eligibility criteria may submit their applications in the prescribed format along with the required supporting documents.

Important Dates

- Last Date for Submission of Queries: 27.07.2026 up to 5 PM
- Issue of Clarifications: 29.07.2026
- Last Date for Submission of Applications: 05.08.2026 up to 5 PM

Empanelment Period: Two (2) Years (Empanelment does not guarantee the award of assignments.)

For detailed EOI, eligibility criteria, and application format, visit www.nium.org.in

For any further details Email: admin@nium.org.in

NIUM reserves the right to accept or reject any or all applications, or to modify or cancel the EOI process without assigning any reason.

Sd/-Director General

National Institute of Urban Management (NIUM)

DIPR R.O.No.R.O. No.331-PPCL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:18-07-2026

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur-302004

S. No : JDA/EE & TA to Dir. Engg.-I/2026-27/ Dated : 17.07.2026

NOTICE INVITING BID

NIB No.: EE & TA to Dir. Engg.-I/16/2026-27

Bids are invited from interested bidders for following works :-

S. No.	UBN No.	Cost of Work (Lacs)	Nature of Work	Last Date
1	JDA2627WSOB00205	256.63	Road	03.08.226
2	JDA2627WSRC00208	275.56	Patch Repair Work	03.08.226
3	JDA2627WSOB00210	269.71	Road	06.08.226

Other particulars of the respective bid may be visited on Procurement Portal website www.sppp.raajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.raajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.raajasthan.gov.in.

Executive Engineer & TA to Dir.Engg-I

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SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Follow us on @SCSRailwaysIndia
Details of the Tender/Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website: www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

Open e-Tender Notice No. Dy.CE/GS/ISC/09/2026/OT. Dt: 16-07-2026

For and on behalf of the President of India, the undersigned invites e-tender for the following works:

SI.No 1 e-Tender No. 09_GS_SC_26_OT Name of the work Appointment of project supervision services agency (PSSA) at various construction sites / sections in the jurisdiction of Gati Shakti Unit, Secunderabad Division, South Central Railway. Approx. Tender Value in Rs. 10,52,54,867.84 EMD [Rs.] 6,76,300/- Completion period in days 24 Months Works considered similar in nature towards Standard eligibility criteria. Technical Capacity shall be ascertained as per 3.2.2(1) of RFP document. Bid closing date 25-08-2026

1. Tenderers should participate through e-tendering only and no manual offers may be considered.
2. Tender conditions/other particulars are available in the Tender documents on IREPS website at ireps.gov.in which can be downloaded, can be participated and can view any modifications if any.
3. All the prospective tenderers are requested to remit EMD through online payments only.
4. The tender notice is also displayed in the Notice Board located in the office of CPM/GS/SC, Secunderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad which can be seen on all working days.
5. The Railway reserves the right to cancel the tender without assigning any reason therefor.
6. All the prospective tenderers are advised to get GSTIN identification Nos. and submit along with their offer.

Dy. Chief Engineer/Gati Shakti/Secunderabad

Tender Notice No.16/2026. Dt.17.07.2026. Supply Of Stores Items. E-Procurement Tender Notice

The Following Tenders Have Been Floated Online. Tenders Are Requested To Visit The Website www.ireps.gov.in And Submit Their Offers Online. The Tender Description, Qty, EMD, SD May Be Seen In Website. Offers Manually Will Not Accepted. Offers By Post Will Not Be Entertained. Tender Closing is 14.30 Hrs Of The Tender For All Indigenous Offers. EMD Will Be Accepted Only Via Online System as Available On www.ireps.gov.in.

Tender no.	Brief Description
LH265952	Junction Box to KBI part No. STN45004
LH265746A	Eddy Current Array Equipment
2526462A	IOH replacement kit
25262098	Pinion 16 teeth for Hitachi TM type HS 15250A
31255012B	Set of Dampers for Vande Bharat Train
LY265419	Supply installation and commissioning (Turn-key basis) of Hydraulic Dead and Buffers
43261006	Supply of Below Set made of MetaAramid
38261587	Slack Adjuster Type IRSA-600

Note: Due dates of Tender Opening
SL.No.01 on dt.22.07.2026. SL.No.02 to 04 on dt.06.08.2026. SL.No.05 on dt.10.08.2026 SL.No.06 on dt.11.08.2026 SL.No.07 on dt.13.08.2026 SL.No.08 on dt.17.08.2026

Beside Above Mentioned Tenders There Are Other Tenders Having Value Above Rs. 50 Lakhs for details Please Visit Railway Webs

Principal Chief Materials Manager/ A558 Secunderabad

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

INF-914-26-27

Chief Executive Officer Development Support Agency of Gujarat Gandhinagar

INF-914-26-27

Chief Executive Officer Development Support Agency of Gujarat Gandhinagar

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WESTERN RAILWAY

Design, Supply, Erection, Testing AND COMMISSIONING WORK

Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer (Construction), Western Railway, 1st floor Station Building, Room No. 165, Churchgate, Mumbai 400 020 invites
E-Tender No: EL-92-12-C-CG-2026-27-01
Name of Work: Design, Supply, Erection, testing and commissioning of 25 KV AC-OHE and modification of TSS/SP/SSP of Harbour Line between Goregaon and Borivali (TRD/PSI Work) under Mumbai Division of Western Railway. NIT Cost: ₹ 19,48,82,072/- EMD: ₹ 38,97,700/- E-Bid Submission Closing: On 28.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. E-Bid Opening Date: On 28.07.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. For further details please visit our website www.ireps.gov.in

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BRIDGE

End-play or throw-in is an elegant play which forces a defender to open a suit at a time which will be detrimental to defenders and helpful to declarer. Obviously to effect an end-play, declarer should be able to have a card by which he can throw-in the defender of choice. It is easy to throw away the throw-in card, unless declarer is alert to the possibilities of a throw-in. Dealer: North Vulnerable: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ Q 5 3 2		♠ J 9	
♥ J		♥ A Q 8 2	
♦ A K J 9		♦ 7 4 3 2	
♣ A J 7 5		♣ K Q 3	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
-	-	1♦	pass
1♥	pass	1♠	pass
2NT	pass	3NT	pass
pass	pass		

West leads the seven of spades to East's ace. East returns the four of spades to West's king. West continues with the spade ten; East discards the three of hearts. Plan the play. It was all a matter of throw in at no trumps,

THE WEST HAND: ♠ K Q 10 8 7 6 ♥ K 6 4 ♦ 5 ♣ 9 8 6 2
THE EAST HAND: ♠ A 4 ♥ 10 9 7 5 3 ♦ Q 10 8 6 ♠ 10 4

Counting the queen of spades, South has eight sure winners. The best play for the ninth trick is in the diamond suit; declarer should cash one of dummy's high diamonds (guarding against a singleton queen), lead to the closed hand with a club, and play a second diamond towards dummy. If West follows to the second diamond lead, South can make the contract by finessing into the East hand. When West shows out on the second diamond lead, South must change plans: go up with the remaining high diamond in dummy, cash, then endplay West by leading dummy's remaining spade. West can cash the rest of the spades, but then must give South the last two tricks by leading into the major heart tenace. To keep this endplay in sight, declarer must win dummy's queen of spades at trick three. Another problem on dummy play. Dealer: North Vulnerable: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ A K J 10		♠ 6 5 4	
♥ 9 7 5 3		♥ A K J 10 8 6 4	
♦ K		♦	
♣ 7 5 3 2		♣ K 6 4	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
-	-	pass	pass
4H	pass	pass	pass

Diamond ace, king, seven, ?. Plan the play.

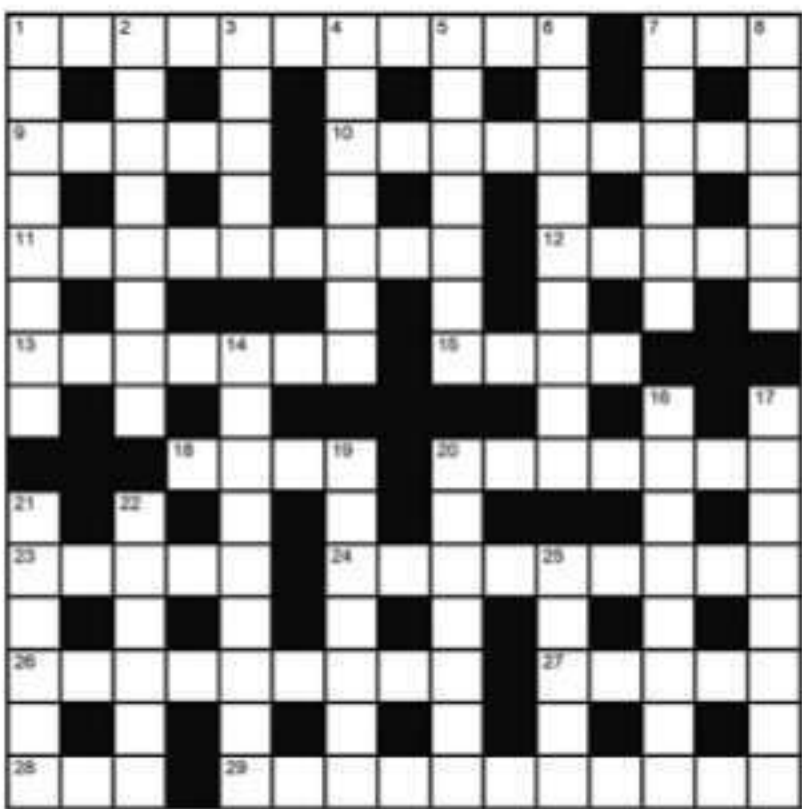
• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
1. Curative (11)
7. Young bear (3)
9. Of sound, hearing (5)
10. Ignorant (9)
11. List of investments (9)
12. Set Fire To The Rain singer (5)
13. Elate (7)
15. Treat lavishly (4)
18. Not of the clergy (4)
20. A cocktail of gin and vermouth (7)
23. Was compelled (3,2)
24. Undoing (9)
26. Pirate (9)
27. Anatomical sacs (5)
28. Call for help (3)
29. Visage (11)

DOWN

1. This is used to stir a beverage (8)
2. Plumped for (8)
3. Cool and distant (5)
4. To the same degree (7)
5. Berate (4,3)
6. Nature (9)
7. Burnt-out coal (6)
8. A mammal; hairy (6)
14. French martyr (9)
16. Part of a whole, a section (8)
17. Misdirect (8)
19. The French mansion (7)
20. Mosque spire (7)
21. Moon of Mars (6)
22. Decrees (6)
25. First name in country music (5)



CRYPTIC CLUES

- ACROSS**
1. King once made poor student an award (6,5)
7. If I bring inside information, lie (3)
9. Delia's perfect form (5)
10. Litre spilled in measure to purify (9)
11. Clarity from occasionally loud police department head (9)
12. Builder regularly ignored bad knee in his address (5)
13. Male and female within reach possible - it's groovy! (7)
15. Man for burning, did you say? (4)
18. Smart fellow the French take into

account (4)

20. Half bite very rotten veal and oyster? (7)
23. Getting even with a rival (5)
24. One fearing aliens vandalised phone box at Middle Creek (9)
26. Sprinkle liberally over one topping for a pizza (9)
27. Quietly increase force (5)
28. Killer did lose heart and got cross (3)
29. Badly made beds please a much admired young man (4,7)

DOWN

1. Network close to snarl-up (8)

SOLUTIONS TO 2590 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Moving, 4 Stand pat, 9 Nepal, 10 Three days, 11 Rare, 12 Skit, 13 Drive, 15 Hangman, 16 Town, 19 Undo, 20 Tel Aviv, 23 Siege, 24 Apex, 25 Scar, 27 Acoustics, 28 Oriya, 29 Stressed, 30 Google **DOWN:** 1 Monarchy, 2 Viperine, 3 Null, 5 Torn to tatters, 6 Ne'er-do-well, 7 Placid, 8 Tosses, 10 Taken for a ride, 14 Amanuensis, 17 Evicting, 18 Overcame, 21 Essays, 22 Deavour, 26 Como **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Buckle, 4 Stick out, 9 R E Lee, 10 Pied piper, 11 Conk, 12 Gobi, 13 Tinge, 15 Gallico, 16 Ails, 19 Will, 20 Detains, 23 Obeli, 24 Cafe, 25 Idea, 27 Megahertz, 28 Blini, 29 Lame duck, 30 Peg-leg **DOWN:** 1 Bird-cage, 2 Colonels, 3 Lees, 5 The wizard of oz, 6 Capitulate, 7 Orpine, 8 Termed, 10 Photoelectric, 14 Diminished, 17 Windmill, 18 Assaying, 21 Formal, 22 Red gum, 26 Abbe

2591

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY JULY 19: Take inventory of your life, because it's time to let go of people and places that have held you back. Do some internal and external house-cleaning.

MONDAY JULY 20: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes in your life. Keep your eyes open for new opportunities and be ready to take the initiative. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

TUESDAY JULY 21: This is a slower paced year. Rejuvenate your energy. Focus on relationships with those who are kind, helpful and have your back.

WEDNESDAY JULY 22: Nurture the happiness that you have within yourself. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Have fun but remember your goals.

THURSDAY JULY 23: You're building foundations in your life, both externally and internally. Explore martial arts or yoga. Stay grounded and levelheaded.

FRIDAY JULY 24: Exciting changes will bring you increased personal freedom this year. Let go of whatever holds you back. Seek out new opportunities .

SATURDAY JULY 25: This is a year of service for you, perhaps service to family. Take care of yourself so that you can be a resource to those who turn to you for guidance and comfort.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD



ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a momentous day because you can go after what you want. Conversations with partners, spouses and close friends could bring about the very improvements that you want. This Week: Vacations, romance and good times.



TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Whatever purchases or financial decisions you make today will be practical, long-lasting and effective. This is exactly what you want —results. This Week: Enjoy home and family.



GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Discussions with your kids or a romantic partner will be transformative today. You have an idea that you want to propose and it will yield reliable results in the future. This Week: An accelerated pace.



CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): This is an excellent day to discuss how to make improvements at home and within the family. If you're open to change, ultimately you will improve your life because you deserve it. This Week: Focus on money and wealth.



LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Your life is opening up in fresh and exciting ways, primarily because of your headspace. You're entertaining new ideas about the people you see and even how you relate to partners and those who are close to you. This Week: It's all about you.



VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You might be having an epiphany about how to use your possessions, your earnings or your wealth to make the changes in your life that you really want, especially related to your job. This puts you in charge of your future. This Week: Privacy and wardrobe shopping.



LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today fiery Mars dances with Saturn, while a Grand Trine between the Moon in your sign and Uranus and Pluto are taking place. Respect your ambitions related to the law, higher education and publishing. You can do things. This Week: You're popular.



SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): You might use the resources of family to make improvements at home. You might steer these changes from behind the scenes, because it's not about the credit, it's about the results. This Week: You shine for the next four weeks.



SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): A discussion with a partner, spouse or close friend will be meaningful today, especially because you're honest. This Week: Opportunities to travel and learn.



CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You're noticed today, which is a good thing, because there's something you want to do. You're working hard to bring about the changes you want. This Week: Bounty might come to you.



AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Discussions about politics, religion, social issues, higher education, the law, medicine and publishing will bring about important changes. This Week: Focus on partners.



PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): The changes you want to bring about at home can now be done as you have the needed practical support. These improvements combined with hard work and determination are the recipe to fulfil your hopes. This Week: Accomplishment through work.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

To me, every hour of the day and night is an unspeakably _____ — Walt Whitman (7,7)

CMEEE

FAIRR

HUCCLT

RUYFMP

ANSWERS: To me, every hour of the day and night is an unspeakably perfect miracle. — Walt Whitman

SOLUTIONS: Ecmee, Lctuh, Frrupm

WESTERN RAILWAY

PROCUREMENT & FIELD TRIAL OF THICK WEB SWITCHES

Chief Engineer (Track Supply), Headquarters Office, Old Building, 2nd floor, Churchgate, Mumbai-400 020 invites **Tender Notice No.: WTR/17/2026/01 Dated 16.07.2026** through E-Procurement mode only for the supply of the following items:

Tender No.: WR-26-02-TWS-TR1	Approx Value of Tender: ₹1,43,72,400/-
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Short Description: Item (A) Procurement and Field Trial of Thick Web Switches Without Relief Planning of Tongue Rail, utilizing existing 1 in 12 Thick Web Switches conforming to RDSO Drawing No. T-8780 Alt 4 or latest Alt. if any. **Tenders Quantity:** 10 Set.

Short Description: Item (B) Procurement and Field Trial of Thick Web Switches Without Relief Planning of Tongue Rail, utilizing existing 1 in 8.5 Thick Web Switches conforming to RDSO Drawing No. T-9775 Alt 3 or latest Alt. if any. **Tenders Quantity:** 10 Set.

NOTE:- The detailed trial scheme along with a proforma (Annexure I) for inspection & monitoring is as per RDSO letter No. CT/PTX (Part) dated 24-03-2026.

Date & Time of Tender closing of E-tender Box: On 12.08.2026 at 11:30 Hrs. For further details please visit our website www.ireps.gov.in

Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly) • Follow us on: [X.com/WesternRly](https://www.x.com/WesternRly)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82(2)(ii)Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person namely **Puran Chand S/o** Om Parkash, R/o: Harijan Chopal V.P.O. Khara Dabar, Najafgarh, Delhi (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 50/2024, 10/2021, U/s 174A IPC, 323/325/506 IPC** registered at P.S.: J.P. Kalan, Delhi and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused **Puran Chand** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Puran Chand** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Puran Chand** accused **FIR No. 50/2024, 10/2021, U/s 174A IPC, 323/325/506 IPC** registered at P.S.: J.P. Kalan, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.09.2026**.

By Order
Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class -08
South-West District Court No. 314
District Courts Dwarka , New Delhi

DP/9833/DW/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

No. NWR-JU-EOI-Consultant -2026 Date : As per signature

Notice for Inviting Expression of Interest (EOI)

Jodhpur Division of North Western Railway- is interested in "**Engagement of Consultancy Services for identification and monetization of untapped & upcoming resources/assets for increasing Non-Fare Revenue (NFR) through different conventional and non- conventional modes of NFR earnings for Jaisalmer, Nagaur and Bhagat ki Kothi railway station over Jodhpur Division of North Western Railway.**"

Firms / Individuals / Service Providers are requested to view the Expression of Interest (EOI) details on North Western Railway official website www.nwr.indianrailways.gov.in or contact Senior Divisional Commercial Manager's office Phone No. 9001198399/ 9001198718 at Jodhpur on any working day for further details. Interested Firms / Individuals / Service Providers having relevant capabilities are advised to submit their Expression of Interest complete with the required details in the prescribed format in **Sealed Covers on 11.08.2026 upto 15.00 hrs.**

Response to Expression of Interest should mention the estimated cost for Consultancy Service. The estimated cost should be inclusive of GST. The envelope containing the Expression of Interest may be superscribed as: "**Engagement of Consultancy Services for identification and monetization of untapped & upcoming resources/assets for increasing Non-Fare Revenue through different conventional and non-conventional modes of NFR earnings for Jaisalmer, Nagaur and Bhagat ki Kothi railway station over Jodhpur Division of North Western Railway.**"

The notice for inviting Expression of Interest is available on the North Western Railway official website www.nwr.indianrailways.gov.in. Applicants meeting the qualification criteria may be invited for a presentation / proposal before the selection committee.

Meeting for the subject Expression of Interest shall be held on **28.07.2026** at 15.30 hours in chamber of undersigned at Divisional Railway Manager's Office/Harish Joshi Marg, Jodhpur Division, Jodhpur - 342001.

1028-DE/26

Please join us on [Facebook](https://www.facebook.com/NWRailways) [Instagram](https://www.instagram.com/NWRailways) [YouTube](https://www.youtube.com/NWRailways)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vijay @ Mikka**, S/o: Bhupender Shah, R/o: N-86, Lawrence Road, near Railway Shakur Basti Industrial Area, Keshav Puram, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 15/2021, U/s 285/337/304A IPC, P.S.: Civil Lines, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Vijay @ Mikka** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vijay @ Mikka** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Vijay @ Mikka** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 15/2021, U/s 285/337/304A IPC, P.S.: Civil Lines, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Kartik Taparai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06 (Central)
Room No. 247, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/9750/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **1. Rakesh @ Tunda**, S/o: Om Prakash, R/o: Plot No. 2845, Gali No. 2, A-Block, Holambi Kalan, Delhi and **2. Dharmveer @ Veera**, S/o: Prempal, R/o: Jhuggi No. 59/2, Jahangir Puri, Delhi have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 173/2023 U/s 379/411/34 IPC, P.S.: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **1. Rakesh @ Tunda** and **2. Dharmveer @ Veera** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **1. Rakesh @ Tunda** and **2. Dharmveer @ Veera** have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **1. Rakesh @ Tunda** and **2. Dharmveer @ Veera** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 173/2023 U/s 379/411/34 IPC, P.S.: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No. 06, Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/9535/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, **Asha, W/o Suresh R/o** H.No. 1003/62 Gali No 1, Makki Sarai, Near Shahdara Metro Station, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CT NO 2337/2019**, registered at **P.S.: Geeta Colony, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Asha**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Asha**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person, **Asha, CT NO 2337/2019**, registered at **P.S.: Geeta Colony, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
East Distt., Room No. 16,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9213/SHD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Manik Anand S/o** Virender Anand, R/o 159/160, Khasra No.-101, Vikas Vihar, Uttam Nagar West, Delhi-59, **Also at:** Lal Ji Toys, Shop No.-105 Near Videokon Tower, Jhandewalan, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC NI Act No. 567/2020, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Sarai Rohilla, North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Manik Anand** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Manik Anand** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant); Proclamation is hereby made that **Manik Anand** the said accused of **CC NI Act No. 567/2020, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Sarai Rohilla, North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Aradhana
Judicial Magistrate First Class (NI Act)-09,
Central Distt., Extension Block,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/9828/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Mukesh @ Montu**, S/o: Kishori Mal R/o: H.No. 416, Metro Plaza, Mata Ka Bagh Meerut, **UP**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **E-FIR No. 28144/2022, U/s: 379/411/482/34 IPC, PS: Vivek Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Mukesh @ Montu**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Mukesh @ Montu**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Mukesh @ Montu**, of **E-FIR No. 28144/2022, U/s: 379/411/ 482/34 IPC, Vivek Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Mohit Sharma
Chief Judicial Magistrate
Room No. 59 Third Floor Shahdara District
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/9599/SHD/2026
(Court Matter)

CSB Bank
Trusted Partner Smart Future

PUBLIC NOTICE ON AUCTION OF PLEDGED GOLD ORNAMENTS

The borrower/s in specific and interested bidders in general, are hereby informed that on account of non-repayment of the Banks due by the borrowers as under despite the payment notice and recall-auction notice issued by the Bank, the gold ornaments pledged with the Bank security by the respective borrowers for the loan availed by them will be sold in public auction on "as is where is" and "non-recourse" at branch premises on **27th July 2026 at 10.30 AM**. The auction may be adjourned to any other later date at the discretion of the bank upon publication of the same in the Bank's notice board. The borrowers are hereby further inform that the gold ornaments will be disposed of by public auction/auction, if the auction is not successful, and if there is a further balance to be recovered thereafter, legal action will be initiated against the borrower/s for recovery of the balance amounts due to the bank. "In case of deceased borrower, all conditions will be applicable to legal heirs."

S. No.	Auction Center CSB Branch	Account Name	Client ID	No. of Acc.	Ball. Outstanding as on 16.07.2026	Weight (grams)
1.	Gautham Nagar	Amar Saini	4317073	1	67399.31	8.8
2.	Palam	Amar Singh	4184467	1	136110.83	17.94
3.	Janakpuri	Pintu Kumar	3433995	1	134399.61	26.57
4.	Dwarka	Abhishek	4791858	1	848026.03	100.16
5.	Shalimar Bagh	Brahm Singh	7573891	1	564529.4	70.4
6.	Shalimar Bagh	Monu	6232647	1	2454735.77	271.03
7.	Shalimar Bagh	Ravina Bhout	4962679	1	163090.61	32
8.	Shalimar Bagh	Sohan Lal	8345090	2	3514553.18	412.13
9.	Patel Nagar	Muneet Chaudhary	7774634	1	288279.15	55.37
10.	Rajouri Garden	Vishal Yadav	8185198	1	799156.83	68.1
11.	Narela	Pardeep Kumar	10058738	1	132417.2	16.77
12.	Narela	Sita Ram Sirohi	4467410	2	556592.8	82.1
13.	Bhajanpura - Newdelhi	Mohd Zaker	10128717	1	87868.92	12.4
14.	Bhajanpura - Newdelhi	Yogender Raj Verma	4592983	1	116400.75	13.65
15.	Krishna Nagar-Newdelhi	Ayush Wahal	7516451	2	253238.23	30.8
16.	Krishna Nagar-Newdelhi	Shobha	4962017	1	1462030.34	165.1
17.	Tri Nagar Delhi	Ashraf	8310655	1	489359.36	48.18
18.	Paschim Vihar	Kajal	10042500	1	5714195.88	559.9
19.	Kailaji	Mir Askar Ali	10131783	1	132079.49	16.5

For more details/account wise information borrower/s interested bidders may contact respective branches and for participating in the auction

DP/9251/SHD/2026

Authorized Officer, CSB Bank

UJVN Limited
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprises)
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website: www.ujvn.com

पर सं: 593 दिनांक: 18 / 07 / 2026

e-Tender (Time Extension-1)
04/EE(Civil-R&R-Tehri)/LMP/2026-27

Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates of bidding of Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil-R&R-Tehri), Lakhwar Multipurpose Project, UJVN Limited, Dakpathar (Dehradun) invites online bid from interested parties are extended as follows:
e-NIT No.: 04/EE(Civil-R&R-Tehri)/LMP/2026-27
Name of work:- Construction of RCC Retaining and Gabion Wall near Compartment No. 4, North-Binhaar (Near Nala) at left bank of Yamuna River of Lakhwar MPP.
Availability of Bid on web: from 17:00 Hrs of 17.07.2026
Last date of submission of bid on: 31.07.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs.
e-portal Bid opening date : 04.08.2026 up to 11:30 Hrs.
For fuller & further details, kindly visit "e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in>"

Executive Engineer (Civil-R&R-Tehri)
Lakhwar Project, Dakpathar

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Gulshan, S/o** Sh. Dinesh, R/o H.No. 210, Prakash Vihar, Gali No. 2, Loni, Ghaziabad, **UP** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 185/2024, U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Kashmir Gate, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Gulshan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Gulshan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Gulshan** accused of **FIR No. 185/2024, U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Kashmir Gate, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.08.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
Central, Room No. 138, 1st Floor
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/9860/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused persons (1) **Pr**



Final puzzle: Can Spain stop Messi?



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 18

YEARS LATER, it remains a regret for the legendary Manchester United manager Alex Ferguson. He couldn't stop Lionel Messi in the Champions League finals, neither in 2009 nor in 2011.

"You need centre-backs who are prepared to drop right on top of Messi and not worry about what is happening behind them," he later wrote in his autobiography. "He's less of a threat on the side than he is through the centre. When we play Barcelona next time in a Champions League final, I wasn't going to let him torture us again," he wrote.

The next time never came. But he is not the only manager or defender whose best-laid plans Messi has torn to shreds. Everyone has a plan until they get punched in the face, as Mike Tyson wrote, until they get Messi-fied, until his unrelenting, immeasurable genius hits them. In theory, there are several ways to stop Messi, but in practice, he has too many ways to beat you. Hristo Stoichkov, a member of Johan Cruyff's Barcelona Dream Team, got hype's presses rolling. "Once they said they can only stop me with a pistol, but today you need a machine gun to stop Messi," he said.

Fundamentally, it's a tussle between sporting spontaneity and practised wisdom. Spain manager Luis de la Fuente has his Messi story too, it's like survivors of a natural calamity reliving the trauma.

Almost every team has failed to shackle the Argentine great, *La Roja* will hope to be an exception



Lionel Messi during a training session with teammates in Morristown, New Jersey on Saturday. AP

It was 2004, and Messi's talents were a whisper rather than a full-blown manifestation. "We went to Barcelona to play them in the Spanish Cup and I'd heard great things about a lad called Messi," he recalled in his press conference.

"Obviously we put him under man-to-man marking from the start. And by the 70th minute, the score was 0-0. And when the player marking him was shown a card, I brought him off. Within 15 minutes he

(Messi) scored four goals!"

He contextualises the situation: "What does this mean? That we're going to mark him man-to-man? No. But that we're going to keep a very close eye on him? Yes."

Practical fix

It has been 21 years since Messi arrived, Pau Cubarsi, among those now deputed to contain him, wasn't even born yet. Yet a practical fix to stop Messi has eluded most man-

Some teams have tried to stop him with double man-marking, one man getting goal-side of him and the other coming around him, stifling his space to cut left. Messi could still spin around them, or nutmeg them...

"We put him under man-to-man marking. By the 70th minute, the score was 0-0. When the player marking him was shown a card, I brought him off. Within 15 minutes, he scored four goals!"

LUIS DE LA FUENTE,
SPAIN COACH

agers and defenders. Unless Messi has a bad day, he is as much an everyday reality as the sun rising in the east.

Pinpoint crosses

Hypothetically, Ferguson's plan that never materialised is a method teams have since adopted to minimise his in-

vasions: isolate him to the extreme right, more so in the sunset of his career, and cramp him for space to fling in his long, pinpoint crosses and di-

agonal balls. His deliveries sting, especially evidenced in the back-from-the-dead games against England and Egypt. For much of the game, Egypt's ploy worked; they crowded the middle and starved him of space between the lines.

He was pushed out from the defensive block to the wings, away from the patch of ground where he is deadliest. Spain would clearly not set up a low block against him, but they would counter-press him, aggressively and doggedly, affording him little time on the ball.

Not press-immune

Herein lies the complex beauty of the game, Messi is not press-immune, but he can beat the press with his immaculate manoeuvring in tight spaces. He can get nasty when protecting the ball, and with one svelte move, could skin two or three defenders on the move, releasing space for his teammates.

But if defenders incessantly pressure him from behind when he receives the ball, he tends to choose the safer option of passing to his nearest teammate. The less time Messi has on the ball, the more reduced, though not entirely neutered, his threat becomes, both individually and for the team as a whole. Spain's is not only the meanest defence in the tournament, but also the most mobile and quickest. They snatch and advance the ball like whippets.

The roles of the left-back (Marc Cucurella) and left-sided midfielder (Fabian Ruiz) are central in ensuring he isn't given the liberty to skip around the defence, dragging the left-back inside and floating the

ball to the overlapping full-back, Nicolas Tagliafico, or Julian Alvarez. Tracking Tagliafico's runs is essential, as Argentina don't have an orthodox winger, unlike Angel Di Maria in the last World Cup.

Some teams have tried to stop him with double man-marking, one man getting goal-side of him and the other coming around him, stifling his space to cut left.

Messi could still spin around them, or nutmeg them, but there's a high percentage that he'd instead retreat or find a teammate behind him.

Strangle his accomplices too, the men that make him work, like Rodrigo de Paul and Enzo Fernández. Use muscle or method. Create a cage, as Jose Mourinho forged in Milan in 2010, in Inter's coup.

His shifting triangular man-marking block of Javier Zanetti, Esteban Cambiasso, and Thiago Motta suffocated him in between the lines. They fiercely marked Dani Alves, the right-back, so his supplies remained deficient.

But just as defenders plot his downfall, he studies the men trying to stop him too. Spain's setup would be familiar to Messi. They play with the lines close together and the players narrow, much like Barcelona did. He knows they would hound him with incessant pressing and try to drag him to the far right.

But how many tactics and ploys has he foiled! Managers have explored every route they could to limit him.

Some have temporarily succeeded too. If anyone can stop him, Spain can, is how football will look at it. But all tournament it has been like trying to catch smoke in a butterfly net.

Ferguson would agree.

Final: ESP vs ARG, 12:30 am Monday

Scaloni, De la Fuente trade jokes, wisdom before the big clash

Sandip G
New Jersey, July 18

GULPING A mouthful of water from the table, Argentina manager Lionel Scaloni cleared his throat and told the media manager sitting beside him: "You need to translate this, it's important now, in English. Very, very clean English."

The media manager looked amusedly at him, even though he could have understood the premise. "I don't have any superstition," he clarified.

The reporter's question was on Scaloni's habit of wearing the same shoe (or rather, sneaker) for every game. The manager narrated how he forsook the ritual. "I had one in the previous World Cup. I used the same pair of shoes during a winning streak. Then we lost to Saudi Arabia, and I had to take it off. So I said, 'bye shoes.' From there on, I didn't have any."

The reporter interrupted again: "What about entering the ground with the right foot?" Scaloni wanted to negate it, but couldn't: "No, no, yes, yes. It's an old one, I enter with my right foot, but I did that when I played too, right?" It was the last question of the interaction, and he left the reporter and the floor for another story trail: "I imagine that the rest of the coaching staff must have some superstition or other. I don't have many."

Two days before the final between Argentina and Spain, a match of engrossing subplots, managers Scaloni and Luis de la Fuente were in a mood of wit, jokes and eloquent explanations, deflecting from the central themes of the game.

De la Fuente, an imposing presence with his piercing eyes and stocky frame, found the funnier side of everything. He called reporters by their first names and whipped up wisecracks with a straight face.

"Are you worried about anything before your first World Cup final?" He thought for a second, and then came up with a gem: "We came by a helicopter, and we have to fly back once the press conference is over. That really makes me nervous." Cue ripples of laughter. A few smartphones mounted on monopods fell off, as the videographers were lost in his humour.

The obvious question didn't take too long to strike. Lionel Messi and Lamine Yamal, the two titular figures of the game. Yamal is not only predestined to be Messi's spiritual successor at Barcelona, but also his country's first footballing megastar. Spain, of course, had Alfredo Di Stéfano and Raúl, Xavi Hernández and Andrés Iniesta, but none exuded a superstar persona. "Messi is one of a kind; he's an immense talent and, above all, an example for younger athletes," he said. "But Lamine has to be Lamine."

Scaloni's mentor

A predictable question struck Scaloni too. On his bond with mentor De la Fuente. "Well, it's not that we know everything about each other. We are friends,



"We came by a helicopter, and we have to fly back once the press conference is over. That really makes me nervous."

LUIS DE LA FUENTE,
SPAIN COACH

but he doesn't know exactly what I think about football," he emphasised. He lucidly elaborated on their styles. "What we'd know is how each other's teams play; he knows how mine plays, and I know how his team plays. We haven't sat down to discuss our respective patterns, but they're evident. Both like time on the ball," he said.

Both are possession-reliant. "But with some nuances," he added. Argentina enjoy passive possession, wherein they pass the ball between themselves simply to frustrate the opponent. Spain, contrastingly, are quicker in advancing to attacking positions with the ball. "They string together a lot of passes and are vertical."

What Scaloni didn't say was that they are equally comfortable without the ball. They could go minutes without having the ball and then suddenly launch a blizzard from nowhere. He also has a penchant for tactical surprises, like playing Angel Di Maria in the 2022 Qatar World Cup final. A wide-man took France aback; a narrow midfield suddenly became wider, and France didn't have the personnel to cope with it. De la Fuente is not prone to impulses.

De la Fuente had half a jab at Argentina's intense physicality: "Referee Slavko Vinčić must not be lenient or allow anyone to cross the limits of the law or go beyond what the rules of football permit."

He then turned to Roman Emperor Marcus Aurelius's quotes: "What brings no benefit to the hive, brings none to the bee. Players should have that mindset where you need to work for the collective good."

He scanned his eyes from one corner of the room to the other, where at least a hundred journalists were assembled, and said philosophically: "You ask me about the trick of winning. I will tell you. Work, work and work. I see that most of you are younger than me, and you should keep working. Never stop. The experience is amazing, when everything works out," he said.

Everything, he would know, would work out for only one team on Sunday.

Both managers would be praying that the team would be theirs.

• SEEING RED MIST

Never mess with Leo: A lesson Spain can learn from Bellingham's bravado

Sandeep Dwivedi
New Delhi, July 18

A COLD chilling stare, lips tightly pursed and a slow shake of the head. That was all Messi did after a long and animated argument with England star Jude Bellingham over a foul in the closing moments of the first half, deep into stoppage time. Those who know, know — this was an early sign of a storm about to strike a football field. This time it was at Atlanta, and it would take almost until the very end of the night for that storm to break.

England didn't lose because of Bellingham winding up Messi but he was guilty of misjudging the depth of the still and silent water he had blindly walked into.

Bellingham is 23 but his captain Harry Kane has been around long enough. He is better at reading games and

faces of his rivals and the game's greats. And he played the game hard, trying his best to tackle Messi but never got personal.

Anthony Gordon put England 1-0 up early in the second half, and for the best part of half an hour, that lead held. But Messi's fury didn't calm down. It simmered, and when Argentina finally broke through, it broke through twice. His two assists — for Enzo Fernandez's 86th-minute equaliser and Lautaro Martinez's stoppage-time winner — turned a famous England lead into a 2-1 defeat and sent Argentina into the World Cup final.

In the magical world where Messi lives, he can win a game without scoring goals and also convey a very stern message without uttering a word.

This isn't the reaction of a veteran slowly running out of patience when faced with the

audacity and petulance of the young he faces on field. Messi has always been like this.

As a 14-year-old, as a wonderkid at Barcelona's La Masia academy, Messi played a game against Espanyol. Till date he remembers a brutal tackle by a defender who couldn't keep up with him — but not his name. For most of the game, Little Messi would dodge past him, making him look ordinary. Frustration would get the better of the Espanyol player and he would lash out at Messi.

Getting triggered

The Barcelona prodigy would be down on the turf with his cheekbone seriously injured. There are no videos or reports to suggest that Messi gave a blank stare and slow head shake that day. But the rest of the story does prove that like against England the other day, Messi does get triggered when



There was no love lost between Messi and Bellingham. AP

confronted, roughed up or taken lightly.

That day, Messi was taken off the field and the doctors told him that he would be out of action for 15 days. But with Barcelona set to play Espanyol the next week, the boy with revenge on his mind didn't want

to sit out. A persistent Messi would convince the coach to keep him in the side. "I will play with a face mask," — was his argument. The game would assume mythical status in the years to come. In the Making of Messi story it would be called *El Partido de la Mascara* (The

Game of the Mask).

In the frenzy of getting back at the defender who had taken him down in the previous game, Messi would rip off the mask and throw it away. The coach would substitute him at half-time but not before he had enhanced his reputation as a goal-scorer and as someone who can't be pushed around or spoken to in an aggressive tone like Bellingham did in the World Cup semi-final. That day, in barely 45 minutes on the field, Messi scored a couple and had a hand in another. The team won 4-1.

In years to come, Messi, whose match face always has a tranquil calm, on some days would rip off the mask. When he first got picked for Argentina, he was a rookie among the stars and seniors. Everyone had a reputation and a matching ego.

Among the seniors was the

celebrated defender Gabriel Heinze, a veteran with an experience of playing most top clubs in Europe. Messi once nutmegged him during training, playing the ball skillfully between his legs and making him look like an amateur. Heinze didn't like it, he started going hard at a young Messi.

There is an interesting line on the incident in an article on Messi in *The Times*. "Squad members recall that Messi said nothing, brooded no complaint, he just flashed Heinze a warning look as if to say: 'Don't do that again.' Go back to the semi-final spat with Bellingham and try to read the look on Messi's face. It clearly says: 'Now, you've had it.'"

There is a famous book called *Messi v Ronaldo*, it chronicles the contrast between the two all-time greats. It says how Ronaldo was protected at Manchester United

and that was not the case with Messi at Barcelona. Sir Alex Ferguson stored him in cotton wool, asked the rest of the team to be careful in tackling him, there was no such worry at Camp Nou.

"Anyone foolish enough to go in too hard on Messi instantly became the focus of his revenge. He would unleash his bag of tricks with the sole purpose of embarrassing that person."

After his angry exchange with Bellingham, Messi embarrassed the English team.

There is an iconic line in the Clint Eastwood starring old Western classic *The Good, The Bad and The Ugly* that professional sportsmen should write and recite before games. Tuco (Ugly) played by Eli Wallach tells the bounty hunter, "When you have to shoot, shoot. Don't talk". It is a creed Good Bellingham would do well to live by.

Cocaine, pistols and WC final: Who is referee Vincic?



Slavko Vincic. CGM

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 18

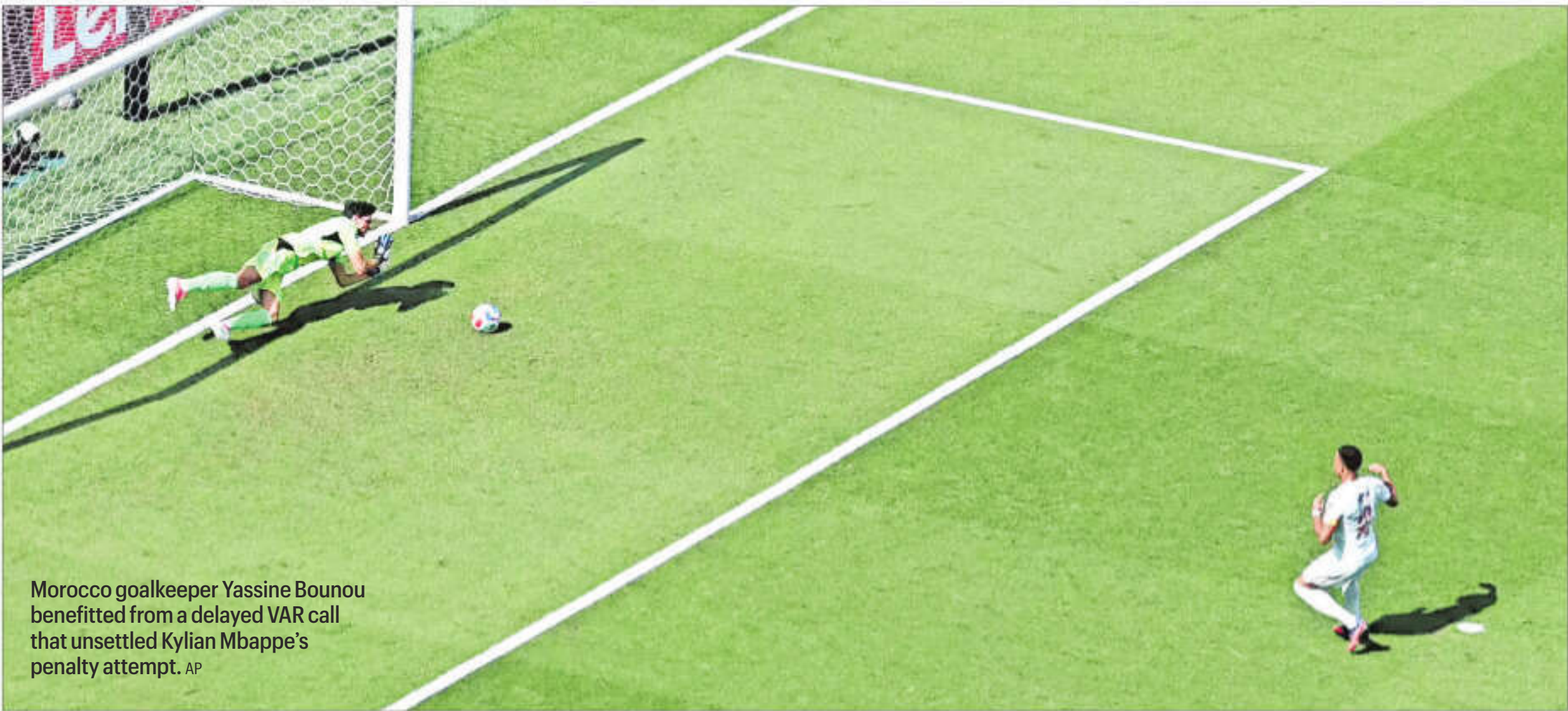
ON SUNDAY, Slavko Vincic will referee the World Cup final between Argentina and Spain. It will be the last match of his career. Vincic very nearly never got here at all, and not for any reason to do with a football pitch. On the night of 30 May 2020, police raided a farm outside Bijeljina, in Bosnia, as part of an operation against an alleged prostitution and drug-trafficking ring. They detained 35 people. Among them was Vincic, who says he had travelled to the town on business and accepted what he understood to be a lunch invitation.

"I found myself on this ranch by chance," he told Slovenian television afterwards. "I accepted an invitation to lunch, which turned out to be my biggest mistake. I have nothing to do with the group that was arrested and detained, nor do my business partners."

Police seized cocaine, ten pistols, body armour, and more than ten thousand euros in cash. A year later Tijana Maksimovic, identified by investigators as the operation's organiser, pleaded guilty to a charge of international enticement to prostitution. Vincic was questioned as a witness and released without charge. No charges were ever filed against him. Vlado Sajin, president of the Slovenian Football Referees Association, said at the time that Vincic was not suspected of anything, based on what the association had gathered "from official and unofficial sources and from Slavko himself." The country where it happened is the same one his parents left for Slovenia in the early 1970s.

He is 46, from Maribor, the son of an electrical engineer. Basketball was what he loved first. Football came second. He studied telecommunications engineering, drifted away from sport entirely, then felt something missing. An uncle who was a referee suggested he try officiating. He was 20.

When the call came from FIFA's refereeing chief on Thursday, Vincic's face went into his hands. The Slovenian press that carried the video used the same word: solze. Tears. They also reported that this World Cup is his last, that after Sunday, he retires.



Morocco goalkeeper Yassine Bounou benefitted from a delayed VAR call that unsettled Kylian Mbappe's penalty attempt. AP

PUT ON THE SPOT

Messi, Mbappe missed: Why even the best fluff penalties?

German legend Oliver Kahn analyses the whys and hows of goalkeepers thriving against elite penalty takers

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 18

● MOROCCO SHOT-STOPPER Yassine Bounou stirred up enough chaos to delay Kylian Mbappe's routine in taking a penalty, and the France captain missed only his second from 16 he's taken.

● Lionel Messi stayed uncharacteristically fumble-prone in line with his low career conversion rate of 78 percent in regulation time penalty kicks, missing against Austria and Egypt.

● Kai Havertz missed for the first time after a 16/16 record - denied by the wily Orlando Gill of Paraguay, as Germany went home.

● Harry Kane slotted home the rebound, after missing a penalty due to the distracting tactics that Croatia's Dominik Livakovic summoned.

● Bounou stopped half the Dutch in the shootout - sending them packing.

And to think, Argentina's Emiliano Martinez hasn't even faced one yet. The 2026 World Cup has not been a very productive tournament for penalty takers. The 12-yard distance has turned treacherous.

Of the 61 penalties taken, 21 - more than a third - have not been converted, either through a save or a miss. That's a success rate of less than 66 per cent, far lower than the overall average of 81 per cent, before this tournament, as quoted by Geir Jordet, author of 'Penalties' writing in *The New*

York Times.

In 90 minutes plus extra time, 21 penalties have seen six misses. Penalty shootouts in World Cups averaged 69 per cent conversions since the 1982 edition, but the number has dipped by 7 per cent to 25 converted out of 40. It's a far cry from the 78 per cent overall success rate at the 2010 edition in South Africa.

"I don't think it's a coincidence. Penalty-taking has become much more predictable than it was years ago," notes iconic German goalkeeper Oliver Kahn. With his cap and stern visage, Kahn was quite a formidable barrier in his day. But a penalty was considered a near-goal and 'keepers went in knowing they were at a big disadvantage. Not any more.

"That's because today every penalty-taker has a detailed profile. Goalkeepers know the perfect corner, the run-up, the body position and even how a player reacts under pressure," Kahn, an expert on *ZEE5*, says.

Earlier, goalkeepers watched eyes, head tilts, micro-movements of hips and the planted foot to judge kick direction. But it was all guesswork. Data on penalties began to be compiled in the 1990s, and patterns of penalty-takers are pored over more thoroughly than ever before.

Bounou has been outstanding with his combination of reflexes and reactions in penalty situations - beaten only twice in the nine he faced. While the

• Number Plate

21

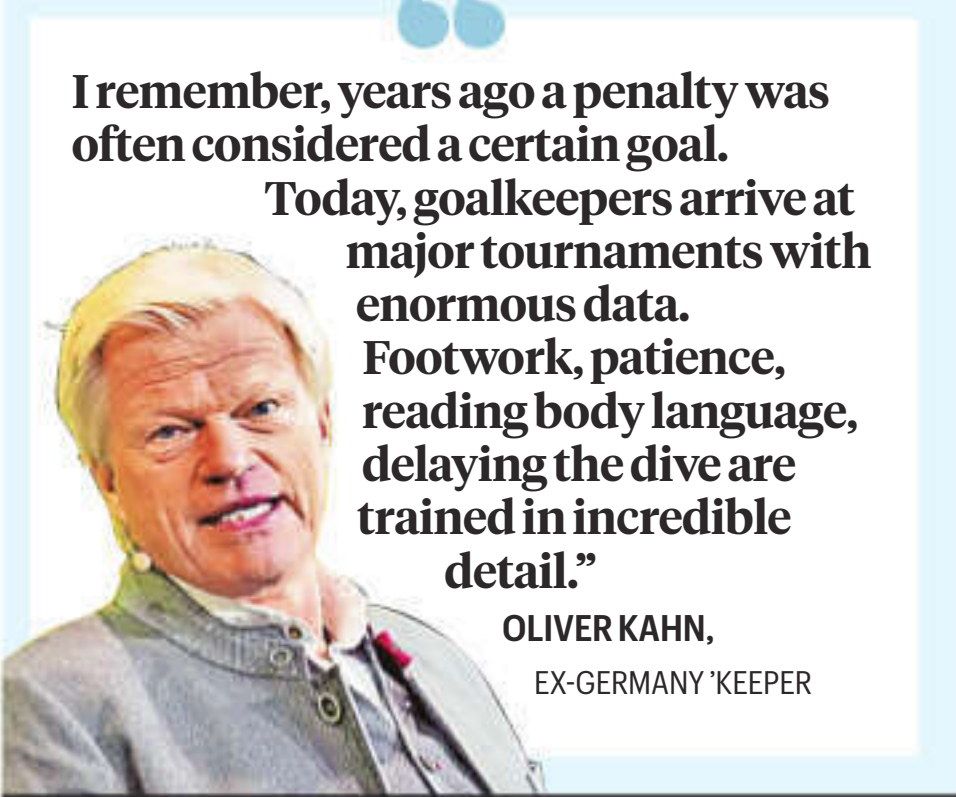
● Of the 61 overall penalties taken until semi-finals, 21 - 34.4% - have not been converted

58

● Goalkeepers with disruptive movements have let in 58 per cent conversions, while silent ones were beaten 79 per cent of the time

6

Of the 21 spot-kicks taken in ninety minutes plus extra time at this World Cup, six have been missed.



I remember, years ago a penalty was often considered a certain goal. Today, goalkeepers arrive at major tournaments with enormous data. Footwork, patience, reading body language, delaying the dive are trained in incredible detail."

OLIVER KAHN,
EX-GERMANY 'KEEPER

three misses had theatrics, the four saves pointed to elite goal-guarding instincts.

"Goalkeepers are preparing much more systematically. They work with video analysts, data specialists and dedicated goal-keeping coaches who study hundreds of penalties before a tournament," Kahn informs.

The German says a big reason for big names fluffing penalties is the enormous burden on their shoulders. "Pressure at World Cups is different than in other tournaments. Players

know one missed penalty can define their whole career," he says. "That psychological pressure often leads to hesitation and bad decision-making. And hesitation is exactly what goalkeepers are looking for."

It might explain why Messi, who has converted seven of nine in shootouts, tends to be shabby in regular time, or why Mbappe ended up with a low, weak shot.

Geir quoted research saying that distracting methods by goalkeepers can bring down conversion rates by 10

per cent. Norwegian Orjan Nyland neutralised Brazil's Bruno Guimaraes. Faked movements are all the rage, and Geir notes that manipulative goalkeepers have let in 58 per cent conversions, while the conventional silent ones were beaten 79 per cent of the time.

"Penalties are no longer just about technique. They have become a battle of preparation, psychology and decision-making. But every goalkeeper relies on gut feeling," Kahn reflects.

Some like Martinez are personalities relying on the chirp. Like his famous tapping of Bruno Fernandes in an Aston Villa-Manchester United game where he asked the Portuguese why Cristiano Ronaldo wasn't taking the shot. He's 12/24 for Argentina, stopping an astounding 50 per cent with his wiles.

"I remember, years ago a penalty was often considered a certain goal. Today, goalkeepers arrive at major tournaments with an enormous amount of data. Footwork, patience, reading body language and delaying the dive are trained in incredible detail. Goalkeepers are much better athletes than they were 20 years ago," Kahn notes.

He's reluctant to concede that the advantage has completely shifted to the goalkeeper.

"A perfectly-executed penalty is still almost impossible to save. The goalkeeper only has a chance to save if the taker makes a bad decision or has a weak shot. But the margin of error has become much smaller. If the taker is not fully convinced, if there's the slightest hesitation, today's elite goalkeepers are capable of punishing it immediately," the German legend says.

{ SIDELINES }



Marc Cucurella already has a European C'ship to his name. AP

Cucurella vows to retire, get coach's tattoo if Spain win

SPAIN DEFENDER Marc Cucurella has said that he will retire from international football if his side lifts the World Cup title on Sunday. The left-back also said he would get a tattoo of manager Luis de la Fuente's face on his bicep. "If we win the World Cup, I'll call Luis the next day and tell him not to count on me anymore, that I'm retiring from the national team. With a European Championship and a World Cup, I can't do any better," Cucurella said. "I would get a little tattoo of Spain manager Luis de la Fuente's face on my bicep if we were to win the World Cup," he added. The Spain manager was his usual calm, amusing self on Friday as he looked ahead to the showpiece match against his former pupil Lionel Scaloni's

holders, insisting his side would embrace the occasion rather than be swallowed up by its enormity. "I'm quite nervous because we'll be returning by helicopter," De la Fuente told reporters with a laugh. "We came by helicopter, and we have to fly back once the press conference is over, and that really makes me nervous. "Nothing else, though - I'm absolutely calm. We're lucky to be in these circumstances, in this situation."

Asked about the old line that nobody remembers the runners-up, De la Fuente pushed back, saying simply getting into position to fight for the trophy was a privilege. "For me, the important thing is to be in a position to win, to reach a final," he said. ENS

Capdevila asks Trump for help getting into USA

FORMER SPAIN defender Joan Capdevila has asked U.S. President Donald Trump for help getting into the United States to watch Spain face Argentina in Sunday's World Cup final, after being denied authorization to travel a decade after playing in an exhibition game in Iran. In 2010, Capdevila helped Spain win their only men's World Cup title, starting in the final against the Netherlands. But he is worried he will miss Sunday's final and addressed Trump in a post on X, saying his application for visa-free entry via the country's Electronic System for Travel Authorization (ESTA) was denied. Visitors from select countries who want to enter the U.S. without a visa apply via ESTA. "I NEED HELP @realDonaldTrump!" Capdevila posted on X on Friday night, adding that his ESTA application was denied. AP

FIFA detects 7 million abusive comments

FIFA'S SOCIAL Media Protection Service (SMPS), which aims to protect players, teams and officials from online threats and abuse, has detected more than 7 million potentially harmful or abusive posts on social media during the World Cup, the global soccer body said on Saturday. FIFA said the detection rate was 14 times higher than the 2022 edition, during which 470,000 such posts were removed. The SMPS team have reviewed more than half a million AI-detected messages targeting players, coaches and officials during the ongoing World Cup. They have reported more than 1,000 threats to authorities including law enforcement. The SMPS have moderated more than 53 million posts and comments since the start of the World Cup, which culminates on Sunday with a clash between Argentina and Spain. REUTERS

Sindhu solves endgame problems

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 18

CHEN YUFEI became PV Sindhu's 40th career win over a Chinese, as the 31-year-old reached Japan Open finals. And in her 21-19, 15-10 win after the 2021 Olympic champion retired from a hamstring pull, Sindhu found another piece of a missing jigsaw - how to guard leads against top names that have played clutch all these years.

"Winning that first game mattered," Sindhu would tell BWF at Tokyo, where her beligerence drove Yufei, World No 4, out of the contest before injury troubles saw her unfortunate retirement. Leading 11-7, Sindhu had set herself a good base. The early lead came from straight attacking smashes to Yufei's far forehand corner as Sindhu charged forward - the hits controlled impeccably by the Indian, World No 10.

The Chinese did well to return from 11-16 down to level at 19-19. Sindhu won a 51-shot rally for 18-16, but Yufei toggled Sindhu back and front, sending the shuttle deep. She reached 19-19, but a skilled racquet-face turning drop to the forecourt gave Sindhu the set point.

The 31-year-old has the set-up smashes, but she has the original no-holds-barred smash too, an unreturnable one, she targeted at Yufei's hand and



PV Sindhu will take on Akane Yamaguchi in the Japan Open final. BWF

shoulder, with wind-cutting speed to take the opener 21-19.

Chen Yufei said Sindhu didn't make it easy for her. The Indian told BWF, "I was very focused because I was leading in the first game and she came quite close so it was important you stay focused. Sometimes you are leading and you give away points and you get suddenly disheartened thinking why are these points going when I was leading. Lot of emotions go on, in your head. But my coach said it's OK, doesn't matter. Just focus on next point. That really helped."

Clarity in the endgame has been a slow-buffer for Sindhu, but against Yufei, she showed no hesitation as she made her first final of the season, at a

Super 750 event.

Sindhu takes on Akane Yamaguchi in the final, in what will be their 30th match. The rivalry couldn't be more keen - Sindhu has 15 wins, Yamaguchi 14. However, her last proper happy win over the Japanese home favorite, came four years ago in May 2022. Yamaguchi retired a set down earlier at Malaysia this year, but has won 7 of the last 10 completed matches. There's needle there in the face-off, in front of the Japanese crowd, as Sindhu plays her first final at Tokyo.

Yamaguchi came back from 9-16 down in the quarters decider against Kim Ga Eun, while Sindhu has benefited from two retirements to earn rest. Not that Yufei was easy in 44 minutes.

She's a 'threat' for Worlds, LA Games: Gopi

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 18

INDIAN CHIEF badminton coach Pullela Gopichand sees PV Sindhu's recent surge in form as a positive sign for the upcoming World Championships and the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. Sindhu defeated Chen Yufei of China in the semi-final of the Japan Open Super 750 on Saturday.

"I think she can beat most of the other players like Chen and Han Yue. It will come down to how she faces An Seyoung," Gopichand told media on the sidelines of the mascot launch of the World Championships. "It's (2028 Olympics) a little far but I think many of them can't read her game style. So I think she's definitely going to be a threat for sure," he added further.

The 31-year-old Sindhu was leading 21-19, 15-10 when world No. 4 Chen was forced to pull out with a hamstring injury. It was a brilliant performance from the double Olympic medallist who clearly dominated the Chinese.

Sindhu will be leading India's campaign at the upcoming World Championships as the marquee event returns to India after 17 years.

Lord's brings Gill a chance to stamp his authority on ODI side

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, July 18

AHEAD OF the ODI series decider against England at Lord's, two stories are unfolding simultaneously. One is the mundane issue of the fate of the three-match rubber. India's last away bilateral ODI series win came in South Africa in late 2023. Since then, they have lost in Sri Lanka (2024) and Australia (2025).

The other matter is transition. If this is indeed Rohit Sharma's farewell game, it could also mark the end of one of India's greatest white-ball careers and the beginning of India's next ODI chapter.

That makes the occasion significant for Shubman Gill.

The 26-year-old took over from Rohit as India's ODI captain last October, inheriting a side that had already developed a clear identity. Under Rohit, India reached the 2023 World Cup final before winning the Champions Trophy in 2025. Instead of a rebuild, he's had the more delicate task of putting his own imprint on the side.

In the 11 games he has led in, India have won six and lost five. The numbers don't suggest a struggling team, but neither do they point to a captain who has stamped his authority on the side so far.



Shubman Gill. CREIMAS

Every successful captain has one early series that becomes the first reference point for his leadership. For MS Dhoni, it was the CB series win in 2008. For Virat Kohli, it was winning an ODI series in South Africa for the first time in 2018. Gill is waiting for a similar achievement.

England may have slipped to seventh in the ODI rankings, but the series has underlined why they still remain a dangerous side. Jofra Archer has bowled superbly, Joe Root has anchored the batting, and the lower order has made useful contributions.

A series win in England would therefore become the first defining achievement of Gill's ODI captaincy. India lost 2-1 in Australia in his first assignment. A promising start against New Zealand at home quickly unravelled, raising questions about India's ability to overcome stronger opposition under their

'Rohit will sort out lean run'

INDIA BOWLING coach Morne Morkel backed Rohit Sharma to overcome his lean run in the on-going ODI series against England. "Rohit, as I said earlier, it is hard work with a new ball up front. We have seen that in the entire series. The ball is moving around. So batting up front, it is not easy. No doubt Rohit will work it out. He has done it in the past. He is experienced. And he just brings that calmness to the batting line-up. So without a doubt, no worries and concerns at all with the way he is going about things," Morkel said. ENS

new leader. The series victory against Afghanistan was an expected result given the gulf between the two teams.

If Gill can lead India to victory at Lord's, the conversation around his captaincy could shift. Instead of focusing on what has gone wrong since he took charge, attention will move towards what India are beginning to build under him.

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The Wayward Traveller

Stephen Alter on his new book, the drama of the oak and the deodar in Mussoorie and looking for nocturnal creatures in Goa’s forests

Raghav Juyal on his non-linear journey



FROM KERALA TO MUMBAI, FROM THE HIMALAYAS TO THE WESTERN GHATS, STORIES OF HOW THE MONSOON SHAPES OUR LIVES, LANDSCAPES AND MEMORIES

What the Rain Became

Kerala was raised on the romance of the monsoon. Somewhere along the line, the rains stopped being the backdrop to its life and became a thing to fear



PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES

Nidheesh MK

PADMARAJAN, FILM-MAKER and author, wrote a short story called *Mazha* (1970), Rain. It opens on a single drop coming off the tip of a coconut frond, running the length of the trunk without scattering, boring a small hole in the wet sand below and vanishing, while a child eases back the door-bolt and slips outside without a sound. Nothing much happens for a while. That is the point. The rain is the event.

He returned to that idea often. *Thoovanathumbikal* (1987) is the film that all the state’s rain-soaked romances are measured against. It starts raining the first time Jayakrishnan writes down Clara’s name, and the rain doesn’t stop. A certain generation cannot watch rain without hearing Johnson’s score playing every drop in that movie. Clara comes with the rain and leaves with it, the woman Jayakrishnan wants but never gets to keep. For a Malayali, she personifies the monsoon: something lovely that arrives from somewhere else and will not stay.

The rain has never waited for chroniclers here. Arundhati Roy opened *The God of Small Things* (1997) with the monsoon: the countryside overrun with green and, in the detail everyone remembers, small fish turning up in the flooded potholes of the highway. Travel writer Alexander Frater flew in from London in 1987 to watch the monsoon “burst” on the beach at Kovalam, then chased it across the length of India. His book, *Chasing the Monsoon*, opens with a line that could serve as a Malayali’s birth certificate: “The first sounds I ever heard were those of falling rain.” He found the Met Office in Thiruvananthapuram overrun by callers wanting to know when the rain would come, one of them from Rajiv Gandhi’s office, whose political survival that year rode on its timing. A whole country waited on the rain, with no idea yet what it would become.

You do not need a book for any of this in Kerala. In July, at the first heavy shower, someone is boiling kattan chaya, black and too sweet, frying pazhampori (banana fritters) to go with it, throwing open a window to catch the smell the dry earth gives off when the first drops land. On any grey afternoon a forward reaches your phone declaring this fine weather for a drink. Every June, Popy and John’s, two umbrella firms run by cousins who fell out decades ago, race to out-invent each other, umbrellas that fold into your pocket, GPS handles, built-in bluetooth.



The monsoon is one of the last things Malayalis still agree is beautiful.

Five centuries ago, the story goes, the Zamorin of Calicut was asked whether he really meant to let the Portuguese carry home pepper vines, the root of all his wealth. He waved it off. Let them take the vines, he said. They could never take the *Thiruvathira Njattuvela*, the rains that make the pepper flower. He was half right. Brazil now grows more pepper than Kerala does, every plant probably descended from those smuggled cuttings. And the rains he was sure no one could carry off have turned on the place that loved them, house by house and hill by hill.

The Ruin That Follows

On July 7, after heavy rain, a hillside near Meppadi in Wayanad slid onto a road-tunnel worksite at Kalladi, killing eight, all of them migrant workers sleeping in the camp below. Loose heaps of excavated earth, never cleared, had come down. The Collector had ordered to clear it on June 20, the public works department again on June 25. No-

The monsoon used to be: *aavesham*, a happy fever, the itch to run into the first big shower. Now, there are other words for what it is — Phobia. Therapy. Death

body moved it. The rain did.

There is one of these every year now. Only the place names change. 2018: floods that put much of the State underwater, more than 400 dead. 2019: Kavalappara, 226 dead and 138 missing; an earthmover operator tells me he had stopped digging for the living and was going by smell. 2024: Mundakkai and Chooralmala, more than 250 dead, many returned to their families as a name on a DNA report drawn from a body part.

Old timers still measure Kerala’s monsoon disasters against the deluge of 1924 that reportedly drowned even the 6,000 ft-up Munnar. What is new is the frequency, and the second face the monsoon has grown: drought. In 2019, the rain thinned to a third of what it owed and by July, 70 per cent of local bodies were trucking in drinking water. In Palakkad, the paddy farmer runs the same gamble every June, whether to sow now or wait for rain that may not keep its appointment. By the State’s own count it has arrived on schedule in only four of the 35 years to 2016.

There is one more thing that makes the monsoon hard to live with. Like love, it submits to measurement only after you are drenched in it. It bites harder in a place that has learned to be afraid of it.

The Shape of the Trouble

Anyone who has seen a map of Kerala can guess why the water does so much damage. A thin strip tilted on its side, mountains along one edge, ocean along the other, a short steep drop in between. The rain falls on the high ridges and reaches the coast in four or five hours, faster where quarrying

MONSOON'S MANY MOODS (Clockwise from top) School children on a rainy day in Kerala; the landslide at Kalladi in Wayanad on July 7; rolling fields that receive the promise of rain

has straightened its path. The rivers that carry it are smaller than their reputation, streams that swell in July and empty as fast; what looks in December like a broad river is, in monsoon, a drainpipe at capacity.

Harish Vasudevan, an environmental lawyer in Kochi, lays out the arithmetic. Kerala takes around 3,000 mm of rain a year; to hold that much you would need a tank the size of the state, three metres deep. For a long time it had one: the paddy wetlands that filled in the monsoon and let the water sink back into the ground. Then rice stopped paying, and the fields, now idle money, were filled and sold. A 2008 law meant to stop it hasn’t. Every wetland lost to concrete is a section of the tank removed, and when it rains, the water, with nowhere to go, goes into people’s houses.

From Angry Calls to Anxious Queries

Rajeevan Erikkulam has watched the mood turn from close range. He works at the state disaster management authority, in a room with two screens where the rain becomes moving colour on a map. Custody of the monsoon used to sit with poets. It has now passed to the emergency desk.

His problem is that the rain has stopped behaving at a scale his instruments can see. It falls in patches, one village drenched and the next dry, and the old spread of stations is too coarse to catch it. At Kavalappara in 2019, no gauge was near enough to know what the cloud overhead was doing. What Rajeevan wants are automatic stations that can clock a cloudburst, 100mm in an hour, gone before anyone can write it down. The State has very few, even as more of its rain arrives in a short span. Rajeevan has a word for what the monsoon used to be: *aavesham*, a happy fever, the itch to run into the first big shower. He has other words for what it is now. Phobia. Therapy. Death.

He tells me about a man in Thrissur, 25 or so, out of work, whose house went under in 2018 and who never quite came back up with the water. He found the office line, then Rajeevan’s personal number, and called. When Rajeevan explained things gently, the man learned the words and threw them back, El Niño, sea-surface temperature, the vocabulary of someone who has read too much and slept too little.

He called at midnight to ask whether it would rain. He hunted down women who posted happily about the weather on Facebook and abused them, told anyone who wished for rain they would answer to him first. Blocked, he came back on a fresh SIM, a new account, an eleventh Facebook account after ten had been blocked. His family said he is an ordinary man; only the rain undoes him. His friends cannot see it in him at all. He may be the extreme, but Rajeevan’s phone stays busy on its own. A 28-year-old woman called about therapy for rain-related depression. Men building houses, and nearly everyone in Kerala is, call most of all: for a contractor, an unplanned wet day is money gone.

A woman once called to ask whether the weather would hold long enough to risk a sari at a wedding. Party men call before a rally, weighing open ground against a roof, because a rained-out *pandal* is a straightforward loss. Film units want the forecast by the hour, not the day. A man rang up to know if rain would reach a judge somewhere, ahead of an important ruling the next day.

Somewhere along the line the rains stopped being the backdrop to Malayali life and became a thing to interrogate, bargain with, dread, and turn into a weapon against someone like Jayakrishnan, who only ever wanted it with his beer, Johnson’s music and Clara.

The Rain Watchers

There is another way the fear comes out, quieter and more useful. In Vadasseri, central Kerala, a postman named Ananthakrishnan keeps a rain gauge and takes it more seriously than his health allows. He is a kidney patient, and travel is hard on him, but when it rains he is out in it, and can tell you where and how much fell, to the millimetre. If the weather office is wrong, he says so; if saying so changes nothing, he files a right-to-information request.

What Ananthakrishnan does alone, a stretch of central Kerala does together. Around the Meenachil, a group that began in the late 1980s, fighting a proposed check dam has become one of the odder and better weather operations in the country. Eby Immanuel, of the Meenachil River Protection Council, walked me through it.

» CONTINUED ON PAGE 4



DOWN IN JUNGLELAND

BY RANJIT LAL

AUTHOR, ENVIRONMENTALIST
AND BIRDWATCHER



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

HERE COMES THE RAIN
During monsoon, the raincoat yellow bullfrog turns colour as it serenades its beloved

Pour it Out

The monsoon has been late but then who in this country has ever been punctual?

THE RAINS have never fazed anyone in Mumbai. No matter how heavy and continuous the downpour, life went on. Back when we were students, if our car got stuck in water, we (in our pristine school uniforms) used to gleefully get out and push, arriving at school late, wet, muddy, bedraggled and gloriously happy.

Of course, days of nonstop deluge could (and still do) cause havoc on the Bombay locals, often forcing people to get down and walk along the flooded tracks. At night, studying by the light of a goose-neck lamp in the otherwise dark and vast veranda, I used to listen to the wind and the rain hammer at the large bamboo chicks making them slam back and forth like the sails of some ancient sailing warship.

One of the highpoints was, of course, our afternoon picnics at the lakes — Tulsi and Vihar — glimmering a dark cloud-silver in the verdant Borivali National Park. We would settle down adjoining a bustling little stream hurrying its way to the lake, and tuck into aloo-paranthas and aam-ka-achaar, admiring the giant bejewelled webs of the wood spiders that were strung across gaps in the foliage.

Earlier on, in Madras (Chennai), in the '60s, the largest garden in our complex would flood, turning into a vast lake or dangerous river like the Amazon or Brahmaputra. It had to be intrepidly crossed. Eyes peeled for piranha, I would sally forth, only to be brought up short by a raft of vicious red ants grimly floating straight for me; talk about getting ants in your pants. Ignominiously, I turned and fled. Occasionally, there would be the cyclones that struck the coast, churning up the Bay of Bengal and dumping sea fans, corals and cowries (and a seahorse skeleton) on the beach.

But, Delhi was such a let-down. That first year, in September, I remember asking someone, "So when do the monsoons break here?" I got a surprised look, "The monsoons — but they are over!"

"What? You mean that shower we had in July?"

"Yes. Good grief! What was worse, here if it rained for 15 minutes, life stopped. Help would not turn up, the electricity would trip, phones and TV stopped working. Once, on the Ridge, 200 raincoat yellow bullfrogs, while serenading their beloveds and kicking each other like stallions, piled over, nearly drowned their ladies. Of course, the Yamuna would flood from time to time, frothing, roaring and racing past but more due to deluges upstream than here. So, it was good, even if risky sometimes, to escape to the hills nearby: where ferns and epiphytes festooned the pines and deodars, mushrooms and toadstools glowed in the undergrowth. But here it could thunder down for days at a time.

Goa, in the rains, has been waxed eloquent about. Apart from the emerald paddy-fields, what struck me most forcefully was how enraged the sea became. Massive granite grey rollers would thunder and thump down on the beach. And when the monsoon retreats, it is time to look out for the dragonflies — glittering like multi-coloured biplanes.

This year, thanks to El-Nino, the monsoon has been late but then who in this country has ever been punctual?



STEPHEN ALTER

Stephen Alter on his book, The Fragrance of Rain: A Brief History of the Monsoon, unpredictable showers, checking for scorpions in his sneakers in Mussoorie and looking for nocturnal creatures in God's forests

Devyani Onial

LIKE IN most places, in Landour, an outpost of Mussoorie in Uttarakhand, the monsoon always arrived accompanied with its rituals. The morning one, says writer Stephen Alter, involved knocking the heels of his sneakers and shaking them vigorously to check no scorpions were lounging inside. Then as day would turn to night, a young Alter would don his gumboots, pick up an umbrella and go beetle collecting.

From then to now, a lot has changed in Landour and elsewhere but what remains unchanged is the unpredictability of the monsoon. "The inevitability of rain but also its unpredictable nature gives this season a special feeling of anticipation and suspense. Every year we wait expectantly for the monsoon to arrive but we're never quite sure... When will the rain start? Is it really here? Where has it gone? How long will it last? The monsoon is always full of surprises," he says. Alter's recent book, *The Fragrance of Rain: A Brief History of the Monsoon* (Aleph), captures the unpredictability as well as the cultural, literary and ecological landscape of one of the greatest shows on earth.

"*The Fragrance of Rain* refers not only to petrichor, the perfume of wet earth after the first rain shower, but also to other odours that accompany the monsoon — the sour-sweet scent of mouldering leaves; damp, clammy clothes that never dry completely or the aroma of monsoon flowers. More than anything, however, if I close my eyes, I can recognise the sound of rain as it begins to fall, from the first stray spattering of drops to the gathering rush of wind and then the torrential deluge that follows," he says.

For the book, Alter initially thought he would track the progress of the south-west monsoon like Alexander Frater did in his *Chasing the Monsoon*. "Though the book began as a journey and I flew to Kerala, hoping to see the first storms blowing in from the sea, soon enough I realised that the monsoon itself is a wayward traveller as the poet Kalidasa describes. Better to hang around at home and welcome its return," says Alter.

So he decided to focus on Mussoorie, the place he grew up in, and on Goa, where he now has a second home. Mussoorie is where Alter's American missionary grandparents and parents settled and Goa is where Alter and his wife decided to get a place a little over a decade ago to occasionally escape the Mussoorie cold. "We are climate migrants. Focusing on these two places gave me two contrasting landscapes and two contrasting parts of India," says Alter.

"What you see in Goa is the monsoon coming ashore and coming inland from the sea. It really feels like waves of rain pouring



RAIN CHECK

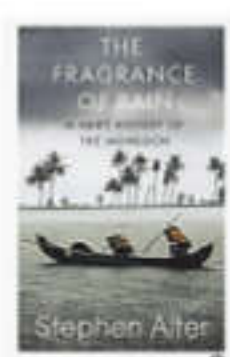
Places to visit in the monsoon

● Goa is wonderful in the monsoon, so long as you are prepared to get wet. There's a freshness to the saturated air and a feeling of unrestrained fertility, all the way from the coast up into the Western Ghats

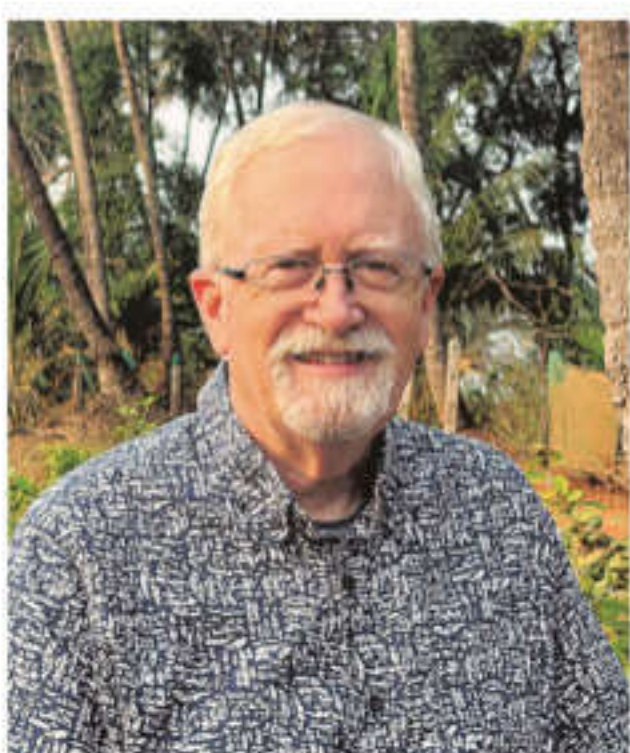
● Rajasthan, when the arid landscape comes alive. Jodhpur's Rao Jodha Desert Rock Park is spectacular in the monsoon as all sorts of indigenous species of plants sprout and bloom

in. The other thing in Goa is the trees and plant life are very tropical, especially when you go up to the Sahyadris and the Western Ghats, it's a rainforest basically. And that experience of being totally surrounded by tropical foliage and then all of the different creatures that emerge, the frogs and the snakes, so that experience is one thing. Landour and Mussoorie is also very wet and there are also all kinds of creeping crawling creatures but it's different species altogether. More than anything the most dramatic thing there, is the oak and the deodar trees with these epiphytic species that grow on the branches so the entire tree is covered in a fringe of green. It's also, of course, cooler up there. There are days even in the monsoon when you feel maybe I should light a fire. But the fundamental contrast is seeing the monsoon come ashore from the sea, and in Mussoorie seeing the monsoon strike

While the weather in some places never seem to change, it's the variations in climate that we experience in the mountains and on the coast that make life interesting



SMELLS LIKE RAIN
(Clockwise from right) Stephen Alter; his new book; monsoon lurks in Morjim, Goa; clouds hovering over Mussoorie, Uttarakhand



AMEETA ALTER

the Himalaya and the deluge that happens when the clouds come in contact with the mountains and the colder temperatures."

From presenting scientific accounts of the genesis of the monsoon to going back to Vedic mythology to documenting the journeys the voyagers from India and Arabia took riding the strong gales, Alter's canvas is wide.

His research into the monsoon yielded many interesting details. "One of the many facts I didn't know before researching this book is that climate scientists and paleobotanists have discovered a correlation between plankton blooms in the Arabian Sea and the intensity of the monsoon, all of which is linked to the water temperatures," says Alter, over the phone from Colorado in the US.

The role of the Himalaya in the annual cycle of the monsoon was another aspect that fascinated him. "Warming temperatures on the Tibetan Plateau generate powerful air currents that draw rafts of clouds thousands of kilometres across the seas and inland over the Indian subcontinent until they eventually collide with the mountains and release their moisture," he adds.



AKASH PATIL

THE ROMANCE AND RUIN OF RAIN
A rainy day in Mumbai's Marine Drive

But there was a wild excitement about the rain. We watched out for it, hoping for No School days. We splashed through puddles and watched mushrooms grow, white as milk, among the dark roots of the trees. Snails appeared. Trees fell. Moss crept up walls. The schoolrooms leaked and fungus drew maps along the cracks.

In adulthood, one's attitude changes. One knows that the city is rainfed, that the lake levels are low. But it always seems to rain in the wrong places and at the wrong times. Through the longueurs of mid-June to mid-September, we resent its commanding presence. It must be accounted for. Appointments must be made with the caveat: "...rain willing".

And each year, we know we will be failed

by the municipal authorities. I suspect sometimes that the flooding of the city is nature's revenge on us. The sea spits up thousands of kilos of plastic waste on the beaches of Mahim and the seafront at Marine Drive. The water accumulates and we watch as television cameras wade through the leptospiriosis-rich waters to get footage of a family whose old people are stranded on the top of beds, their homes reduced to stagnant pools.

The floods have their benchmark: 26 July 2005. Everyone in the city knows what they were doing and how they got home. I was working in Mahalaxmi and at around 3 pm, I decided that I would walk home. My boss then, Radhakrishnan Nair, thought this was stupid. We should simply sit it out in the office, sleep there, get home the next day. But

there is something about the notion of home that calls when *pralaya* seems imminent.

The late Pria Agni, artist extraordinaire whom we lost too young, also lived in Mahim so we decided we would walk together. Without even discussing it, we chose to use Tulsi Pipe Road. There was a moment of fear when we walked through Parel. I was at five ten waist-deep, Pria shoulder-deep. We met a young woman who looked close to panic and held her between us until we got to knee-deep water. She decided to try her luck with the trains at Dadar though we didn't think this a great idea.

Mahim was fine. There were no floods. It was business as usual and the elderly folk who had not stirred out were surprised at our stories. Our great big sponge, Shivaji Park, was doing its work. My sister, who worked then at Kalina in the University Library, walked home too and at one point, made her way through the flood water with another woman, holding hands, clinging to the wall by the bridge on the side of the Mithi River. All the seven goddesses of Mumbai — Mum-badevi, Kalbadevi, Prabhadevi, Sheetaladevi, Mahalaxmi, Gaondevi, Mother Mary — were working overtime that day.

We have obviously learned nothing. We are cutting down our mangroves. More and more of Shivaji Park is being covered by concrete. We are still throwing away as much plastic as suits us.

The rain bides its time. It has some more lessons for us.

Jerry Pinto is an author and translator based in Mumbai

The rain bides its time

Perhaps the flooding of the city is nature's revenge on us. In Mumbai, the sea spits up thousands of kilos of plastic waste on the seafront at Marine Drive. Water accumulates and we watch

Jerry Pinto

IT WAS 1980, my friend Mehli Gobhai, the painter, was to have his first group show at the Bronx Museum of the Arts in New York, curated by Madeleine Burnside and Jeanette Ingberman. He wanted to be there, of course, but he also was reluctant to miss what he called the melodrama of the monsoon, the grey clouds piling up over the horizon and then sweeping imperiously into the city, changing everything from gold and grit to grey and moss.

"I kept changing my ticket," he told me. "And my mother kept warning me. I replied: 'Well, if billionaires can beat jet lag and time zones and sign multimillion dollar deals, I can turn up on the day of the opening.'"

Only the monsoon decided otherwise. His flight to New York was delayed. It landed at Istanbul and so he spent 24 hours there

with the result that he did not even have time to shave and had to take a taxi straight to the show from JFK airport. And when he walked into the show, he did not present the suave façade he had imagined. He let out a horrified squawk.

"It's upside down!" he shouted.

The monsoon is the city's wild card. Through the heat of the summer, we long for it. When it arrives, everything must change. Clothes must be decided according to it. Umbrellas must be fished out and dusted off. Rainwear must be purchased. My father said June was the month that stretched his budgetary capacities the most: both his children had to be kitted out for school: new books, new uniforms, 'rainy shoes' as we called them, and Duckback raincoats which had their own peculiar smell when they lay, unused over your arm, as you plodded along to school.

After years of being a dancer and hosting television shows, Raghav Juyal talks about consistently reinventing himself as an actor, making people laugh and his ambition of being a superstar

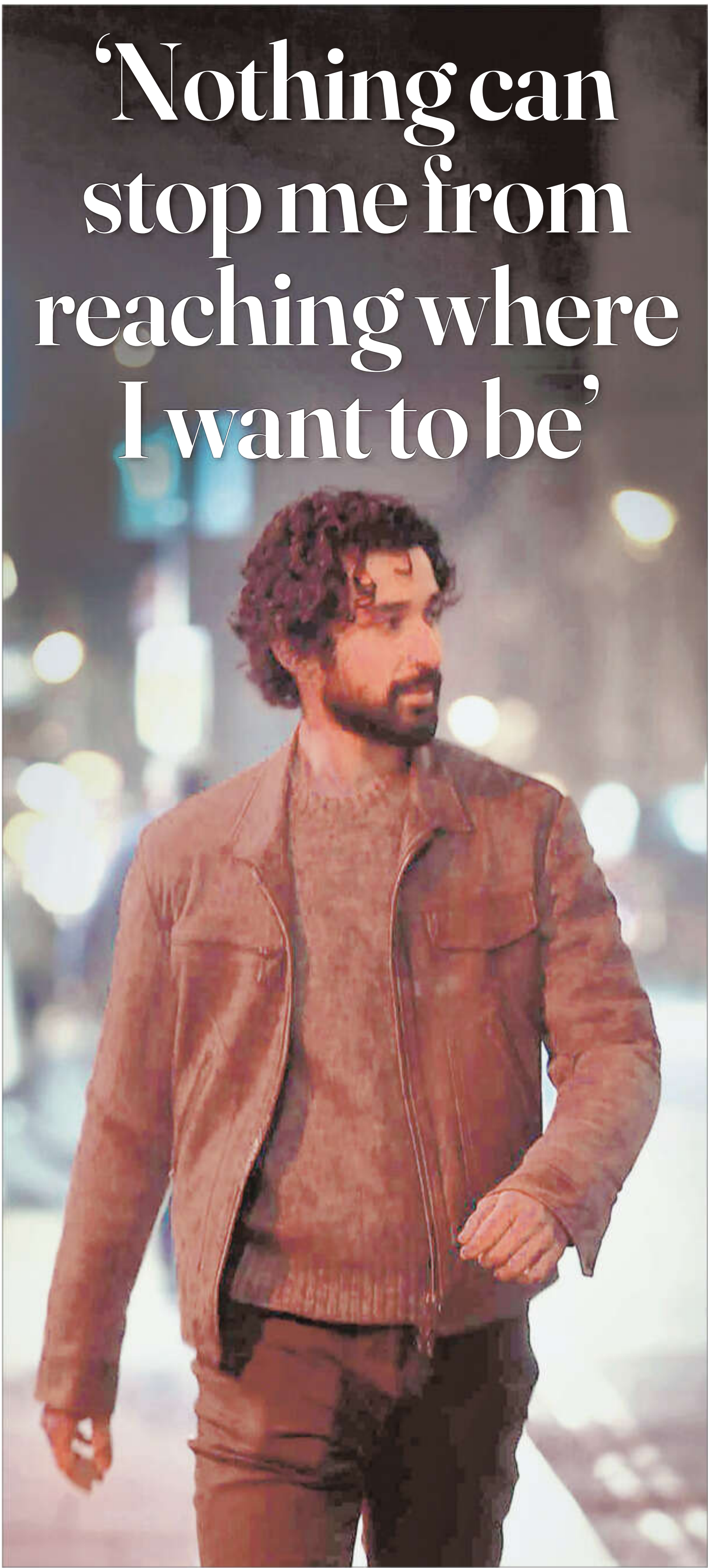
Alaka Sahani

FOR RAGHAV Juyal, his new film, *Bhai Tera Star Hai*, is not just another release. This is his first film as the leading man — a milestone that has been in the making for over a decade-and-a-half. “I am excited about the new movie. So are my parents, who live in Dehradun. They are very proud. I have been a background dancer, reality show contestant, host, choreographer, supporting actor — and now, finally, a protagonist in an entertaining Bollywood feature film,” he says.



“People today are under so much stress. Earlier, we had so many comedy films led by Govinda and others. There’s a gap today. I want audiences to watch this film, have a good time and leave with a hearty laugh”

Juyal’s journey to this point has been anything but linear. He stepped into showbiz as a contestant on the dance reality show, *Dance India Dance 3* (2011). In recent years, he has garnered wider recognition with his performance as a hot-headed goon in the action thriller *Kill* (2023), and as the much loved Parvaiz in the Netflix series, *The Ba**ds of Bollywood* (2025). The number of acting offers increased dramatically after *Kill*’s release. “I received 751 scripts after that film. Out of them, I chose *Bhai Tera Star Hai* as well as those in the pipeline, including *The Paradise*, *King* and *Ramayana*,” he shares. After Aryan Khan’s *The Ba**ds of Bollywood* gave a major boost to his career, he decided to advance the release of *Bhai Tera*



Star Hai, a comedy directed by Vivek B Agrawal, to July 30. “People today are under so much stress. I want to make them happy,” says Juyal, adding, “Earlier, we had so many comedy films led by Govinda and others. There’s a gap today. I want audiences to watch this film, have a good time and leave with a hearty laugh.”

ONWARDS AND UPWARDS
A still from *Bhai Tera Star Hai*

While many actors gravitate towards more intense roles as their careers progress, Juyal sees comedy as a tougher genre. “Making people laugh is a different challenge. It’s something I enjoy and want to explore,” he says. Although streaming platforms have given him visibility, his focus now is on theatrical releases. “I have

The number of offers increased dramatically after *Kill*, as many as 751 scripts. Out of them, Juyal chose *Bhai Tera Star Hai*. Other projects include *The Paradise*, *King* and *Ramayana*

acted in several series. Now, I want to concentrate on films made for the big screen. I’m choosing scripts carefully. Good writing is important,” says Juyal, who has been part of web-series *Abhay 2* (2020) and *Gyaarah Gyaarah* (2024).

For him, his biggest achievement has been to remain relevant in the entertainment world for 15 years. “That has only been possible because I kept reinventing myself and pushed the envelope,” says the actor. It has also helped him savour his journey as a dancer-turned-actor. “Movement” continues to define the way he approaches life and work. “I can’t lead a monotonous life. Nothing in nature stands still — not the earth, the wind or rivers. Nature itself teaches you to keep evolving,” adds Juyal, who was also part of films such as *Street Dancer 3D* (2020), *Kisi Ka Bhai Kisi Ki Jaan* (2023) and *Yudhra* (2024).

The biggest hurdle though, for Juyal, was overcoming the industry’s perception of him. “When you come from television, it is difficult to get rid of certain perceptions. You audition for big projects, sometimes reach the final stage and still don’t get the role. But that’s part of the game. I don’t want to complain,” says Juyal, whose father is an advocate and mother is a teacher.

Juyal became serious about transitioning into acting after playing a supporting role in *Nawabzaade* (2018). By then, he had established himself as a popular television personality after choreographing for *Dance India Dance Li’l Masters 2* (2012); hosting *Dance Plus* (2015, 2016, 2017); and competing on *Fear Factor: Khatron Ke Khiladi 7* (2016), among others. “My performance in *Nawabzaade* was not anything special. So, I took a break and trained under actor and coach Saurabh Sachdeva for five years while continuing to audition,” he recalls. “Then, I got *Kill*.”

Despite his growing success, Juyal insists he is still “a Dehradun boy” with big dreams. “I want to be a superstar.” Juyal believes his “authenticity” would lead him to superstardom. “Nothing can stop me from reaching where I want to be. But I have to remain true to myself,” says the actor, who believes good performances come from strong collaborations.

“My co-stars are important. In fact, I want them to be better than me. That would inspire me to do better. Lakshya (his co-actor in *Kill*, *The Bads*...) is a good friend. It’s also important to jam with directors, experiment together and learn from their wisdom,” says Juyal, who was asked by Shah Rukh Khan to join *King*’s cast after the success of his Netflix series.

He considers the Badshah of Bollywood his “mentor”, and sought his advice for *Bhai Tera Star Hai*’s release and got the assurance that “your work will speak for you.”

Even though acting remains Juyal’s singular focus, whenever his schedule allows, the actor returns to his ancestral village Khetu and mountains in Uttarakhand. “I manage to visit only a couple of times now but my friends back home are the same. They don’t treat me differently because I am an actor,” he says. Camping under open skies remains one of his favourite escapes. “Those moments make me feel alive.”



A HOLISTIC APPROACH
Actor Rima Kallingal playing the chenda

A New Beat

Rima Kallingal on her chenda arangetram and how it changed her life

Anusree KC

ACTOR RIMA Kallingal has spent most of 42-year-old life on stage. While she made her acting debut at 25, she started dancing as early as when she was three. But, her most recent on-stage outing, earlier this month, looked different than any other.

As she stood on the stage at the Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi in Thrissur, she was not waiting for the musical cue to begin a dance performance. Instead, she stood with the chenda — a cylindrical percussion instrument native to south India — suspended from her neck, her right hand grabbing the chenda *kol* (the stick) and her left hand beating the drum to the rhythm of the *panchhari melam* (a traditional percussion ensemble and temple orchestra from Kerala). It was Kallingal’s *arangetram* (formal debut) in the traditional art of chenda *melam*. She performed alongside fellow debutants at Mamangam Dance Academy — which she founded 12 years ago — all trained by their guru, the renowned percussionist Vivek Kanimangalam.

Kallingal is best known for her strong, unconventional performances in Malayalam films such as *Virus* (2019), *Theatre: The Myth of Reality* (2025), *City of God* (2011), *Rani Padmini* (2015) and *22 Female Kottayam* (2012), which won her the Kerala State Film Award and the Filmfare Award for Best Actress. She decided to learn the chenda only earlier this year, to lead her dance company’s upcoming production, *Vattam*. Conceived by percussionist and choreographer Santosh Madhav, who has been with Mamangam since its inception, the production borrows its title from the chenda’s *vattam* or the circular drumheads. “*Melam*,” Kallingal explains, “connects to the circle of life, where everybody needs to be together to complete the circle and nobody gets left behind.” Combining Indian contemporary dance and chenda *melam*, the production is set to premiere in Moscow on July 21.

“The original plan was to learn just enough chenda to perform one choreography. But once we started training, we wanted to learn it in-depth. We put in two extra hours daily for the chenda, after eight hours of dance rehearsals,” says Kallingal, who compares their exhaustive research on the instrument to the physical toll of playing it — calluses, and sore shoulders from the weight of the drum.

To further their understanding of the instrument, the team went looking for the source of its sound. They travelled across Thrissur, first to Vellarakkad, where the chenda is produced from the core of jackfruit trees, and then to Peruvanam, the birthplace of *pandi melam* (the classical chenda concert). There, they also met percussion legend Peruvanam Kuttan Marar, who enriched their knowledge further. “I have always believed local is international. I want to explore and go deep into my roots and present it in a contemporary space, where the kids of today look at our culture and say, ‘Wow, this is so cool,’” says the artiste who is also trained in taekwondo, chhau (a semi-classical dance form from eastern India) and kalaripayattu (a 3,000-year-old martial art indigenous to Kerala).

The multi-facetedness of chenda mirrors Kallingal’s public personality. She is an award-winning actor and dancer. She is also the co-founder of the Women in Cinema Collective in 2017 that advocates safer, fairer working conditions in the Malayalam film industry. “We are all in the middle of a lot of stuff in our life — work, family problems. But I wish this for everybody — to open your heart and mind to a new art form, craft, sport. It will change your life.”

What the River Says

From Kabir to Shiv Kumar Batalvi, Surjit Singh Patar and Pash, poetry runs through the fabric of Honey Trehan’s *Satluj* that tells the story of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khrala

Suanshu Khurana

HANERA NA soche ki chaanan dar gaya hai/ Raat na soche ki suraj margyahi/ Baal jyotaan zindagi de maan mattiyan/ Uth jagaa de mombattiyaan

(Let the darkness never believe that the moon is scared/ The night should never think the sun has died/ Light up the flame to honour life/ Get up and light the candles).

Moments before Jaswant Singh Khrala (played by Diljit Dosanjh), in Honey Trehan’s *Satluj*, is shot dead and dumped into the Har-ike wetland, the human rights activist investigating extrajudicial killings and disappearances during Punjab’s insurgency, shares a conversation in his jail cell with Kuljeet Singh — a character based on real-life Special Police Officer (SPO) Kuldeep Singh. Uncomfortable with the torture Khrala was subjected to, Singh would secretly give him food while keeping watch.

In the film, Kuljeet urges Khrala to abandon his fight, and that the police would let him return home if he just agreed. It is then that the battered Khrala responds with the sun-and-candle analogy in prose, drawing

unmistakably from Surjit Singh Patar’s celebrated poem, *Jaga de Mombattiyaan*. Trehan acknowledges Patar in the film’s opening credits, connecting Khrala’s unwavering decision to not abandon those killed in custody but still labelled *lawaaaris laashaan* (unclaimed corpses) to Patar’s poetic response to the dark times some years later.

In fact, throughout the film, verses by some of Punjab’s significant, revolutionary poets are recurring motifs. *Satluj* also draws on *gurbani*, one of the elements that Trehan was asked to remove by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC).

In the film, the director has used poetry as a narrative device right from the first scene, creating a disarming normalcy with a bunch of cops in a moving jeep, drinking and singing. One of them sings noted poet Shiv Kumar Batalvi’s *Gamna di raat lammi ae, Ja mere geet lamme ne/ Na bhairi raat mukdi ae, Na mere geet mukdene* (Either this night of sorrow is long/ Or my songs are never-ending. This dreadful night does not end/ Nor do my songs finish). It is being sung by the policemen discussing a colleague’s upcoming wedding. Minutes later, they kill



AN ARCHIVE INVERSE
(From left) Shiv Kumar Batalvi; Surjit Singh Patar; a still from *Satluj*



a few young men without an arrest warrant or a court trial and dump them in the flowing canal. The lines that were once a meditation on Batalvi’s personal grief becomes a reflection on Punjab’s long night, implying years of never-ending fear and violence. Batalvi, also known as Punjab’s Keats and *Birha da Sultan* (The Emperor of Longing) is also thanked in the film credits.

In *Satluj*, Trehan places his portrait along with that of Punjabi poet Avtar Singh Sandhu, better known as Pash, in the library where Khrala’s wife Pammi works. Pash, the revolutionary Punjabi poet, was assassinated by militants at 37 for writing anti-establishment poetry. The poetry and the poet references woven in the film is the filmmaker telling us that poetry preserved what the State didn’t, how poets, through their writing, were witnesses and archivists of the time.

In fact, Pash, behind the famed poem *Sab Ton Khatarnak* (The Most Dangerous) was from Talwandi Salem in Punjab’s Doaba, where the Sutlej flows past the re-



gion’s western and southern edges. He often wrote of the river. *Addhi raat vich/ Meri kambni satt rajaiyan vich vi na ruki/ Sutlej mere bistar te utar aaya/ Satton rajaiyan gillliyan/ Bukhar ikk sau chhe, ikk sau satt/ Yug nu paltan vich lagge lok bukhar naal nahin marde* (In the middle of the night, my shivering didn’t stop even with seven quilts/ The Sutlej came down onto my bed/ All seven quilts are soaked/ Fever is one hundred six, one hundred seven/ People trying to overturn an era do not die of a simple fever). While not used as a direct verse, it is entwined in Khrala’s struggle as part of the longer journey of resistance. When a drenched Khrala appears before Kuljeet in the film’s only dream sequence, long after his death, shivering from the cold and speaking of his pain, the moment becomes a haunting echo of Pash’s poem.

Trehan also brings in Kabir’s *Sir dije kaan na kije* (Give me your head, and do not pay any attention to public opinion), included in Guru Granth Sahab, when Khrala

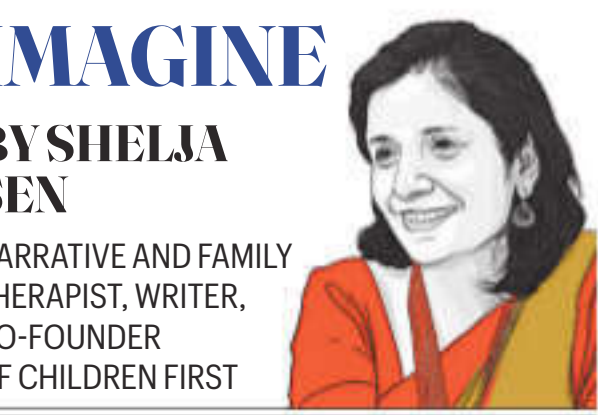
is brutally beaten in police custody. The poignant shabad transforms the scene from one of physical torture into one of one man’s resolve.

The film also shares a fascinating cross-reference space with Gulzar’s *Maachis*, one of Indian cinema’s defining explorations of militancy in Punjab. Jimmy, the dog, finds its way into both films, as do actors Kanwaljit Singh and SM Zaheer, who portrayed the morally compromised police officers Khurana and Vohra in *Maachis* (1996). A character was also called Jaswant Singh then.

While the poetry in *Satluj* does bring cultural gravitas to the film, what it really does is tell us how these verses in Punjab have been repositories of grief. Like documents of the time, this literature was what stood witness to Punjab’s darkest times. Trehan has tried to tie this literary conscience with that of Khrala’s in an attempt to never forget what happened to Punjab, in turn peeling off that cheerful facade of mustard fields, folk music, bhangra and prosperity.

The Architecture of Belonging

Why third spaces matter



IMAGINE
BY SHELIA SEN
NARRATIVE AND FAMILY THERAPIST, WRITER, CO-FOUNDER OF CHILDREN FIRST

I DO not have any friends in school. Nobody likes me,” says five-year-old Kabir with a matter-of-fact shrug of his shoulders. He continues making his “wildlife sanctuary” with all the animal models in my room. The only hint of pain I see is in the way his eyes dart at me and then back at his animals. I want to give him a hug but I have learned that witnessing pain with my presence is more important than any quick fixes. I observe that all the animals are in pairs or in little groups. I wonder aloud, “Kabir, what are you making?” He says, “I am designing a place where everybody has a friend. Nobody feels that ‘nobody likes me.’” As I watch him place each animal with care, I sigh and wonder at the painful drama of unbelonging and exclusion.

In our organisation, we work with children and young people up to the age of 25. A recurring theme is “loneliness”, “not belonging”, “feeling left out”, “isolation” or “feeling invisible” across the ages. A young man in high school confides, “I feel like a ghost in my school. Everyone looks through me.” A young woman from a small town, who started college in a big city, admits, “There are days I go without speaking to anyone. As if I do not exist.” Behind these words, I hear the echo of little Kabir, “Nobody likes me.”

Sahej, a high-schooler, talked about a school presentation where a speaker warned the students about how a “global loneliness epidemic could kill us, as it is equivalent to smoking 15 cigarettes and can cause cardiovascular diseases, dementia and stroke.” Then, he laughed hollowly and added, “He told us how we should all have friends. As if we do not know that.” What made it even

worse was that after the talk, many of his classmates started ribbing him, “Dude, you are going to die an early death.” A presentation intended to raise awareness had simply found another way to shame those already feeling excluded. The cultural discourse around the “loneliness epidemic” is becoming about “why can’t you just go out and make some friends?” We are looking for an individualistic remedy to a cultural problem. The person is not the problem, the problem is the problem, and the problem is largely social. So the solution has to be social too.*

But even loneliness isn’t distributed evenly. It impacts young people with varying degrees of ferocity depending on where they are placed in the status hierarchy. Their class, caste, religion, gender, looks, sexuality and grades become their social currency. It becomes even more complex when the child has a visible or invisible disability. This is amplified to another level when social media demands performativity, where likeability is policed, ranked and judged.

Nysa, from middle-school, made an interesting observation: “When you were in school, if you had a fight with a friend, chances are that you would have it sorted out by lunch break the next day.” She pointed out how much the “social drama” has changed drastically. If there is a fight now, most of which happens on WhatsApp or Instagram, within an hour, the screenshots are posted as stories and “battle lines are drawn.” What might have started as a seemingly innocuous squabble can get the person (whoever inhabits the “lower rung” on the status ladder) banished and cast out as a social reject. Ouch! The irony of our times is that despite being the most connected, we are so disconnected. Digital platforms have compressed the time between conflict and banishment. What once took days now unfolds in minutes, with spectators, screenshots and algorithms amplifying humiliation and outrage.

Loneliness is a shape-shifter and can show up across ages in various guises like anxiety, depression, addiction and so on. Kabir’s parents were at wit’s end to see their child look so burdened and miserable.



GETTYIMAGES

WORK AS PLAY
When the problem is social, the solution must be social too

Sahej had started wondering if anyone would even miss him if he died. Nysa had taken to cutting herself to numb the pain of social exile.

The cost of loneliness for our children is obvious. We have to be curious about what the architecture of belonging looks like. Every time a child tells me that they like their school, I am curious to know why. They tell me various versions of the same answer: “Because I get to meet my friends” or “The teachers are kind”. They might then tell me about “also” the subjects they like or sports they play or the art class that is fun. It makes sense, right? Learning is inevitable when a child feels safe, seen and secure. Before children become curious, confident or creative learners, they need a place where they feel welcome. Schools are spaces where our sense of who we are, what we value and our identity start to take shape. After all, as Desmond Tutu reminded us, “People are people through other people.”

Schools can be hubs of social change. But they cannot carry the responsibility of belonging alone. A young woman introduced me to the idea of third spaces as “a social space which is beyond home, school, college or work.” I immediately fell in love with the idea as it reminded me of my childhood when, after school, my friends and I would gather on a neighbourhood hill every day. We would climb trees, tumble down, sing, dance and invent new games every day. What delights me is how young people are finding innovative ways to come together through music,

arts, acting, sports, knitting, crocheting, book clubs, dance groups, protests and so much more. It takes a child to raise the village.

Imagine if schools, colleges, museums, bookshops, galleries, parks, animal shelters and libraries could host evening or weekend third spaces where children of all ages could gather to co-create inclusive spaces. The ethics of the third spaces are about creating inclusivity, acceptance and belonging. I would go even one step further and suggest that the future of mental health is not in the clinics but in the architecture of these third spaces.

When adults speak about loneliness, we often like to blare out alarming statistics, diagnoses and clinical interventions. Kabir reached for a handful of toy animals. Without knowing the language of public health, he understood something profound — belonging is not a given. Communities of care and concern are something we have to build intentionally. We can all be architects of “designing a place where everybody has a friend.” Where no child has to come to the conclusion, “Nobody likes me.”

Synonyms and composite stories have been used to maintain confidentiality.

**Acknowledgement to my friend and fellow narrative practitioner, David Denborough.*

In this column, Shelia Sen curates the knowhow of the children and youth she has the honour of working with. Email her at shelia.sen@childrenfirstindia.com

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What the Rain Became

THEIR INSTRUMENT is homemade and cheap: a PVC pipe-like tube with its bottom sealed, standing open-mouthed on a stool or a cleared corner of the *muttam* (courtyard), somewhere the sky can reach it with no tree in the way, a measuring cup beside it. Every morning at 8.30, and through the night when it is heavy, people read the cup and send the figure to a WhatsApp group, now an app, each reading pinned to a location. Schoolchildren and seniors over 70 do much of the reading.

It spread the way these things do. Six school kids, fired up by Greta Thunberg, painted a measuring scale on the wall of their house after the 2018 floods, and the idea caught on. Painted scales now climb bridge piers and gateposts up and down the valley, so anyone crossing can read how far the river has risen. Some volunteers have been at it so long, they can call the rainfall from the sound of it on the roof, and be right before they check the cup.

Being right, they have learned, is not the same as being heard. When the readings warned of a punishing night over a packed colony at Koshamattam, 100 people in 100 square feet, the residents did not believe it and would not move. Only after the police were pushed did anyone leave. The water reached their necks that night.

Which is roughly why Lakshmikutty Amma measures her cup. She is 73, retired from government service, and for three years has read a gauge a neighbour handed her when he left to live with his children abroad. Most mornings, around 8.30, she checks the last day’s rain and feeds the number into the app, which defeated her at first; she had used a computer only for her pension, and her children had to teach her.

She has watched water her whole life. She was a girl during the flood that took her cat, when a snake came into the house on the rising water and she watched her mother try to kill it. She had the same feeling in 2018, the family camped on the upper floor for days, the television carried up out of reach, the new car drowned below. Ask her why she keeps at it, an old woman with a stubborn app and a plastic cup, and she laughs and says she is retired, there is nothing else to do, and “if it helps the neighbours, so much the better.”

She leaves out the rest: that the cup is a watch kept over something none of them can stop, only see coming. English-language reporting likes to write that the monsoon “hits” Kerala, as if it were a fist. In Malayalam, it is gentler. It is *varunnu*. It arrives, the way a guest arrives, or a letter, or a season you were waiting for.

The Zamorin was right that no one could carry the monsoon off. He did not think it would move into the house and turn on the family. Lakshmikutty Amma keeps the cup where the rain can always find it, mouth open to the sky, the way you keep an eye on a guest who has hurt this house before.



Neil Patil
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TWO years ago, my daughter Raya took her first international trip. We chose something off-beat. We went to Georgia. Not the American state. The country. The one wedged between Europe and Asia, on the edge of the Caucasus mountains, that most Indian travellers haven’t seriously considered visiting yet. And I can tell you now, looking back, that it was exactly the right call. Not just as a trip, but as a first introduction to what the world outside India can feel like.

We did Tbilisi, Kakheti, and Kazbegi. Ten days that rearranged something in my head about where the most interesting travel experiences actually live. Because here’s the thing I keep coming back to: the two oldest wine-producing civilisations on earth are not in France. They are not in Italy. They are in Georgia and its neighbour Armenia. Two nations that were making wine when the pharaohs were still building pyramids, that adopted Christianity before the Roman Empire did, and that have a food and hospitality culture so elaborate it would make an Indian wedding caterer nod in recognition, well almost.

I have done one half of the Caucasus. Armenia is still on my list. But between what I have seen and what I have read, I’m convinced that this is a very interesting corner of the world travel map that you shouldn’t continue to ignore. Let me tell you why.

Georgia: Where the Feast Is the Point
I need to start with the supra, because nothing prepares you for it. A supra is a traditional Georgian feast, and once you have been to one, you understand the country. There’s a designated toastmaster called a tamada who leads the table through a series of elaborate toasts. To family, ancestors, friendship, the land, and the guests. The food doesn’t stop. Khachapuri, a cheese-filled bread so central to Georgian life that the national statistics office literally tracks its price the way we track the consumer price index. Khinkali, soup dumplings with a

They Beat The French

built-in drinking ritual: hold the top knot, bite a small hole, sip the broth, eat the dumpling, leave the knot on your plate so everyone can count how many you’ve had. Walnut-paste salads, grilled meats, churchkhela which is a walnut-and-grape candy that looks like a candle and tastes like nothing you’ve eaten before. And through all of it, wine.

Georgia has been making wine for 8,000 years. That’s not a rounded number for effect. Archaeological evidence dates Georgian winemaking to 6000 BC, making it the oldest continuous wine culture on the planet. The traditional method uses qvevri: large clay vessels buried underground, where grape juice ferments with the skins and seeds still in it. The result is amber wine, a category that barely exists outside the Caucasus. UNESCO now protects the method as an Intangible Cultural Heritage. Georgia has over 430 indigenous grape varieties, more than almost any country on earth.

We spent a few days in Kakheti, Georgia’s wine country, and this is where the numbers become personal. Almost every household in the region makes its own wine. You visit a family, and within minutes you are in their cellar, tasting from qvevri their grandfather buried. The wine isn’t for sale. It’s for you, because you showed up, and in Georgia, a guest is considered a gift from God. That’s not a tourism slogan. It’s a proverb they actually live by.

Tbilisi is a city that feels like it couldn’t decide between Europe and Asia, so it chose both. Sulphur baths from the Persian era sit next to crumbling Art Nouveau balconies from the Russian period. A 4th-century fortress overlooks a skyline of glass-and-steel modernity. The old town is a maze of narrow lanes where wine bars serve natural wines alongside cheese so fresh it squeaks.

And then, Kazbegi. The drive up the Georgian Military Highway, through the Greater Caucasus, is one of the most spectacular road journeys I have done anywhere. And at the end of it, the Gergeti Trinity Church, perched on a hilltop at over 2,000 metres with Mount Kazbek’s 5,054-metre glacier behind it. Raya and I stood there, not saying much, because there wasn’t much to say. Some views just close your mouth for you.

Armenia: The Country I Haven’t Been To Yet

And now, the other half. The half I haven’t seen but can’t stop reading about. Armenia was the first country in the world to adopt Christianity as its state



religion, in 301 AD. Thirty years before Georgia and a full decade before the Roman Emperor Constantine converted. Yerevan, the capital, was founded in 782 BC, which makes it older than Rome by 29 years. The entire landscape is scattered with monasteries and churches that predate most of European civilisation.

And some of them sound extraordinary. Geghard Monastery is partially carved directly into a cliff face, with chambers hollowed from the rock where monks lived and prayed in near-total darkness. The acoustics inside are reportedly so precise that a single voice can fill the entire space. The Wings of Tatev, the world’s longest reversible cable car, carries you 5.7 kilometres across the Vorotan Gorge to reach Tatev Monastery, which has been sitting on the edge of a canyon since the 9th century. Khor Virap, a monastery at the foot of Mount Ararat, gives you what might be the most iconic view in the entire Caucasus: the monastery in the foreground, the sacred mountain rising behind it, and the uncomfortable knowledge that Ararat, Armenia’s holiest symbol, actually sits across the border in Turkey.

The food, from everything I have read and heard, is extraordinary in a different register from Georgia. Where Georgia is cheese and wine, Armenia is smoke and stone fruit. Khorovats, the Armenian barbecue, is a national obsession: marinated meat grilled over grapevine coals, the smoke carrying a fragrance that doesn’t exist anywhere else. Lavash, the

traditional flatbread baked by slapping dough against the walls of a clay tonir oven, is so culturally significant that UNESCO gave it intangible heritage status. Dolma, ghapama (a stuffed pumpkin served at celebrations), and a cuisine built on herbs, walnuts, pomegranate molasses, and dried apricots. And then there’s the brandy.

Armenia makes what might be the most underappreciated spirit in the world. Ararat brandy has been produced since 1877, and there’s a story about it that I can’t get out of my head. At the Yalta Conference in 1945, where Churchill, Roosevelt, and Stalin were carving up the post-war world, Stalin poured Churchill a glass of Ararat Dvin after dinner. Churchill was reportedly so taken with it that he had cases shipped to him for years afterwards. The legend says the quality dipped at one point, Churchill complained to Stalin, and Stalin discovered that the brandy master responsible had been exiled to Siberia. The man was brought back. Whether every detail is accurate or slightly embroidered over the decades, the spirit itself is real, it’s remarkable, and you can visit the distillery in Yerevan and taste expressions aged up to 70 years.

That’s the kind of thing that makes Armenia pull at you. Every fact leads to another fact, every story opens a door to a deeper one.

Two Countries, One Story

Here’s what makes Georgia and Armenia work so well together, and

why I’d tell any Indian traveller to visit them as a pair.

They are the two oldest Christian nations on earth, and yet their versions of Christianity are different. Georgia is Orthodox, Armenia is Apostolic, following its own ancient path. The churches look different, the rituals feel different, and the role religion plays in daily life has a different texture in each country. Having seen the Georgian side, I know the Armenian side will land differently because I’ll have something to measure it against.

They both claim to have invented wine, and both have the archaeology to back it up. Georgia points to 8,000-year-old grape residue in clay vessels. Armenia points to the Areni-1 cave, where a 6,100-year-old winery was discovered, complete with a wine press, fermentation vats, and storage jars. I have done the Kakheti wine region. The Areni valley is next.

They are both small and compact. Georgia is roughly the size of Ireland. Armenia is smaller than Belgium. You can see the highlights of both in ten to twelve days without feeling rushed. They are affordable in a way that Western Europe has forgotten how to be. A full Georgian meal with wine for two can cost less than a single entree in Paris. Armenia is even more accessible. And here’s what, as an Indian traveller, I keep coming back to: the hospitality. In both countries, hosting a guest isn’t a commercial transaction. It’s a point of honour. The Georgian supra, where the tamada toasts to your health, your family, and your ancestors, felt remarkably similar to the way an Indian family welcomes someone into their home. The Armenian insistence on feeding you until you physically cannot eat any more will be familiar to anyone who has ever visited any Indian household. There is a warmth in the Caucasus that goes beyond politeness. It’s cultural. It’s structural. And for Indian travellers who have grown used to being treated as tourists first and guests second, this region is a reminder that not every part of the world has forgotten the difference.

What Stays With You

I’ll end with this. There are places you visit for the photographs, and there are places you visit for the feeling. Georgia was a feeling place. The taste of amber wine from a clay vessel in a family cellar in Kakheti. The echo of wind at Gergeti, 2,000 metres up, with Raya standing

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next to me, quiet for once. The supra that started at eight and ended at midnight, with the tamada’s final toast still ringing in my ears.

Armenia, I suspect, will be the same. The hymn in a rock-cut monastery. Mount Ararat at sunrise, impossibly large, impossibly close, impossibly not yours. A glass of brandy with a century of history in it.

I have seen one half. The other half is waiting. And these are places that know how to wait, they have been here for 8,000 years.

Know the Unknown

Ever since we launched flight bookings on Veena World, I have been disappearing down rabbit holes about flight routes, airport quirks, and things you can only see from 35,000 feet. This week’s find genuinely surprised me.

Most people spend lakhs standing in a field at minus fifteen degrees hoping the Northern Lights show up. Here’s what nobody tells you, you can see them from your airplane seat. Los Angeles to Helsinki, New York to Reykjavik, Tokyo to London. These flights cross the aurora zone at night, at 35,000 feet, above the clouds, above the light pollution. Passengers describe it as flying through a curtain of green and purple while the cabin sleeps.

And right now is the moment. The sun just hit one of its strongest peaks in decades, making this the best aurora window in eleven years. It closes in 2027. North-facing window seat. Lights off. September to March. So what’s your pick to see the Northern Lights? From the ground or from 35,000 feet? See you next week....

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